

Psych 310 Personality and Its Transformations

Course transcript with numbered paragraphs

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Highlighting key

key vocabulary terms and concepts distinctive to this course

key figures thinkers, characters, and figures central to the lectures

Paragraphs are numbered lecture.paragraph (e.g. 3.12 is the twelfth paragraph of Lecture 3). Each lecture opens with an "At a glance" overview, which is not part of the transcript.

1. Bridging Psychology's Foundations

AT A GLANCE

Sets out the course's premise: personality is both a state and a transformative process, and the religious, psychoanalytic, humanist, existential, Piagetian, biological, and psychometric traditions describe that process at different levels of one hierarchy. Previews all seven domains, then turns to Eliade's account of shamanism as the most archaic model of transformation: descent into the underworld and reconstitution. Links this to anxiety and entropy (Friston), the metaphor of up and down, the breakdown of a frame of reference, and the three routes to the shamanic vocation: spontaneous vocation, hereditary transmission, and personal quest.

- 1.1 So why **personality and its transformations**? Well, because people are something, and they're also becoming something. And so if you want to understand personality, you have to understand it as a state and as a **transformative process**. And of those two, probably the **transformative process** is most relevant because the **transformative process** is essentially equivalent to consciousness. And there's nothing that's more emblematic of what a human being is than the process of consciousness. So **personality and its transformations**. State and process.
- 1.2 Why a clinical introduction? Well, some people who teach personality are also social psychologists and a smaller minority are clinical psychologists. And I'm a clinical psychologist. And so I got interested in personality through clinical psychology rather than the reverse. So I'm interested in understanding personality as it pertains to mental health or even flourishing, you might say, as opposed to psychopathology and the hell that accompanies mental illness. And so, that's the rationale for the clinical approach. And so, and that means that what we'll cover in some ways is more theoretical than might be the case for people who are trained more purely empirically or from the social perspective.
- 1.3 I'm very interested in the philosophical approaches to—religious and philosophical approaches to personality, as well as the scientific approaches, and I think they're reconcilable. So one of the experiences you might have if you train as a clinical psychologist is going to be, depending on the school that you attend, is that the psychoanalytic types, who are increasingly rare, are set against the behaviorist and more physiological types, or vice versa. The behaviorists are set against the psychoanalysts, but from my perspective, they're just viewing the same set of phenomena from different perspectives.
- 1.4 And one of the things that I'm going to help you appreciate is the hierarchical nature of personality, the fact that it can be analyzed at multiple levels, that there's some apparent internal contradiction, depending on where you start, depending at what level at which you approach the problem, but that those contradictions are more apparent than real. So I'll endeavor to provide you with something approximating a coherent and complete description of personality lacking in detail, as all forms of knowledge are, but one that will allow you to

reconcile the findings of the more empirical biologists, let's say, and behaviorists, with the more abstract psychoanalytic thinkers and the **phenomenologists**.

- 1.5 I believe that they, all those levels of analysis have their utility. And to the degree that they're correct, they're not going to be fundamentally disunited. Assuming that there's something coherent about both personality and the approaches to personality, and there is something coherent. It took me a long time in teaching and thinking to start to understand not only how the theories differed, the multiple theories that we'll discuss, but what was the same about them, which is, I suppose, equivalent to something like the core of personality theory. And that's a very, very exciting thing to understand, because everything that you'll learn in this course, I will endeavor to make directly, personally relevant to you. It shouldn't ever devolve into a collection of dead facts.
- 1.6 This is something you always want to do. If you're lecturing in a manner that is actually compelling, the material has to be accurate. So let's say factually accurate, but it also has to be relevant to the people who are listening, because otherwise they'll, their attention will wander and they won't remember. And you'll bore yourself and your audience. And that's never a sign that you're on the right track, let's say.
- 1.7 All right, so what are we going to cover? Seven different domains in an introductory manner. Because this is an introductory course. We're going to talk first about religious and mythological conceptualizations of **personality and its transformations**. I like to set the more recent, let's say, psychoanalytic traditions and everything that stemmed forward from that, including the behavioral traditions, in a much more broad historical context. I think that's necessary, partly because you don't want to suffer from the delusion that everything about human beings that's relevant and accurate has been discovered in the last 150 years, which is most definitely and absolutely not the case.
- 1.8 The scientific understanding of personality and the clinical understanding of personality have a deep affinity with markedly traditional understandings of the nature of human beings, stemming all the way back, as we'll see, to the **shamanic** conceptualizations, which are, in all likelihood, hundreds of thousands of years old. Modern human beings, in our current genetic form, emerged about 350,000 years ago. We can assume some continuity of conception and process over that entire period of time, and that's also something extremely interesting to know as setting yourself in a historical context that's that archaic, gives you a much more fundamental sense of who you are and where you came from.
- 1.9 And it's also the case that understanding those extremely archaic ideas, which also tend to be very fundamental and unchanging, sheds substantive light on many of the things that you'll experience in the modern world, most particularly the meaning of the narratives, the fictional representations, the movies and dramas that grip your imagination and entertain you. There's a reason that a fictional representation is entertaining when it's of high quality. And the reason is, is that it echoes in your soul, so to speak, at a very, very deep level. And one of the things that

you'll come to understand more deeply, I hope, in consequence of this course, is why that echoing occurs.

- 1.10 Then we'll talk about the psychoanalytic tradition. Now, the more strictly scientific types tend to be skeptical of the analytic tradition, and that's a big mistake. It's partly because the scientific enterprise actually has a number of stages, let's say, and one stage is scientific hypothesis testing and data analysis. Careful experimental analysis. The behaviorist types, who are pretty physically grounded, were very good at that end of the scientific enterprise, as were the psychometricians who concentrated on the measurement of personality. But the psychoanalysts, the psychoanalysts were exceptionally good at generating hypotheses, and that's a more unexamined part of the scientific tradition. Where do ideas come from? How do you generate an idea that's innovated, innovative and interesting?
- 1.11 And the, Freud and Jung, let's say, and their associates and followers were unbelievably innovative in their approach to conceptualizations of the human mind. And I would also say that recent developments, especially with regards to large language models and artificial intelligence, have demonstrated, I believe conclusively, that the psychoanalysts were exactly on the right track in relationship to the structure of the human unconscious, and we'll go into that in some detail. And that's something very new. I've only been able to understand that relationship in the last two years, let's say, because the large language models have really only been on the scene for that length of time. So I think large language model cognition can help us understand what the psychoanalysts meant, technically meant, by symbol.
- 1.12 Now, one of the reasons the behaviorists who are more down to earth, let's say, have criticized the psychoanalysts, literary critics, for that matter, is their claim that the interpretations laid out by people like Freud and Jung were nothing but projections of the imagination. They bore no relationship to reality, no demonstrable relationship to reality. But the large language model calculations are predicated on the idea in a way that every word or every idea is surrounded by a cloud of ideas that are highly likely to co-occur together statistically. Right, so you could imagine that the word witch, for example, is quite likely to be accompanied by words like cauldron or coven, and very unlikely to be surrounded by words like skyscraper or stainless steel, and so that a given concept exists within a cloud of associated conceptions.
- 1.13 And the elaboration of that cloud of associated conceptualizations is something like the symbolic analysis, the free-association symbolic analysis, of the psychoanalysts, and also of the symbolic investigation of the literary critics. I suspect we're on the cusp, in the realm of artificial intelligence, of mathematically systematizing our assessment of symbolic representations. I already have a large language model built that's predicated on my work that's very good at dream analysis. And so that means to me, and I think this will happen, that the analysis of dream images will become something that can be purely scientific and mathematically encapsulated.
- 1.14 So, and I think, I really believe that psychoanalysts, starting with Freud, were on the right track conceptually and practically with regards to the investigation of the symbolic meaning of dreams and and literature for that matter, drama. So that's extremely exciting. The idea that we can

make a, not only a science, but even a mathematical model of the symbolic landscape that we inhabit. So we'll delve into that in some detail.

- 1.15 Carl Rogers and the humanists. The humanist tradition is, I think it's a secularization of Christianity, essentially. Carl Rogers himself was a, was a missionary before he lost his religious faith. And his representation of human personality and psychotherapy, because Rogers was very involved in the psychotherapeutic tradition, is a recasting of the Christian idea of redemption into the realm of secular mental health and psychopathology. Rogers believed that truth-seeking in the psychotherapeutic process was intrinsically redemptive, which is a restatement, you might say, of the gospel notion that the truth will set you free.
- 1.16 We'll delve into Rogers analyzing, in particular, his conception of dialogue as transformative, and do our best to understand what that means practically, let's say, with regard to your relationship with yourself, but also to other people, and also what it means in relationship to the genesis of psychopathology and its cure.
- 1.17 Existentialism and phenomenology. The existentialists, the Freudians, let's say, the Freudians made the essential presumption that the trauma was the cause of much psychopathology. That the default human personality was healthy. But when it suffered damage, especially early in life, the healthy developmental path was circumvented and various forms of pathology emerged. The existentialists questioned that particular Freudian presumption, making the case instead, which is also a case grounded in deep religious tradition, that the vagaries of human existence are such that suffering capable of generating psychopathology is not necessarily a consequence of trauma, but built into the structure of human existence itself, not least because we're self-conscious, say, and aware of our own mortality, which is an existential problem of sufficient magnitude to give us all grounds for a certain degree of mental illness, and perhaps even malevolence in the absence of any particular marked trauma.
- 1.18 Which is not to say that some people don't have it worse than others, or that you won't have it worse at some times in your life than others, and you will. It's not to say as well that the consequences of having it worse might not have some additional influence, let's say, on you, on your, the course of the development of your personality. I really like the existentialist approach, because I think that the notion that the, the problem that—what would you say? Mental health problems, so to speak, the problem of psychopathology is not a consequence of the deviation of the normative or ideal human pathway, but something that's baked into the structure of human existence itself, that we all have to grapple with the finitude of our existence, let's say, and our subjugation to suffering. And that understanding that, how that warps and dements us, and also how that might be dealt with in a forthright manner, is of great utility.
- 1.19 Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn, who's not precisely a personality theorist in the classical sense, although is definitely an existentialist, made the case that the lies attendant on the human proclivity to deny the existential reality of our own experience not only warped our souls in the most profound of ways, but also laid the groundwork for the development of the terrible atrocity-seeking totalitarian states that most particularly characterized the 20th century. And so the

other great contribution of the existential theorists, as far as I'm concerned, is their ability to link the inadequacy of any given individual's approach to the existential problems of their own life with the emergence of something like state-sponsored hell on Earth.

- 1.20 And I think that that's something of absolutely crucial significance to understand. There's probably, you know, one of the clichés that emerged in the aftermath of the Holocaust in World War II, or prior to World War II, prior and during, prior to and during World War II, was the notion that we should never forget what happened. But you can't remember something you don't understand. And it's not particularly easy to derive the lesson from Auschwitz. Now the **existentialists** and again, I would say particularly **Solzhenitsyn**, went further and **Viktor Frankl** went further along that path than anyone else trying to draw a relationship between your individual moral obligations, your failure to live up to them, and the genesis of the authoritarian catastrophes that characterized the secular 20th century.
- 1.21 The **phenomenologists** I find particularly interesting because they, following **Heidegger**, approached the problem of what constitutes reality in a very unique manner. The more scientifically-oriented Enlightenment behaviorist types and the psychometricians make the assumption that the most appropriate way to conceptualize reality, the truest way of conceptualizing reality, is in relationship to its objective truth. Now, there's some problems with that presumption in that our experience of reality, which in some complex way is indistinguishable from reality itself, has an irreducibly subjective element which the objective tradition has a very difficult time dealing with. The **phenomenologists** attempted to circumvent that subjective-objective dichotomy by describing reality itself as that which is experienced, and adopting that approach.
- 1.22 Well, first of all, profoundly transforms the manner in which you think about what constitutes the real. If you assume, consciously or implicitly, that only objective, that only the objective is real, you cast your own emotions, motivational states and dreams, fantasies, visions of the future, even the meaning of your life, into something that constitutes some second-order reality or even a non-reality, and that has potentially devastating, that contributes in a potentially devastating way to the development of a kind of life-devouring nihilism.
- 1.23 If you're nothing but a brief flicker of flame, no, composed of dust on a third-rate planet at the edge of a minor galaxy, it's very easy to become cynical and dismissive about the fact of existence itself and your own life. And reconstituting your idea of what constitutes reality to, on the assumption that what you experience is the most foundational, is the, is the fundament and the foundation, transfigures the manner in which you might conceptualize the dignity and significance of your own existence. And that's a crucial, that's crucial existentially, because if you have contempt for yourself, you know, as a second-order reality, let's say, that's, it's very easy for that to become contempt for other people and even contempt for existence itself. And that's a very dangerous road to walk down.
- 1.24 And one whose nature has been laid out quite comprehensively in the religious and mythological representations of man and woman that we already discussed and in the

psychoanalytic and existential traditions. So the analysis of the phenomenological approach, which puts human experience at the center of things, or maybe even experience itself, or maybe even conscious experience itself, is a powerful antidote to that dehumanizing objectivism, let's say. And Heidegger himself formulated his philosophy, upon which the phenomenological approach was predicated, in order to combat that dehumanization and then paradoxically fell prey to the Nazi ideology and, say, degenerated into a supporter of precisely the kind of psychopathological approach that he in principle was attempting to fight. So ironic twist in 20th-century history.

- 1.25 The Piagetian tradition. Jean Piaget, a developmental psychologist, not often regarded as a personality theorist. But that's generally because personality theorists don't know how to integrate his thinking into the personality tradition. And I think I know how to do that, and so that's not a problem. I like Piaget and thought a lot, not least because it points, and he knew this to something approximating an emergent morality that has a certain grounding in objective, in the objective. So Piaget noted, and we'll delve into this, in some detail, that the games that children spontaneously play have a particular pattern. So part of that pattern would be, if I force you to play, that's not a game. And I'm not going to be a popular child, and you're going to be a bitter and resentful kid in consequence of the force and compulsion that's been applied to you.
- 1.26 A game, a true game, has to be voluntary, has to have rules that both parties accept and are willing to abide by. There's only a set, there's a pattern, you might say, to games that have that quality and that can be played sustainably or that can be played in an improving manner. And you might say, the essence of the set of all playable games that can be played in an improvable manner is the foundation of morality. There's a very important thing to understand.
- 1.27 You see that importance of that make itself manifest in the stages of childhood, where children start to become truly social, which starts to emerge around the age of three when they can begin to take the perspective of someone else, when they begin to have true friends, when they can engage in reciprocally altruistic behavior, when they can take turns and share, right—which is to learn, to begin to learn, how to treat another person as if they had the same status and importance as themselves or their own desires.
- 1.28 That capability, well developed, makes them highly socialized, popular, and happy children, and also turns them into the kinds of adults who can engage in sustainable and improving patterns of cooperative and competitive behavior with other people, which is a good way, for example, of conceptualizing a friendship or a marriage. It's a game that can iterate, repeat. It has a certain pattern and the iteration produces improvement as it progresses. Now, you could imagine that there's many ways of interacting with people that do not have that property, and a small subset, a straight and narrow path, you might say, that characterizes the set of interactions that do have that property.
- 1.29 And if the goal is voluntarily sustained improvement of function, socially distributed, that's not much different than the establishment of a transcendent ethic, the transcendent ethic upon which morality itself might be predicated. And so that's a very useful and interesting thing to

understand. You know, it's a great antidote to the idiot moral relativism that proclaims that all approaches to social interaction are of equal, are diverse first in their essence and also of equivalent value. Because there's no transcendent ethic, no possibility of a transcendent ethic. I think that's mostly just an escape from fundamental responsibility rather than an intelligent approach.

- 1.30 But I also think that the Piagetian analysis of the emergence of games in children, which you could dismiss if you were casual in your thinking as something relatively trivial—why be interested in the games that children play before they're mature? His analysis of what children are doing is so profound that it points the way to the reconciliation between the religious viewpoint and the scientific viewpoint, which was actually what Piaget was trying to do. That was his motivation. And so that's really something to understand as well.
- 1.31 I also like the Piagetian tradition because it builds the—it allows for the comprehension of personality from the bottom up, so to speak. Piaget was interested, for example, in what he called the basic reflexes that children bring into the, that infants bring into the world when they're born. The micro movements and preconceptions that they're capable of manifesting, upon which the entire superstructure of socialized personality is erected. It's a bottom-up approach, and one of the things that's so lovely about that, from a philosophical perspective, is that it maps extremely well onto the neurobiology of the brain and the development and maturation of those neurobiological structures in the course of human socialization.
- 1.32 And so we'll move from the Piagetian tradition to the biological talk about the physical foundations of the motivational and emotional systems in particular, although also the perceptions and patterns of action that characterize us as biological entities, and we'll do what we can to integrate that biological view with the religious tradition, the analytic tradition, the humanistic tradition, the existentialists and the phenomenologists, the Piagetian developmental constructivists.
- 1.33 And then finally we'll close with the psychometric approach, which concentrates on the science of measurement and the use primarily of statistics to lay out the domain of human personality. The most effective psychometric, psychometrically oriented psychologists have identified six, seven—it depends on how you break them up—fundamental human traits. One is general cognitive ability, which is likely the most— what would you say? It's the most powerful abstracted conceptualization of the entire corpus of social science and medicine. There's nothing that's more well documented, easier to measure, and more powerful and reliable as a conception and predictor than psychometric intelligence.
- 1.34 And there's nothing more controversial and potentially cultural, culture-destroying. The culture war that besets us is in no small part an emergent consequence of the findings of the psychometricians, particularly on the intelligence side. It's a brutal, bloody business. One of the things you learn as a clinician, especially if you do IQ testing, is the absolute scope of the intellectual differences between people. They're stunning. And given that there's no better predictor of long-term life success than psychometric intelligence, there's no better predictor of

climbing, let's say, the economic ladder. There's no better marker of future success at birth than intelligence, including wealth.

- 1.35 The differences between people in intelligence are pervasive and marked and also very fundamentally, biologically predicated, which is also an awful realization because we like to believe as, what would you say, compassionate people committed to the notion of equality, that everyone can learn equally, and that the field of opportunity, especially with regards to complex matters, is open to all. And there is very little evidence that that's true.
- 1.36 So one of the most damning statistics, for example, which we will refer to further, is the fact that the US Armed Forces, which has been using psychometric tests continually since World War I, when they were trying to determine how to organize people rapidly to fight off the threat that the war constituted, they turned to psychometric testing, which was developed by French psychologists and perfected to some degree by the English, especially the socialists, as it turns out.
- 1.37 They turned to psychometric testing to identify potentially promising officers and continued their investigations into psychometric measurement for 60 years, concluding, I believe, by the 1980s, something like that, 1990s perhaps, that no one with an IQ of less than 83 could be trained under any circumstances whatsoever to do anything that wasn't positively counterproductive while they were members of the Armed Forces. And that is really something to understand, given that that's about 10% of the population, and that the Armed Forces is always desperate for manpower and committed to using a career in the Armed Forces as a stepping stone for people, let's say, in the underclass or in the working class, to move themselves up the economic hierarchy.
- 1.38 So they're highly, highly motivated to make use of everyone available and yet concluded after their 50-year investigation that 10% of the population cannot be utilized in any productive manner whatsoever for military enterprises. And so it doesn't take much thought about that to understand that something approximating the same thing applies in the general world, which means that the conservative idea that everyone can get ahead merely as a consequence of diligent effort, and the liberal idea that everyone can be trained to do anything given enough resources, are both seriously wrong, and nobody knows what to do about that.
- 1.39 So now the psychometricians also outlined the basic structure of personality considered from a statistical perspective, generating the now well-known so-called Big Five models—extraversion, neuroticism, agreeableness, conscientiousness, and openness. Honesty, humility is sometimes added to that, as is the Dark Tetrad, which is a constellation of malevolent and counterproductive personality traits. We'll analyze all the five traits, broken down each into their two aspects. Make some reference to honesty, humility, and delve a bit into the patterns of the Dark Tetrad types, relating all of that back as we progress to the other psychological models that we're going to cover.

- 1.40 So, that's the plan. We'll start with religious and mythological conceptualizations to provide this historical context. So as I mentioned earlier, human beings of our type took our form, something approximating, 350,000 years ago. And so we've been around for quite a long time. One of the anthropological mysteries that bedevil us is, if we've been around for that long, why did it take us so long to get our act together, right? Because there's not a lot of evidence for rapid cultural progression until something approximating 20,000 years ago. Something like that. And that means that we were occupied with god only knows what for about 320,000 years before that.
- 1.41 And some of the darker speculation is predicated on the assumption that we couldn't get off the ground because we were too busy pulling anyone who was successful down and engaging in constant warfare with the other tribal groups in our, let's say, in our locale, and that whatever generated the unifying thrust of civilization, which was likely something like the pervasive spread of monotheistic religious systems, had to fight against both of those proclivities—envy, let's say, and the tendency to engage in continual low-level, chronic destructive warfare.
- 1.42 So I studied the most archaic personality conceptualizations, including conceptualizations of transformation, primarily by investigating the writings of Mircea Eliade, who was a Romanian historian of religions and a true genius. He was someone who basically operated in something approximating the psychoanalytic tradition. He was a compatriot of Jung, for example, of Carl Jung, whose school was influenced heavily by Freud, and Eliade was very interested in the universal patterning of religious ideation across cultures.
- 1.43 He's a theorist who was cast aside by the Postmodernists, who now dominate the universities and certainly the field of inquiry into the history of religious ideas, because the Postmodernists claim— this is the fundamental Postmodernist claim—that there is no fundamental uniting metanarrative. And so that's a critique, let's say, an extended quasi-Nietzschean critique, of the idea of God, a continuation of the death of God that Nietzsche so famously pronounced, but also the insistence that there is no fundamental unity that aggregates our personalities, let's say, within ourselves or across people— a very dismal and disenchanting view of human nature.
- 1.44 If you are not particularly amenable to conflict, because if there's no fundamental unity, then there's a fundamental disunity, and if there's nothing but a fundamental disunity, there's no integration of personality and there's no hope for peace. Now, the way the Postmodernists dealt with that existential problem was by— what would you say? Surreptitiously inserting a uniting metanarrative derived from the Marxists, which is the narrative of power and the presumption that the only game in town is my attempt to attain dominance and status, likely or even inevitably, at your expense, that there's no such thing as genuine dialogue.
- 1.45 For example, there's no discussion between people of intrinsic worth and goodwill oriented towards establishing something like a maintainable peace, which would imply a kind of unity. There is only instead something like the Hobbesian war of everyone against everyone. That's a world predicated on power. And I believe, speaking psychoanalytically, that people who believe that are doing it primarily because they want a justification for using nothing but power. And I

also not only believe but think, I know that a world that's predicated on nothing but power is indistinguishable from the total—the atrocity-committing totalitarian states of the 20th century.

- 1.46 Now, I had a discussion at one point with Camille Paglia, who's a very well-known literary critic, and she said something very interesting that's relevant to this course, something I'd never heard any other psychologically-oriented thinker state, which was that, if the academy, the universities, particularly the departments of English and their literary critics, had turned to the school that Eliade was part of, that included Erich Neumann and Carl Jung, for example, many other thinkers, particularly of the Bollingen School, the history of the last 30 years, particularly with regards to the culture war, would have been entirely different.
- 1.47 Mircea Eliade and his group, Jung, etc., massively influenced, for example, Joseph Campbell and the filmmakers who made Star Wars and who concentrated on the re-presentation of the hero myth. The analysts of the hero myth assumed that that myth in particular was one form of the uniting narrative superstructures that did point to an overarching unity of human psychological and social conception. Eliade had delved deeply, for example, into the shamanic tradition, which was what I was originally making reference to, as the most primordial form of philosophical/religious enterprise that we have any record of.
- 1.48 The shamanic tradition likely extended from the dawn of modern human beings, let's say, approximately 350,000 years ago, until the present day. There are still societies that are essentially shamanic in their traditions extant on the Earth, especially in places like the Amazonian jungle, although they're becoming more rare. There's a pattern to the shamanic rituals, which is, if properly understood in my understanding, equivalent to analysis of the potentially creative breakdown of the individual human personality and its reconstitution on more solid ground. So it's an early variant of the notion of death and rebirth as the pathway to progression upward, both psychologically and socially.
- 1.49 And I think, and I'll show you in the course of this course, the existence of that pattern at every level of psychological analysis that we're going to engage in. I think it constitutes the core, which I referred to earlier, that unites all of the schools of personality theory and investigations into psychopathology that we'll cover. You can decide for yourself as you walk through this, whether or not you find the evidence compelling. I think that one of the reasons that it's compelling, and this is actually a technical description of what makes a fact compelling, is that it occurs in multiple contexts that are independent from one another. Right?
- 1.50 So one of the ways that you judge the reality of something is whether it makes itself manifest to various modes of, various independent modes of measurement. So that's why you have five senses, right? You can see something that isn't there. It's less likely that you will see and hear something that isn't there. It's less likely still that you'll see, hear, and touch something that isn't there. But that's enough, not enough. You have two other senses just to nail things down. And even more than that, we're still skeptical, which is why, if I believe something is real, I might ask you and you and you, and look for consensus across all three of you to help me adjust the potential error of my perceptions.

- 1.51 That's what you do when you use multiple methods of measurement, which is something, by the way, formally recommended by the psychometric psychologists who've been endeavoring to determine when a psychological measurement is real as a measurement, but also reflective of something real in the world. It's real if it can be detected in a variety of distinguishable and separate manners. And so the pattern that I'm going to lay out for you that characterizes the **shamanic** pattern of transformation does make itself manifest at multiple levels of analysis, and we'll use it as a uniting structure as we progress through the various theories.
- 1.52 Now, I also think and hope, know, for that matter, that you'll find this personally relevant, because understanding the pattern of personality transformation can help you maintain your faith when things fall apart, knowing as you hopefully will come to, that having things fall apart at different levels of depth is actually a precursor to transformation, such that things come together more reliably and productively. And understanding as well, and this is something absolutely fundamental, that to the degree that you can engage in the process of personality dissolution and its **reconstitution** voluntarily, your chances of success and your freedom from anxiety and your ability to maintain hope will be much, much improved.
- 1.53 And so all of that's locked into the **shamanic** practices. And so we'll do an overview of that now, as well as a relatively deep dive into the abstract structure of the processes of transformation that the **shamanic** rituals both constitute and refer to. We'll start with the **shamanic** foundation, and then we'll close this first lecture with an analysis of the relationship between the Judeo-Christian conceptualization of **personality and its transformations**, which is determinative for all the psychological theories that we're going to consider, all protestations of the practitioners of those schools of thought to the contrary. I'll show you the relationship between these Judeo-Christian ideas, which are ancient in their own right, and the underlying **shamanic** substrate, let's say, that's far more archaic even than those traditions.
- 1.54 We'll talk about **descent into the underworld** and **reconstitution**, because that's the essential nature of the **shamanic** endeavor. Upward striving, **descent into the underworld**, and **reconstitution**. You know how it is in your life. You have periods of time where you encounter something initially incomprehensible and profoundly difficult, and things fall apart around you and within you. And maybe there you are for some indeterminate period of time in the **underworld**, right? Suffering the torments of hell. But you emerge stronger and wiser, now able to deal with and to understand things that were beyond you to begin with.
- 1.55 Well, that's the characteristic pattern of human adaptation. As such, there's no learning without at least a small death, which is part of the reason that we're eternally resistant, even to the learning that might transform us. Now, if you understand that, and you'll come to understand that more deeply in consequence of this class, you may be able to see not that every treasure has a dragon, let's say, but that every dragon has a treasure, which is an unbelievably useful thing to know as you encounter the difficulties that will beset you as you make your way through life.

- 1.56 There is an insistence, beginning with the shamanic practitioners themselves, that the manner in which we encounter the unknown elements of life tears us into pieces before reconstituting us. And if we can understand that process and accept it and even welcome it and even worship it, you might say, then we're best positioned to transform ourselves when necessity makes either doing that or dying necessary.
- 1.57 So what will we examine in the Judeo-Christian tradition today, somewhat briefly? The notions of pride, self-consciousness, sin and the fall of man that characterize the opening chapters of Genesis. The notion that personality can transform, but that that's a consequence of humility. First, you're wrong. You admit it. You would like to change, and you're willing to, which Carl Rogers identified as the precondition for any successful psychotherapeutic endeavor. Right? You have to come to the agent of change, let's say the therapist, knowing or hoping that you have something to learn and some manner to change in a beneficial way, even if that's going to be painful to you, as a precondition for the transformative process to even begin.
- 1.58 That's identical to the proclamation that religious humility, which is the opposite of the greatest sin, which is that of pride, is the precondition for atonement, at-one-ment. The pulling of yourself back together and the uniting of that integrated self with, you might say, the world and the spirit of the world, the pulling together of that, and redemption, which is your ascent out of Dante's inferno and the abyss, back into something approximating the light. We'll also assess the role of prayer, so to speak, and revelation, mostly in secular terms, because I want to draw your attention to the correspondence between those fundamentally religious ideas and our secular notions of thought itself.
- 1.59 Here's a way of beginning that. How is it that you go about thinking? Well, first of all, you have to have something to think about. And so what does that mean? Well, you have to have a problem or something that you're interested in. That's conscience, the problem, or calling the thing that you're interested in. Then you have to understand that you don't know, right? Because why think, if you know? And so you, that's the admission of insufficiency, let's say, and ignorance. Then you have to believe that, if you're ignorant and you want to know, that something will respond to that.
- 1.60 And modern people, when they think, they say, "well, something occurred to me" or, let's say, "something revealed itself to me in consequence of my questioning," without understanding that they're making a case right then and there, in their words and their experience, for something like the revelation that's always hypothetically attendant on questioning, right? Knock and the door will open. Well, that presumes that you knock. And so one of the things that's worth understanding is, what are the psychological preconditions for knocking and asking and seeking? And certainly one of them is the realization that, if you're not living in paradise now, maybe you still have something to learn.
- 1.61 So prayer, what's that? The practice of upward aim in relationship to personality transformation. That's a very good way of thinking about it. Revelation—that's what you learn if you're lucky and fortunate, let's say. And if your aim is true, when you admit to your own insufficiency and

something descends upon you, that makes you more than you were. Karl Friston has made the case that anxiety emerges as a consequence of the manifestation of entropy, disorder, chaos, anomaly, the unknown. Right, and that you become anxious when a conceptualization that you hold that structures the world and makes it predictable disappears.

- 1.62 That happens when someone betrays you. Right? You have a model of someone. That model enables you to predict your interactions with them. They violate a presumption of the model. That's the betrayal, and all hell breaks loose. Why? Because that person is a lot more complicated than you thought they were, right? And that's not just an encounter with their unrevealed complexity, but also with yours, insofar as you're capable of betraying, and also with the malevolence and unpredictability of human beings as such. Because if your loved one can betray you, and you can do the same, then everyone can do the same thing. And so that encounter with unpredictability and malevolence, right? The willful violation of agreed-upon social rules, that's the revelation of entropy, right?
- 1.63 Friston also made the case, which was something I hadn't conceptualized, that pos—so negative emotion is a marker for the emergence of entropy. He also made a case that positive emotion signified a decrease in entropy, insofar as if you have a goal in mind, which frames your conceptions and your apprehension and structures your world, and you see yourself progressing towards that goal, which is something that makes you happy and enthusiastic, the reason that positive emotion emerges is because it marks a decrease in the distance between you and the goal, which is equivalent to a decrease in entropy.
- 1.64 So, Friston, we did work on this idea in my lab as well, has associated the notions of positive and negative emotion with one of the most fundamental concepts of the, of the, what? Of the world of physics. And so why am I telling you that? Because the descent into the underworld is the dissolution into entropy, right? It's what happens to you when the ground under your feet dissolves and down you fall. Why down? Well, it's a metaphor. You know, it's the metaphor of hell. It's the metaphor of below. Why is down, metaphorically, negative for human beings? Well, up is positive, right? We climb upward, we look up. When we're confident, we stand straight and we look forward. We look up. We gaze into the distance. We let the stars guide us. We let the sun and the moon be our markers. We're oriented by the north star. Up is where we look for inspiration and illumination.
- 1.65 Down is where we collapse when things go terribly wrong. Right? Down is where your face falls when you're miserable or depressed. Down is the more unconscious realm of the body. Up is towards the, towards vision, which is associated with illumination and enlightenment. Down is dust and dirt and decay and death and the grave, and up is heavenward and skyward and towards the light. And so the dissolution and descent into the underworld is the collapse of unifying structure into its constituent parts.
- 1.66 Confusion, confusion. It's what you experience, for example, when your, when the rickety old car that you can afford because you're really not a very hard and reliable worker breaks down on the way to the job that you hate to go to. And so what happens when the car breaks down?

Well, first of all, whatever you're in is immediately not a car. And you think, well, of course it is, because it hasn't changed in its important material aspects. It still has four wheels, for example, and two doors, some of which might even be functional depending on the cataclysmic state of your finances.

- 1.67 But you're under a misapprehension with regards to your understanding of objects, because a car isn't something with four wheels and, let's say, two doors; it's a conveyance from one point to another, and when it stops conveying you, it's not a car. And when it collapses on the freeway, let's say, it's now a nest of snakes, and you're in it. And what's the nest of snakes? Well, how stupid are you, that you're 35 years old, let's say, and that's the best bloody car you can afford? It's no wonder your wife or your husband can't stand having you around. And is the fact that you're driving this old clunker a consequence of your own fundamental inadequacy? Or is it a reflection of the sorry state of the cosmos itself, and what, the cursed nature of man at the hand of God?
- 1.68 And is it going to be that now you're going to lose the third job this year because you didn't get to work yet again? And are you perversely happy about that, because you actually hate the damn job and your boss? And what does that say about the entire substructure of the capitalist world, let's say, and poor, oppressed, and enslaved you, struggling mightily to get your clunker off to your hateful job? Well, that's what the car has turned into, right? All that confusion and chaos, all that noise and doubt. Right? That's a descent into the underworld.
- 1.69 That one happens to be involuntary. And that means it'll be signified by negative emotion. Anxiety first, that indicates the multiplying of the pathways in your life which had been reduced to: get in the car, drive to work, do your job; and expanded into whatever the hell mess you're in now, especially given that you can't afford the repair bill. So how are you going to get anywhere? And you're the sort of clueless character too daft about your own belongings to not be constantly taken advantage of, let's say, by malevolent mechanics who look upon you as a deserving object of exploitation, right? In no small part because of your own stupidity. Right.
- 1.70 So all that mess, that's what the car turns into. That's a very interesting way of looking at it, and a very interesting way of looking at the collapse of your conceptions in your life as such. It happens all the time. That's associated with the pattern of shamanic initiation. So I'm going to read you some material from Eliade, and we'll analyze it as we read it. Eliade, in his studies of shamanism, which was a pattern of practice and conception that was very widely distributed, especially in Neolithic times, so let's say 40,000 years and previously, and as I said, and is what mirrored in diverse places as far flung as Australia, among the aboriginal inhabitants, and in the Amazon, as well as across the Siberian plain.
- 1.71 Right, so it's the—you could think about it as the default religious system of Homo sapiens. Descent into the underworld, the collapse of the cosmos into the underlying chaos from which it was originally generated. Something that happens psychologically when you descend into a state of confusion, and socially, when your family or your community or your tribe or your nation descends into, say, chaotic fractionation, and nothing is certain, right?

- 1.72 Three routes to the shamanic vocation, as far as Eliade could document. Spontaneous vocation. So what does that mean? It's likely a hallmark of people who are high in trait openness, right? People high in trait openness are creative and interested in ideas. What does creativity mean technically? Well, imagine that I throw you an idea. OK, now imagine that the neural systems that apprehend that idea are surrounded by other neural systems which contain or represent associated ideas. OK, and that there's some probability that when you hear a given idea or encounter a given idea, that associated ideas will be simultaneously activated.
- 1.73 Now, if you were manic or schizophrenic or under the influence of a hallucinogen, then any given fact might trigger a plethora of associated facts virtually without end. Now that's useful creatively, but overwhelming and exhausting. And so, for the purposes of normal adaptation, there needs to be some limit on how much ideation is triggered by your receipt of any given idea, and there's individual variation in that, in that constraining. Some people are an inexhaustible well of new ideas, which, as I said, can degenerate into something approximating mania. Some people stick with what they've heard and that's it.
- 1.74 You can actually assess something like this quite straightforwardly. So, for example, I could get all of you to spend three minutes writing down all the words you can think of that are four letters long and begin with the letter S. And what we find is that, first of all, there's a Pareto distribution of your production. Some of you will produce 90 words at the exceptional, exceptionally fluent people among you, and some of you will produce five and far more of you, perhaps not five, 10. Far more of you will produce the lower numbers than the higher numbers. That's an ineradicable law of creative production. A small minority of the people do all the creative work. It's actually the square root of the number of people who are involved in the enterprise do half the work. That's, that's Price's law, right? A brutal, another brutal psychometric slash economic finding.
- 1.75 How many words you produce in three minutes is a decent predictor of your lifetime creativity. So especially in combination with general cognitive ability or intelligence, intelligence is probably something like the rate at which you can produce ideas, whereas creativity is something like the breadth of ideational scope and the probability that relatively distant ideas will be co-activated. So, you know, someone particularly creative makes a big leap. So imagine there's an idea. There's a core of close concepts around it. There's a secondary penumbra of more distal ideas. Outside of that, more distal ideas yet.
- 1.76 More creative people have more ideas in general, but also leap farther out, which can make them wrong because they jump to the wrong conclusion and also difficult to understand because they're so creative and also make it hard for them to explain how they got there, because that process occurs to them as something like a revelation, rather than as the consequence of, say, algorithmic cognitive processing. You know, something will occur to you rather than having you think it up. And if you're creative, something distant occurs. Right, and so spontaneous vocation with regards to shamanism. More creative people, the more creative people are likely to be more dynamic in their personality transformations.

- 1.77 So a conservative person, low in **openness**, is likely to find a pathway and bloody well stick to it. And that's a good idea if you're not very smart and if times are uncertain and if everybody knows what's going on and the pathway has been well specified. Stay the hell on it. But in times of change, right? Or if you're trying to gain an edge, a creative approach is useful. High risk but high return. Right, and so whereas the conservative approach is low risk and moderate return and characterized by a relative lack of **entropy**.
- 1.78 Now, I suspect as well that the **shamanic** types are not only high in **trait openness**, which makes them dynamic and flexible in their personality restructuring, but also high in **trait neuroticism**. Right, because you can fall apart, so to speak, or transcend yourself because you're creative, but you can also fall apart because you're very sensitive to negative emotion. And it's a rather dreadful combination of traits, to be very high in **openness** and very high in negative emotionality, because you keep sawing off the branch that you sit on and then suffering because of it. But that's also a pathway to transformation. It's often the case that people who are tormented by ideas solve problems.
- 1.79 That was certainly the case, for example, of people like Darwin, who was obsessed with the idea that eventually made itself manifest as the theory of natural selection, despite his faithful and staunch Christianity. And that conflict also threw him into the **underworld** and tortured him. We'll talk about the **creative illness** with the close of this section on the **shamanic transformation**, because there is a pattern of **descent and ascent** that characterizes creative revelation, even among secular people, even among, you know, atheistic scientists. They still, their discoveries still follow the ancient religious pathway, so to speak.
- 1.80 **Spontaneous vocation**. So that would be temperamentally determined, let's say, maybe even a slight tilt towards various forms of mental illness. Manic depressive disorder, for example, or possibly even psychosis, would also increase the probability that someone would undergo something approximating a spontaneous, deep personality transformation. Many of the earlier investigators into the **shamanic** process made the presumption that it was emblematic of psychopathology. But the important consideration here, and you want to really keep this in mind, is that whether or not a radical transformation of personality is psychopathological or redemptive depends, to a large degree, on whether it's undertaken voluntarily or thrust upon you. Right?
- 1.81 And so one of the reasons to be courageous and forthright in your approach to life is so that you can encounter the snakes at a time of your choosing, and on ground that you prepare, rather than waiting for them to get you in your—what would you say? As you cower under your bed. That's not a good strategy. It's also not the human strategy, not the fundamental human strategy, and it's associated with far greater levels of stress. This is a good thing to know. Imagine that I submit you and you to the same stressor, but you involuntarily and you voluntarily. And I measure your psychophysiological responses, let's say, from the neuron level upward.

- 1.82 What I'll find is that, if you're in the condition where you're encountering the stressor voluntarily, an entirely different pattern of psychophysiological preparedness, including attentional focus, characterizes you, than would characterize you doing it involuntarily. If you do it voluntarily, you're in challenge mode and you confront the stressor as if it's an opportunity. And that primarily produces motivation on your part in consequence of the positive emotion that marks progress towards a goal.
- 1.83 If, by contrast, it's thrust upon you kicking and screaming, then you're going to go into defensive prey animal mode, produce an overwhelming amount of cortisol, shrink, fail to pay attention, refuse to learn, petrify. That's why the basilisk in *Harry Potter* turns people to stone, by the way. Petrified like a rabbit being gazed at by a wolf and forego the advantages of voluntary exploration. Right? OK.
- 1.84 **Hereditary transmission.** Well, like hereditary priesthods, the vocation of **shaman** can be transmitted from generation to generation. That can be explicitly taught. So amongst relatively pre-literate tribal groups, the **shaman** and their apprentices often have a vocabulary that's 3 or 4 times greater than the typical vocabulary of the typical group member, because they're the storehouse of cultural tradition. Part of the cultural tradition is a description of the **shamanic transformation** process, the means by which it might be brought about, and the conceptualizations that allow it to be bounded and understood, so it's not terrifying.
- 1.85 Now, **Eliade** believed that most **shamanic** practitioners who weren't pathological engaged in their enterprise in a state of comparative sobriety. He believed that those practitioners who turned, let's say, to the use of psychedelics were an aberration from the fundamental stream. But I think he was probably wrong in that matter. Given more recent investigations into the historic use of psychedelic substances, it's the case that psychedelics produce a physio-chemical state that's quite analogous to what happens to you when you're highly stressed. That produces a neuroplasticity that facilitates learning.
- 1.86 It disinhibits the effects of memory on perception, because most of what you see is what you presume, rather than what's there, which is why the world is not as magical for you as an adult as it was when you were a child. That's reversed by psychedelic agents, which also produce this stress state, which can degenerate into an experience of hell, but that also facilitate learning. And so part of the technology of psychological transformation in the **shamanic tradition** is actually the usage and handling of psychologically active, hyper-powerful psychological active, psychologically active substances—psilocybin mushrooms, for example, or ergot, which is a fungus on rye which contains LSD, or *Amanita muscaria* mushrooms, the fairy tale mushroom, red with white dots, which is also a powerful psychoactive chemical, although different chemically than the classic hallucinogens. That was used, particularly, by the Siberian **shaman**.
- 1.87 There are ongoing investigations now into the use of psilocybin, for example, for addiction cessation, for the treatment of the fear of death, which it appears to be successful at managing, which is the understatement of the century if it's true. How can a physio-chemical reaction produce cessation of death anxiety? This is among people who are terminally ill. It produces a

spiritual transformation that reconciles people to their mortality. God only knows how, but that's part of what we're going to investigate. Most of that work was done at Johns Hopkins by Roland Griffith, who's a very solid, wise scientist who unfortunately recently perished of cancer.

- 1.88 **Hereditary transmission.** That's what we're doing in this course, is the **hereditary transmission** of the **shamanic vocation**, just so you know. And **personal quest**. Well, what's a **quest**? A **quest** is the adventure of your life, right? Whatever you're doing and wherever you're going, you're after something, right? It might be something proximal. You're after something sitting here. You're after whatever it was that made you interested in coming here. And that's associated with whatever it is that you're interested in general.
- 1.89 And that's associated with, with what? Are you here for good or for ill? Let's say, let's assume you're here for good. Well, then, the specific manifestation of your interest in the topic at hand is a specific instance of the manifestation of your tilt in general towards the upward voyage, let's say, or the good. If you're not sophisticated, particularly if you're immature, that orientation towards the good will be proximal and very time-bound. You'll be only interested and compelled by what might happen in the very short term. That's how a child reacts, right?
- 1.90 As you become increasingly mature, you're able to take a longer and longer view of what is motivationally significant, concentrating more and more, more and more on what's not only good for you right now, let's say from an emotional perspective, but on what might even be difficult for you right now from an emotional perspective, but highly beneficial in the medium to long run, or not specifically beneficial to you here, right now, but beneficial in the long run for everyone that you love around you and for the broader community.
- 1.91 And so you can think of that orientation upward toward the transcendent good as a manifestation of the maturation that makes you able to increasingly apprehend longer spans of time and include more people in your conception of appropriate action. Right now, the way that's marked instinctively, this is such a cool thing to understand, the way that's marked instinctively, that proclivity to mature and develop across time, is by the grip of your interest by forces that are beyond your control. So you wonder, if this is easy to understand. You know that if you're studying, for example, for a course that you spontaneously find rather dull, you have to beat yourself with a stick in order to concentrate, even though, you know, hypothetically, that you need to learn the material, that you have to pass the course, that it's necessary for your future. The spark just isn't there.
- 1.92 And yet, there are other circumstances under which you can learn things equally difficult, much, much more easily. Because why? Because the subject matter calls to you. Well, that call has a pattern. This is something unbelievably important to understand because your ultimate aim, known or unknown to yourself, is what calls to you. And so one of the reasons that you follow the **Socratic dictum**, which is know yourself, is because you want to bloody well make sure that you're following something that isn't leading you to the worst possible place in a permanent way. So, **calling**. That's that.

2. Beyond Comfort Zones

AT A GLANCE

Continues the personal quest as call and conscience (Bilbo, Pinocchio, Abraham), and argues that integrating aggression and the shadow, with resentment as a signal, is part of maturation. Reads Eliade on shamanic initiation: ecstatic and traditional instruction, dismemberment, reduction to a skeleton, communion with the ancestors, and climbing the world tree, with William James on pre-cosmogonic chaos and a child's archetypal dream. Covers Ellenberger's creative illness, Genesis on pride and humility, prayer as upward aim, Rogers on voluntary assent, listening and free association, and closes with questions on the reluctant hero, subjectivity, and IQ.

- 2.1 **Personal quest**, right? The **quest** motif has two fundamental variants. One is call, the other is **conscience**. You see that played out, for example, in the famous **quest** narratives that preoccupy our culture. Let's say, the **quest** narrative that's embedded in the Hobbit and the Lord of the Rings. You have **Bilbo** or **Frodo** who are small, nondescript inhabitants of a highly protected, even though that's not known to them, corner of a kingdom threatened by dark forces.
- 2.2 That's the existential condition of the default human being, right? Not renowned, not particularly powerful, not particularly wise, extant in some half-forgotten corner of the world, subject nonetheless to forces of protection. That's the sons of the great kings that shield the boundaries of the Shire, unbeknownst to the hobbits, and also threatened by the totalitarian forces of the all-seeing eye of **Sauron**. Well, what's the **quest**? Well, the wizard, the magical agent of transformation, appears on the scene and piques the interest of **Bilbo** and **Frodo**, and says, "There's more to you than you think. Leave the comfort of your surroundings and have the terrible adventure of your life."
- 2.3 That's the same voice that comes to **Abraham** in the form of God in the Old Testament. Have the terrible adventure of your life. Why? Because it's fascinating and interesting and you could be more than you are, but also because you should. That's **conscience**. In the Hobbit, **Bilbo** is guilty because he first rejects the call and refuses the adventure, and he rejoins the **quest** group, not only because he's interested despite himself in the adventure, but because his **conscience** tells him that he's foregoing something of great value to maintain his infantile dependence and security. That's the pattern of human learning.
- 2.4 As such, you're always somewhere—what would you say? You're always somewhere that's more comfortable than it could be. You're almost always somewhere that's more comfortable than it could be in relationship to your further progress. You can reside and stagnate in that comfort, or you can move towards the cutting edge, the **zone of proximal development**, where you encounter just enough novelty to keep you optimally alert and anxious and on edge and awake and excited and enthusiastic and engaging in life. That's the instinct of meaning.

- 2.5 And it's identical to the process of development that's at the core of the **quest** and to cortical maturation and to the pursuit of the ethos that unites people internally, psychologically, and communities harmoniously and productively. And as a side benefit, by the way, those who pursue the **quest** are much more attractive to people of the opposite sex. So that's a very useful thing to know, at least in principle, and perhaps to practice.
- 2.6 **Personal quest.** How do you find that **quest**? Follow what interests you. Pay attention to what bothers you, because the things that bother you, that's your destiny, trying to make itself manifest. That negative emotion is a marker to the pathway that would be best for you to take, even if you're apprehensive about that, as well you should be. That interest that makes itself manifest spontaneously, that's the same spirit that calls to **Moses** from the depths of the **burning bush** in the opening sections of Exodus, that reveals itself as something that shines forth. That's a phenomenon that shines forth, that then reveals itself in consequence of further diligent pursuit as the impetus of the divine itself.
- 2.7 Same thing applies to **conscience** in the **Pinocchio** story. The redeeming figure shows up as **Jiminy Cricket**, J. C. **Jiminy Cricket** is a southern US slang replacement for **Jesus Christ**. Why is **Christ** a bug in **Pinocchio**? Because things that bother you are your destiny **calling** to you. And so you avoid your **conscience** at the peril of your development. And worse, you avoid your **conscience** in a manner that will destabilize the state of your family, of your community, insofar as you could and should play a determining role in the furtherance and stabilization of yourself, your family, and the community.
- 2.8 So the **quest**, part **conscience**, part **calling**. It's the voice of adventure that propels you beyond your zone of comfort, hopefully in an optimally adventurous and playful way, and puts you on the edge of the development that makes you more and more capable in a greater and greater variety of situations. You see with the Lord of the Rings, the Hobbit, that perversely, **Bilbo** is called upon to develop his **shadow** elements when he first becomes a hero, right? They hire him for the **quest** as a thief, which is someone who breaks the rules and violates the moral order. You see the same motif in the **Harry Potter** series where Harry and his, **Hermione** and **Ron** are good kids, all things considered, but continual troublemakers and rule violators.
- 2.9 And the reason for that is, number one, some of your darker traits might be very useful for doing good if you develop them properly. Number two, you're morally required to break a rule when the moral order itself is degenerated. So the hero is frequently a **shadow** figure or has that element integrated into himself, which is why in action adventure movies, for example, the typical adventure hero has a very dark side. That's very well exemplified, for example, in the figure of **Batman** that's become particularly popular in recent years. And you see the same thing in, what would you say, quasi-superhero representations like **James Bond**.
- 2.10 The hero is not a simply nice person, a harmless figure. The hero is someone who instead has his or her capacity for absolute bloody mayhem well under voluntary control. That's equivalent to the **integration of the shadow** from the perspective of the **Jungian** analytical thinkers, right? What did **Nietzsche** say? Something approximating the voyage of transvaluation of all values

begins with the reconsideration of just what constitutes good and what constitutes evil. What that means—and it means something like this, I think, that there are tendencies within you that are very powerful, and if they lead you, they can be the worst of all possible things. But if you can put them in their proper place, let's say, in relationship to something like an integrated higher goal, they become the most effective servants of your **quest**.

- 2.11** And that's certainly the case with regards to your proclivity for aggression. This is something very useful to understand, practically, let's say, especially if you're agreeable. So if you're high in **agreeableness**, if you're in a negotiation with someone else, you're likely to take their side rather than your own. And so you might think that's a very moral thing to do. But it's not, because you deserve some consideration just like the other person. And worse, if you habitually sacrifice yourself to other people, you will become resentful and bitter.
- 2.12** Now, agreeable people are very good at caring for the ill and dependent. And women are more agreeable than men cross-culturally. And that happens at puberty. And one of the likely reasons for that, because of the immense proclivity for dependence that human infants have, that female human beings have to sacrifice themselves completely to the care of infants when they're dependent. And that proclivity for self-sacrifice that characterizes infant care properly can unfortunately generalize. It's a good strategy for someone who's six months old, but not a good strategy for dealing, let's say, with your husband.
- 2.13** One of the consequences of being agreeable is that you can get bitter and resentful and then all hell breaks loose. And so this is a very useful thing to know, psychologically. If you're resentful, you've got to watch this. If you're resentful, there's only two reasons. One is, you should grow the hell up and quit whining. The other is, you have something to say that you're not saying because you're under the thumb of something or someone whose thumb you shouldn't be under. And so then you have to analyze that resentment and that darkness to see what words it would present to you if allowed to have its say.
- 2.14** Now, you can do this just as an exercise. One of the things you do for people in therapy for **assertiveness** training is like, OK, you're angry with this person. If you could say exactly what your most evil heart desires to say, what would it be? Write it down. Write them an email. Don't send it. Write them an email because you need to know. What's the blackest part of your soul aiming at? Now, it might have something to say. And maybe if you analyzed its desire intelligently, testing the spirits to see if they're of God, so to speak, you could find out that there is something that you should be saying to set things right in your own heart and perhaps in relationship to the people in your family and your community.
- 2.15** And that's part of that integration of aggression. You might say, well, you should never be aggressive. Well, that's a foolish sentiment. It's not attractive. It denudes your personality of character, not least because anger is one of the most effective antidotes to fear. And so if you dispense with aggression, you're much more susceptible to anxiety. If you have that aggression integrated, then you have a motivational force at hand that's part of your personality that will dispense with fear when that's necessary. And that's unbelievably useful. And so you don't want

to remain infantile in relationship to your ability to wield a club, which doesn't mean that you should wander around randomly clubbing people just because you feel like it.

- 2.16 Adam is called upon by God to subdue the world. To name and subdue the world. What does that mean? Everything in its proper place. That's what it means. That's the operation of a highly functioning consciousness. Everything in its place, including the primary motivational drives, let's say, or subpersonalities of aggression—and according to the Freudian, sexuality. Very powerful forces. Intellectual prowess for that matter, which can manifest itself in pride. Everything in its proper place. Then it can serve the highest good and be a facilitating agent, let's say, in the quest.
- 2.17 Back to the shamanic. Eliade: "By whatever method he may have been designated, a shaman is recognized as such only after having received two methods of instruction. The first is ecstatic. Dreams, trances, visions." A new revelation can make itself manifest in the form of a flood of images, rather than verbal thoughts, let's say. And that dream-like flood of images is the birthplace of ideas, just like your dreams are the birthplace of ideas, and your visions or the visions of a culture are the birthplace of ideas.
- 2.18 "The second is traditional. Shamanic techniques, names and functions of the spirits, mythology and genealogy of the clan, secret language. This two-fold teaching imparted by the spirits and the old master shamans constitutes initiation." Classic religious inculcation. Why? Well, in Catholicism, there's this spirit of the tradition. That would be conceptualized, let's say, as the Holy Spirit. That's encapsulated within the box that's dogma and tradition. And both of those things are necessary because if you're all spirit and no tradition, heaven help you. You're a loose cannon, even to yourself. And if you're all tradition and no spirit, you've got no adaptive flexibility.
- 2.19 And so the genuine quest is a optimized balance of one foot in order and one foot in chaos, right? And the shaman are trained to be masters in both domains, so they can deal with, what would you say? They can deal with the anomalies that might confront them in their community, but they're also stabilized by their knowledge, not least of the tradition that defines the transformative process, as I mentioned previously.
- 2.20 "In Siberia, the youth who is called to be a shaman attracts attention by a strange behavior. For example, he seeks solitude, becomes absent-minded, loves to roam in the woods or unfrequented places, has visions and sings in his sleep. In some instances, this period of incubation is marked by quite serious symptoms. Among the Yakut, the young man sometimes has fits of fury and easily loses consciousness, hides himself in the forest, feeds on the bark of trees, throws himself into water and fire, and cuts himself with knives. The future shamans among the Tungus, as they approach maturity, go through a hysteroid or hysterical crisis, but sometimes their vocation manifests itself at an earlier age."
- 2.21 It's logical that this would occur at puberty because an intense period of neurological pruning and, what would you call, pruning and stabilization takes place at puberty when the mature

personality catalyzes, or doesn't. That's often the time in life where schizophrenia makes itself manifest as well, in no small consequence of that neural regeneration and reorganization gone astray. "The boy runs away into the mountains and remains there for a week or more feeding on animals, which he tears to pieces with his teeth. He returns to the village, filthy, blood-stained, and it is only after 10 or more days have passed that he begins to babble incoherent words."

- 2.22** That's a descent into, you might say, prelinguistic savagery, right? A disintegration of the personality to its fundamental elements as a preparation for its **reconstitution** in a higher and more structured form. This is why it's so useful to understand when you're wrong and to look for that. Because every time you can figure out when you're wrong, when something besets you and befalls you, when an obstacle appears in your path, you think, OK, is there something I did? Even something distant in the past that increased the probability that this particular misadventure has befallen me.
- 2.23** Now, there are times when that seems to be a very difficult thing to manage because something patently unfair has happened to you, let's say, and the last thing you want to do is some soul-searching under those conditions. But if there's something that you did wrong, that you could discover, that you don't have to repeat, then maybe that thing will never happen to you again. It's a very useful thing to understand when you're trying to make peace, let's say, with your husband or your wife.
- 2.24** There's going to be fights that appear and reappear frequently in your relationship, and it's going to be a royal pain to solve them. It's going to be a descent into the inferno. It's going to be a search for the betrayal that produced the pathology. It's like a surgery, and it will be, what would you say? Devastatingly difficult and demanding and met with plenty of resistance in the form of anger or tears, psychological disruption. You might say, why bother? And the answer is, do you want to have the same damn fight for the rest of your life or do you want to settle it?
- 2.25** And the same thing applies to yourself. Part of the religious injunction towards humility is realization of the fact that if you could figure out how you were wrong, even if it's 5% you and 95% your idiot mate, then you could rectify that 5%, and then the same misadventure would cease befalling you. And so that's a very, very—see, and conjoined with the realization that if you encounter something difficult voluntarily, it's a challenge rather than a stressor. That means that you can transform the manner in which you respond to your own errors. Instead of thinking of them as evidence of your insufficiency and reason for being resentful, you can think about them as opportunities that have not yet revealed themselves.
- 2.26** And that's an unbelievably—that's enough to perhaps impel you, if you understand it, to really search your soul when things are going wrong. It's like, maybe I could find it. Well, that's devastating because some of you is going to have to go when you find out what the error is. But if you know the payoff is a better you and a less obstacle-ridden future and more peace and tranquility of the genuine sort, more productive relationships, why wouldn't you make the sacrifice? And that's a very useful way of conceptualizing it, too.

- 2.27 In the biblical corpus, the relationship with the divine is established through sacrifice. Why? All of your stupidity has to go, right, in the **quest** for what's highest. And so partly what you do is you try to find that, on your knees. You try to find where you're insufficient, not so that you can flagellate yourself, but so that you can rectify that foolishness and what? And who knows what? And learn again to walk with God in the garden. That's the promise, right?
- 2.28 "The strange behavior of future **shamans** has not failed to attract the attention of scholars from the middle of the past century. And from the middle of the past century, several attempts have been made to explain the phenomenon of **shamanism** as a mental disorder. But the problem was wrongly put; for on the one hand, it is not true that **shamans** always are or always have to be neuropathics. On the other hand," this is the critical point, "those among them who had been ill became **shamans** precisely because they had succeeded in being cured." So it's not the illness, it's the recovery. Right.
- 2.29 Pattern of the shamanistic vision and transformation, **reduction to a skeleton**. That's a form of death. Why death? **Whitehead**, I think it was **Whitehead**—I can never get the philosopher right—who said, "The purpose of thinking is so that our thoughts can die instead of us." So you have a stupid idea, you act it out, and you're dead. Contrarily, you have a stupid idea. You subject it to criticism. You gather some opinions. You find out it's stupid. You painfully allow that conviction to depart, and you live. Thinking is going to require suffering, but not as much suffering, at least this is the promise, as acting out your most profound levels of stupidity.
- 2.30 So thinking is going to be a process that produces anxiety and offense if it's ever serious, because if you're really thinking about something, something has to go. And it might be something deep. Better that than you. That's why **Christ** tells his followers in the gospels that if their eye offends them, it's better to pluck it out than to maintain the illusion. Better to sacrifice the part than the whole. And that's the sacrificial approach to developmental understanding. **Reduction to a skeleton**. Something's going to die. And the more profound the death, the more complete the personality transformation, but the more potentially agonizing and intimidating the process.
- 2.31 This is also part of the religious pattern. The crucifixion, death, and resurrection is a **descent into the underworld** and a **redemption** motif. And it's predicated on the idea that voluntary death and **reconstitution** is the pattern that redeems the world. And that appears perfectly accurate, psychologically and socially. It's actually the pattern of human adaptation because we can abstract, right? We can produce fictional avatars of our own selves, and we can experiment with them and let them disappear when they're counterproductive.
- 2.32 It's an evolutionary revolution because prior to the emergence of that capacity for, let's say, the **logos**, the capacity for abstracted thought, an organism in error only had death as its choice. Now, you can just get rid of what's stupid about you. That's a much better solution. And it means that, in the course of a single life, you can die and reconstitute an infinite number of times as you repair and reconfigure your personality and make yourself more and more well

adapted, attractive and productive. And so it is voluntary sacrifice. It's the pattern of voluntary sacrifice upon which the community is genuinely founded, if it's not founded on power.

- 2.33 Communion with the ancestors. Well, why? Complicated. Let's say you're confused and you can't find any wisdom even among your peers. You don't know what's going on. Neither do they. Where do you look? Well, there are two patterns. There are two sources of wisdom that stabilize us in addition to our senses. One is consensus, as I pointed out. "This is what I think. What do you think?" And the other is, well, you don't know what the hell you're doing either. Let's look to the wisdom of the past.
- 2.34 Right, so there's a vertical axis of stabilization. That's tradition and a horizontal axis. That's the **holy mountain**, by the way. The horizontal axis is the populist proclivity and the desire to seek consensus, which is useful. And the vertical axis is something like, yeah, but the crowd can go dreadfully wrong. And so you need something like reference to the eternal verities to stabilize you. That's why the **shaman** are practitioners of spiritual enlightenment, the process, but also masters of their tradition.
- 2.35 Jung said famously, "The purpose of a religion is to stop people from having religious experiences." A very paradoxical formulation. But what he meant by that was, God allows himself to be revealed to **Moses** as a consequence of Moses' faithful service. But before that happens, Moses has to hide between two cliffs so that he can barely see anything and then only get a glimpse of God as he passes. Why? How much can you take? And so part of what tradition does, this is what memory does, too, is constrain your perceptions so that you're not encountering any more than you can handle. And so you violate that protection at your peril.
- 2.36 There's a scene in the Old Testament, for example, very difficult to understand, where this gentleman, whose name is **Uzzah**, is walking alongside the **Ark of the Covenant**, and it's being carried on a litter, and the bearers of the Covenant trip, and the Covenant is in danger of falling. So **Uzzah** puts out his hand to touch it, and he's immediately struck dead. Seems very unfair, given what he was trying to do. But the moral of the story is, touch the sacred at your peril, and that's dead true. In fact, you could say that that's a definition of the sacred. The sacred is what you touch at your peril. And maybe you won't know when you first do it. It'll take a decade for the consequences of your presumption to reveal itself.
- 2.37 Climbing the **world tree**. That's the journey up **Jacob's ladder** towards the ineffable infinite, right? The good that unites all goods that can't be defined. The transcendent good that lurks behind all proximal goods. After the descent, the ascent upward. That's voluntary as well. Exactly. And that's the realm of the ancestors first, because when you emerge from the abyss and move towards enlightenment, one thing you can encounter is the wisdom of the prophets, right? The genuine protection and brilliance of the tradition. And beyond that is the spirit itself, which is the force that gave rise to the tradition to begin with, and which still makes itself manifest within you as your upward striving and transformative consciousness.

- 2.38 "According to a Yakut informant, the spirits carry the future shaman to hell and shut him in a house for three years. Here, he undergoes his initiation." This is images of suffering. "The spirits cut off his head, which they set off to one side, for the novice must watch his own dismemberment with his own eyes, and hack his body to bits, which are later distributed among the spirits of various sicknesses." We experience that when we say, in our own lives, "things really fell apart for me." I didn't know where I was. I didn't know where I was going. I had no notion of what was happening. Everything was turned upside down.
- 2.39 "It is only on this condition that the future shaman will obtain the power of healing." Voluntary acceptance of the transformative process is the key to the mastery of healing. The psychoanalysts knew that. They insisted that practitioners of analytic psychology underwent their own analysis before they practiced. That's the wounded and resurrected healer as the archetype of, what would you say, archetype of the physician. "His bones are then covered with new flesh. And in some cases, he's also given new blood." Blood is emblematic of spirit, let's say. That's why there's an injunction in the Old Testament against consuming the blood of animals. And the flesh is something that's more solid and material, let's say, and so the future shaman is awarded a new structure and a new spirit.
- 2.40 This happens in the story of Abraham, by the way, who makes sequential sacrifices as he pursues the spirit of adventure. He transforms so completely that he's given a new name. Same thing happens to Jacob, who becomes Israel, who's the chosen of God, because that's what Israel means. What it means is that if you allow yourself to transform upward, allow that process of death and resurrection to continue, and transform yourself completely, you'll turn into something so different from what you were, it will be as if you're a new person. That's a baptism, by the way.
- 2.41 "One of the specific characteristics of shamanic initiations, aside from the candidate's dismemberment, is his reduction to the state of a skeleton." That's a formidable process, right? But engaged in, with faith and courage, with knowledge of the sequence, then even that descent into the inferno can be something that speaks of the light that will eventually shine. And God only knows how true that is of all the misadventures in your life. We said already that every treasure has a dragon. That's the essence of the hero myth. There's no opportunity without threat, but the converse of that could well be true. There is no obstacle without its opportunity.
- 2.42 And that's something to really understand when something really terrible comes your way. It's like, well, maybe there's something here. If I could only see it, if I was only careful enough, faithful enough, courageous enough to see it, maybe there's something here to learn, proportionate to the terrible—what would you say?—proportionate to the suffering that the experience constitutes. Many of the people I know who have become wise in their journey through life did, became so, not least because something terrible came their way, and they mastered it.
- 2.43 So that's a very useful thing to know because terrible things will come your way. And you're going to want to know why you should possibly or even how you could maintain faith when

everything seems so unjust. It's like, you're called upon to maintain faith no matter what happens to you. That's the moral injunction. And that's partly because, imagine something terrible happens to you, and then you're angry and miserable and bitter and resentful. Well, then all you're doing is magnifying your misery. No matter how undeserved it is, it's not an attitude that's going to help you. I know that's a lot to ask, that no matter what you're suffering, no matter how unjust, that you maintain your faith in yourself and in the cosmic order.

- 2.44 But what's the alternative? Like, a bleak resentment? And that's just the starting point of a very terrible descent because it's first resentment, and then it's anger, and then it's vengeance. And God only knows what it is after vengeance. Murder, genocide. Things go from bad to worse very rapidly, just like they go from good to better very rapidly.
- 2.45 "One of the most specific characteristics of shamanic initiations, aside from the candidate's dismemberment, is his reduction to the state of a skeleton," to the essence, to the bones. "We are here in the presence of a very ancient religious idea, which belongs to the hunter culture. Bone symbolizes the final root of animal life, the mold from which the flesh continues continually rises."
- 2.46 Reduced to your fundamentals. That's the motif of voluntarily undertaken sacrifice. Reduction to the fundamentals. That's how you identify what the fundamentals are. That's how you become aware of what they are. That's how you consciously recraft your life in relationship to your discovery of those fundamentals. "It is from the bone that man and animals are reborn. For a time, they maintain themselves in the existence of the flesh. Then they die and their life is reduced to the essence concentrated in the skeleton from which they will be born again."
- 2.47 "I would like even now to stress the fact that the psychopathology of the shamanic vocation is not profane. It does not belong to ordinary symptomatology. It has an initiatory structure and signification; in short, it reproduces the traditional mystical pattern." That reduction to chaos and the reconstituting of the world, that's Noah's flood. It's the same idea. That chaos that people fall into, that's the same chaotic potential that the spirit of God that traverses the, what would you say, the primordial waters, encounters at the beginning of time and extracts order from. That's the same process that characterizes the human beings who are made in the image of the divine creator, right? Your capacity to encounter chaotic potential, contend with it, and cast it into the order that's good.
- 2.48 The essence of consciousness, because consciousness deals with what has not yet been mastered. The essence of the process of maturation, the essence of adventure, the essence of romantic adventure, the essence of relationship, the predicate of social order, and the process upon which the regeneration of the state depends. That's why you have the right to free speech so that you can engage in that process of regeneration so that the state doesn't stagnate and stultify.
- 2.49 "The total crisis of the future shaman, sometimes leading to complete disintegration of the personality and to madness, can be evaluated not only as an initiatory death, but as I said, also

as a symbolic return to the pre-cosmogonic chaos." That's that potential that exists always and at the beginning of time. That's the field of potential that you apprehend when you consider what you could do with what's in front of you, for better or for worse. That's what your consciousness always contends with. That's the dragon that you're always wrestling with insofar as you're conscious. That's what consciousness does and is. "To the amorphous and indescribable state that precedes any cosmogony," any establishment of order.

- 2.50 What is that pre-cosmogonic chaos? William James, who established experimental psychology—I used to work in the building named after him at Harvard. William James wrote about this partly because he learned what it was by experimenting with nitrous oxide, which is a relatively harmless hallucinogen, which was quite popularly distributed in the late 1800s. Latent information. "Pure experience is the name I give to the original flux of life, before reflection has categorized it. Only newborn babes and persons in semicoma from sleep, drugs, illnesses or blows can have an experience pure in the literal sense [of a that] which is not yet any definite what, tho' ready to be all sorts of things."
- 2.51 The potential that you experience when you wake up in the morning and apprehend the dawn of the new day. "Full both of oneness and of manyness," he definitely sounds like a 1968 hippie. "Full both of oneness and of manyness, but in respects that don't appear; changing throughout, yet so confusedly that its phases interpenetrate, and no points, either of distinction or of identity, can be caught."
- 2.52 A poem that he wrote in the throes of nitrous oxide intoxication. "No verbiage can give it." So it's outside the domain of semantic conceptualization. "Because the verbiage," the verbal representation, "is other. Incoherent, coherent, the same. And it fades! And it's infinite! And it's infinite. Don't you see the difference? Don't you see the identity? Constantly opposites united. The same me telling you to write and not to write! Extreme—extreme, extreme. Something, and other than that thing! Intoxication, and otherness than intoxication. Every attempt at betterment,—every attempt at otherment—is a—it fades forever and forever as we move."
- 2.53 He is trying in the throes of his poetic inspiration to conceptualize the domain of that which has not yet been conceptualized. The remnant mystery in your marital partner, the part of yourself that you do not understand, the elements of the world that are not yet revealed but could be in consequence of your actions. How do you define that which has not yet appeared? Possibility, chaos, plentitude, opportunity, terror, hell, chaos, all of that. That's the domain that consciousness contends within, the domain into which it can sink when it disintegrates because of the misalignment or inadequacy of its aim.
- 2.54 "Now, as we know, for archaic and traditional cultures, this symbolic return to chaos," this is a good thing to know in your own life as well, "is equivalent to preparing a new creation." That's the story of Noah and the flood. And that pattern of story is extremely well distributed all around the world. The notion that things can fall apart so badly that nothing yet, nothing remains except the seed from which something new can be borne. "It follows that we may

interpret the psychic **chaos** of the future **shaman** as a sign that the profane man, the inadequate man, the insufficient man is being dissolved and a new personality being prepared for birth."

- 2.55 That's a good attitude to adopt as a matter of habit. The purpose of the most fundamental forms of religious training is to train you to understand that that's what you are, always. You're not what you are. You're what you could yet be. And when you are forced to choose between what you are, stable and predictable and comfortable, though that may be, and what you could be, the golden rule is to always choose what you could yet be. That justifies the sacrifice. That's also that upward-aiming spiral. And it's the adventure that justifies the suffering of your life. Now, that's something to understand.
- 2.56 Is life meaningful? Well, let's say you say no. Well, you're wrong, because then the meaning of your life is pain that won't remit, and that's a meaning, too. So the question more intelligently formulated might be, "Is there a manner of apprehending meaning such that your suffering fails to make you bitter?" Right. That's the pattern that's being laid out in the **shamanic** process of transformation.
- 2.57 Here's an idea that my daughter had when she was very little. This is an example of how dreams and **archetypes** make themselves manifest even in the imagination of children. She was five years, eight months old, playing prince and princess with her, with **Julian**, who was her three-year-old brother. She came to me and said, "Dad, if we killed a dragon, we could use its skin as armor, couldn't we? Wouldn't that be a good idea?" So what does that mean? It's the idea of the **pharmakon**, which is the idea that a little of the thing that poisoned you will cure you.
- 2.58 That's the idea behind vaccines when they're not fake, right? Is that, if you expose yourself voluntarily to the things that poison and dismay you, you'll become stronger and more resilient, right? That's the symbol of the staff with the serpent around it, by the way, that is the ancient symbol of **Asclepius**, who's the god of the physician. It's also the serpent and staff upon whom God called the Israelis to gaze upon when they were being bitten by poisonous snakes in the desert. They looked upon that which poisoned them and were in consequence fortified. That's the alchemical dictum. The thing you most want will be found in the place you least want to look.
- 2.59 So what happens if you confront what's emblematic of mortality and malevolence? You discover something that you can put on as armor, right? And she figured that out. It's a good thing, too, because she got very ill after that and very seriously needed to know exactly that. The following dream was described by my daughter again, **Mikhaila**, when she was three years, nine months old, about my son **Julian**. This speaks to the developmental stage progression that **Piaget** laid out as characteristic of children, which is a variant of the **shamanic transformation** process. About my son **Julian**, one year, 11 months old, October 5th, 1995.
- 2.60 **Julian** was in the process of toilet training, a stage **Freud** identified as the fundamental emergence of the social order into the individual psyche. Regulate a fundamental motivational state, excretion in this case, in a manner that's socially acceptable. It's the invasion of the

superego, you could say, into the **id**. It's a determinative transformation from the psychoanalytic perspective, and you can understand that at least symbolically, even if you don't believe it practically. Toilet training and rapid speech development. He was on the cusp of no longer being a baby. He's changing from a baby into a toddler.

- 2.61 But **Mikhaila** liked to call him baby. Now, we weren't **calling** him baby anymore, but she liked to call him baby. Now, there was a reason for that. When her brother was born, we trained her to take care of him, even though she was only a year and a half older than him, and liable, in consequence, to suffer from sibling rivalry, which was quite common when children are separated by less than three years. We ameliorated that by giving her responsibility for the baby and encouraging her to form a relationship that would substitute for the loss of her mother. So that's a useful thing to know, which she did very well. And so they were very close.
- 2.62 Now, the consequence of that was, she liked the baby. Now, this is an early manifestation of what could be the devouring mother, because a devouring mother is someone who likes the baby a little bit too much. And the toddler and the child and the potential future man, let's say, not nearly enough. Well, why was she resistant to stop **calling** him baby? Well, we said he's not a baby anymore, and she's only three. What the hell does she know? She's thinking something like, well, I like this baby. And now what the hell is he? And where has he gone? And, like, every mother asks herself that question when she has to start the painful process of detaching herself from her dependent infant.
- 2.63 We had several discussions about the fact that he wasn't a baby anymore. She told me this story while I was at the computer. It's such a cool story. So I was able to get it verbatim. **Mikhaila** said, "Julian's eyes falled out and then he fell into pieces." I said, "What sort of pieces?" And **Mikhaila** said, "**Julian** pieces. And the bones falled out, too. Then a hole got him, and there was water in it. And when he came out, he was big." Mom said, "**Julian** isn't a baby anymore?" And **Mikhaila** said, "No, he's a big boy. And a bug with legs got him out because bugs can swim. And the hole was in the park and it moved into the backyard and he falled into it. A tree burned and left the hole."
- 2.64 It's a stunning dream. We lived next to a park, and I used to take the kids into the park at night to experiment with fear because it's a spooky place. Lots of rocks, old trees. And so it was a place they could go to encounter their fear. And there were trees there, big trees. And the tree is emblematic of life and development. It's the **burning bush**, for example, or the tree of life, or the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. And so the tree in her dream moved into the backyard, this tree that the **shaman** climb when they make their ascent out of the pit. It moved into the backyard and burned down. So that's a symbol of transformation.
- 2.65 Left a hole, and the hole filled with water, which is the **pre-cosmogonic chaos**. And the baby went into the **underworld** and was **reduced to a skeleton** and lost his eyes and then reconstituted. And came out under the impetus of a bug. Remember, we talked about the bug, about **Jiminy Cricket**, under the impulse of this instinct to move forward that compels and, what

would you say, plagues people. And that was her deeply profound imaginative reconfiguration of her brother and the transformations of life.

- 2.66 Never assume that your children are stupid. They're young and they're not very verbally proficient, but their imaginations are as old as life itself. And that imagination has seen everything and been everywhere. And it can make itself manifest in the dreams, especially the **archetypal** dreams of which this is certainly and obviously one. It was so cool. Such a cool dream. So remarkable.
- 2.67 She was quite enthusiastic and happy when recounting this. You could imagine it was a nightmare, but it wasn't. She was happy about that, and that appeared to reconcile herself, reconcile her to the new reality, a shifting of her imaginative representation, and then the emergence of a new conceptualization. It didn't hurt that we explained to her as much as we could what the dream meant, that **Julian** was changing in an important and positive way, but that doesn't mean that he was lost, more that something new was coming into being.
- 2.68 **Ellenberger** characterized, described the characteristic elements of the **creative illness** that I referred to earlier, the pattern of profound creativity as follows. "A **creative illness** follows a period of intense preoccupation with an idea, its search for certain truth." That's a **quest**. "It's a polymorphous condition that can take the shape of depression, neurosis, psychosomatic ailments, or even psychosis. Whatever the symptoms, they are felt as painful." That's the process of something new coming to be born. "By the subject with alternating periods of alleviation and worsening."
- 2.69 Imagine that you're on a **quest**, and the consequence of that is that your most fundamental presuppositions, even about yourself, are reconfigured. Well, you're going to fall apart as a consequence of that, because when you make that discovery, let's say, that there's more to you than you thought, which is what soldiers discover when they do terrible things on the battlefield and then suffer post-traumatic stress disorder, right? Never imagining that they would be capable of such things. You fall apart as a consequence of the profundity of your realization. But that doesn't mean that you should be leery. No, it doesn't mean that you should avoid profound self-reflection because nothing gained, nothing ventured.
- 2.70 And in your **quest** for enlightenment, reference to the traditions that stabilize is intensely useful. **Jung** said that many of his clients, most of whom were highly creative and were attracted to someone like **Jung**, often returned to the religious tradition of their origin in consequence of their psychotherapeutic practice and progress.
- 2.71 "Throughout the illness, the subject never loses the thread of his dominating preoccupation. It's often compatible with normal professional activity and family life. But even if he keeps to his social activities, he's almost entirely absorbed with himself." What would you say? The dream emerges to take over the semantic personality. People descend or ascend into the realm of image and fantasy. And that's part of the process of the renewal of semantic and propositional conceptualization. What you know in words is reconfigured by immersion in the dream.

- 2.72 "He suffers from feelings of utter isolation, even when he has a mentor who guides him through the [ordeal], like the shaman apprentice with his master. The termination is often rapid and marked by a phase of exhilaration." The ground is firm under the person's feet, and new opportunities make themselves manifest in keeping with the new conceptualization. That's the renewal of the future. "The subject emerges from his ordeal with a permanent transformation in his personality," the goal of successful psychotherapy or religious practice for that matter, true religious practice, "and the conviction that he has discovered a great truth or a new spiritual world."
- 2.73 We're always surrounded by the unknown, always. And we can fall into it at any moment when something we didn't expect makes itself manifest. That's the reemergence of the dragon that can be banished but never defeated, that always threatens the, what would you say, unprepared city. The proper orientation in that situation is to take on the new manifestation of possibility as a challenge. Done voluntarily, this catalyzes a disintegration that, if voluntary, can be withstood and even welcomed, a reduction to essence and a reconstitution. That's a profound Piagetian stage transition. That's a transformation of personality.
- 2.74 It's an element of the sequence of personality transformations that lead people, you could say, to the top of the heavenly mountain. That's the imagery that's associated with that continual quest. That's Mount Tabor or Mount Sinai in the biblical tradition and the holy mountain of religious traditions everywhere in the world. Why the pinnacle of a mountain? Because you have to climb to get there and because you can see everything when you're at the top, because you're closer to the heavens, because you can touch the sky, because you're in the domain of the sun and the moon. That's that upward movement, metaphorically speaking.
- 2.75 And it is an upward movement conceptually, because this is something Piaget understood that makes our lives not that of Sisyphus pushing the same boulder up the same mountain only to have it roll down. Boulders and mountains, but in sequence with each peak higher than the last, with progress marked by the fact that, with a real personality transformation, you can still do everything the previous you did and more, and that there's no logical conclusion to that upward process of transformation.
- 2.76 In the accounts in Genesis, in particular, there's a portrayal of the personality of—there's a portrayal of human personality and its transformations. The account is as follows. The first idea is that man and woman alike are made in the image of God. And that means something very particular in the Genesis text, because the God that's portrayed and characterized prior to the creation of man, so the only God that has been described when that creation takes place, is in fact the spirit or process that broods on the pre-cosmogonic waters. So the chaos that we had discussed, and whose exploratory and linguistic action gives rise to the order that is either good or very good. Good with regards to creation as such, and very good with regard to the specific creation of man and woman.
- 2.77 So God is characterized as a dynamic, a spirit that extracts out of potential order. Now that's related to the shamanic idea of the descent of personality into chaos and its subsequent

reemergence renewed. Now, there is a more specific account of the reasons for that descent as well in the Judeo-Christian account, because particularly in the story of the fall, the reason that the personality deteriorates or is in need of renewal is further elaborated. It's fundamentally a consequence of something approximating intransigent pride.

- 2.78 Imagine that part of the reason that you might become stale and outdated, let's say, and then bitter and resentful, is because you cling bitterly and desperately to your outmoded presumptions. That's what the Pharaoh does, for example, in the story of Exodus, which is why he's visited by sequential plagues that accelerate in intensity, which is exactly what will happen to you if you stick to your guns a little bit too foolishly when you're called upon to transform.
- 2.79 Eve and then Adam are tempted by the spirit of pride to overextend their reach. And that prideful arrogance produces a cataclysmic descent into the chaos that's actually portrayed as history itself at the dawn of the Old Testament accounts. What's the medication for that? Well, it's death and renewal, but it's also formalized to a great degree in the Judeo-Christian tradition, which is a clear precursor to the therapeutic tradition, which is part of the reason that I'm outlining it. The first stage in that redemptive process is the humility that's the antithesis of pride. It's literally the opposite. That humility is, you're probably wrong about something.
- 2.80 And so your goal, and this is the goal of confession, let's say, the confession that helps you atone, is to figure out, well, where were you wrong? And to really search for that. And you can understand if where you're wrong is a stumbling block, if it's actually the cause of your demise, that anything you can do to uncover it is going to be to your benefit. So you search oriented by upward aim. And that's actually the purpose of the prayer, let's say. When you think about something, when you consider something, you're calling out, that's a way of thinking about it, for a revelation, an intuition. Maybe you think you've done something wrong, but you don't know what it is. And so you search for that.
- 2.81 Well, what does it mean to search? What are you searching, exactly? Are you searching your unconscious? Are you searching the stars? Where is it that you expect this revelation to come from? If it's you, why do you need it? You'd already know it. If it isn't you, then where does it come from? Well, the monotheistic hypothesis in part is that it descends from on high, so to speak, that it emerges from the source of all being itself, and that that revelation from the source of being, if that's the source you call upon for your enlightenment, will in fact inform you as to the nature of your faults and illuminate for you the appropriate pathway forward that atones.
- 2.82 And that is how thought works. It wouldn't work if it didn't work like that. Obviously, you formulate a question. Obviously, it's in relationship to your own insufficiency. If that question couldn't be answered, there'd be no point in formulating the question. It can be answered, and obviously by something that's in some sense beyond you. You can attribute to the unconscious, I suppose, which is what the more secular thinkers would do. But something responds, and it responds in the spirit in which you call upon it. So this is also something very careful to note.

- 2.83 If you're trying to find your way forward, let's say, in a complex situation, and you allow motivations that you're not willing to become aware of—resentment, bitterness, anger, the desire for destruction, revenge, all of that—if you allow that to color your aim, then the spirit of those motivations is what will respond to your query. And so this is, seriously, I don't know if there's anything you can learn that's more terrifying than that, that the spirit you call on is what answers. So what's the purpose of prayer, so to speak, or the purpose of the determination to aim upward is to make bloody sure your aim is right, because if it isn't, you'll be led astray.
- 2.84 And there's no doubt that this is true. You'll see this when we get into the physiology. We know enough about how perception works now to understand that the pathway forward that reveals itself to you, along with the objects of the world, do so in accordance with your aim. Obviously, because you couldn't even walk across the street if your perceptions didn't specify a pathway. Clearly, the way that you look at the world is dependent on where you're headed.
- 2.85 And so this works in abstraction as well. Imagine that if thoughts in some ways are substitutes for real-world objects or, what would you say, or real-world actions, because they're abstractions, the thoughts that make themselves manifest to you in the theater of your imagination are going to be guideposts to the destination you've specified, consciously or unconsciously. And so you better aim up if you want the proper pathway to make itself manifest in front of you. If you really want to know who your friends are, if you really want to know who your foes are, and the true obstacles in your path and the facilitators forward, you better have your aim right. And the purpose of spiritual devotion is to ensure the accuracy of that aim.
- 2.86 Now, Rogers, as I said, also pointed out that in his estimation, and I certainly believe this to be the case, not least in consequence of my practice as a psychotherapist, is that there's no psychotherapeutic transformation possible without the voluntary assent and full-hearted commitment of the person involved. That's a precondition. It's a precondition. You have to go there thinking, maybe it's you. Now, if you have a good therapist, the therapist doesn't assume a priori that you're the problem, although that's one of the options that's on the table. There are situational factors that should be taken into account. You can suffer dreadfully at the hand of someone who's fundamentally psychopathological, but you want to lay out the landscape with extraordinary detail and attention, and then let the cards fall where they will.
- 2.87 This is partly what you want, actually, when you're talking to someone that you love, your wife or your husband, let's say, someone you're deeply associated with. This is something men really need to know about women who are more sensitive to negative emotion. One of the things that you can do that's extremely helpful to your partner is just let them talk. They have a problem. It's compelling communication. It's not necessarily the case that they know what the problem is. They can feel it. It rises as a sense that something isn't right, some anomaly. People have to beat around the bush, stupidly and blindly, in order to flesh out the actual diagnosis. Very, very difficult.
- 2.88 Men have a proclivity to jump to the solution, and that's fine because a solution is wanted, but there's no sense solving the wrong problem. And women, you can think of women in some ways

as alarm systems with their heightened sensitivity to negative emotion and their increased agreeableness. They're going to have a sense that something's not right before it's really explicit. And what would you say? And its essence is laid bare. And so, and that requires some wandering of investigation in order to specify. Then once it's specified, and you know what the problem is, well, then you can come up with a solution.

- 2.89 But if you do it, if you leap to the solution, not least because you're impatient, let's say, with the wandering, well, good for you, except you've solved the wrong problem, and so that's not going to be very helpful. And it's a painful thing. Make no mistake. This is a painful process because if I have a problem, if we have a relationship, if I have a problem, you might be the problem. And so one of the things that I'm going to explore is, is it you? Now, if I'm honest, I'm also going to see if it's me with equal, what would you say, diligence. But during that exploratory process, especially if it's a serious problem, a lot of things are going to come out of the woodwork. And so you got to be patient.
- 2.90 And same applies if you're a practicing psychotherapist. See, Freud figured this out. We'll turn to that in the next lecture. This is why Freud developed the free association process. His approach was, say whatever comes to mind, whatever, whatever. Now, people rarely have an opportunity to do that. If someone listens to you, which almost never happens, you get to say whatever comes to mind. Now, Freud noted that that's actually a process, and that that process unfolds in a manner that descends, takes apart, and then reconstitutes. He got that right, as far as I'm concerned.
- 2.91 And that makes sense, right? Because imagine that your attention wanders as you speak. Something appears to you and then something else appears to you. All you have to do is think about that for 15 seconds from an evolutionary perspective, say, and you'd understand that that's obviously purposeful. Well, Freud's observation was that if you just listen to people, their speech will wander until it finds a problem, and then it'll circulate around the problem and descend into it. And then, possibly, with all the destruction that entails, also generate a solution.
- 2.92 And one of the things that almost all therapists figure out is that sometimes someone will have a problem. They bring it to you, and you know what the solution is. But if you tell them, it's useless, partly because they don't know the details of the solution. But even more importantly, because they didn't come up with it. And so they haven't thought it through. They don't even really know why they should implement it. It's not like you can give someone their destiny as a gift. They have to do the hard work.
- 2.93 And so if you're interested in practicing as a therapist, let's say, or training as a therapist, one of the things you really have to understand is there's almost nothing you can do that's more effective than just listening. Just listen. You have no idea how many people there are out there, perhaps including you, who have never been listened to by anyone in their life and who are, in consequence, full of knots that haven't been untied and stories that haven't been told and realizations that haven't made themselves manifest and intuitions that died stillborn. It's not good.

- 2.94 But the other thing, too, is that that's a key to success. People will tell you what they want and need if you listen to them. They will tell you everything. It's a remarkable thing. They'll tell you things they've never told anyone else or even themselves, if you just listen. And what that means is that, if you learn to listen, then people will tell you how to deal with them. So if you have a business and you actually listen to your customers, if you're fortunate enough to have customers, they'll tell you what you're doing right, and they'll tell you what you're doing wrong. And all you have to do is listen and do those things, and poof, you're successful.
- 2.95 I spoke with the comedian Jimmy Carr about how he prepares his comedy routines. Many comedians do this. When they're preparing a new tour, let's say, that they take out into the world, their 90-minute routine, they go to small clubs and they try out their idiot jokes. And some of them aren't funny. No one laughs. Some of them, people laugh. So they just overproduce. That's Darwinian. Overproduction. Then they test and they cull everything that isn't funny and they keep what everyone laughs at. And once they have 90 minutes of things that everybody thinks are funny, because they've been told that, they go on the road and everyone laughs. And so you can't believe how much that's the secret to life.
- 2.96 So when you talk about voluntary versus involuntary, how does the trope of the reluctant hero fit in with that?
- 2.97 So when Pinocchio first encounters Monstro in the abyss, he turns tail and runs. That's a very, very common mythological motif. And that's because the thing you're avoiding is worse in its essence than you think. And by the time you discover that, it might be too late. You'll be tempted to run. Very, very common reaction of the reluctant hero, who then, inevitably, insofar as he's a hero, reconstitutes himself and goes forward. Maybe he gathers more resources. Maybe he gathers more allies, maybe he, what would you say, engages in the proper sacrifice. In some manner, he fortifies himself, and likely by making reference to his aim.
- 2.98 When Abraham is called by God to undertake the adventure of his life, he undergoes a sequence of transformations, and each is marked by a sacrifice. Part of what the sacrifice is, is he builds an altar to reorient himself towards what's highest, to remind himself that's what he's doing. And you need to do this periodically in your life. You undertake a particular task, and then the task comes to an end. Well, then what? Well, that's like a little fragment of your personality has made itself fully manifest.
- 2.99 Now what? Well, the answer to that question is, well, you interact with what's highest, once again, in the abstract sense, and wait for the next revelation forward. What should I do next? Well, it depends on what you're aiming at. But let's say you're aiming upward. You wait for the pathway demarcated by that aim to make itself manifest again. And that is how your perceptions work, by the way. This is something absolutely crucial to understand. And I think it's an unassailable fact. The pathway for—your perception is primarily of a pathway forward. Pathway forward with obstacles and facilitators, a pathway with friends and foes, a pathway with agents of magical transformation. That's the landscape of the world.

- 2.100 The pathway forward that reveals itself is dependent on your aim. Now, there's nothing that should terrify you more than that realization. Because what it means is that the world's reality makes itself manifest to you, both perceptually, so at the level of fact, and emotionally, in absolute lockstep with your aim. So Jung said, you better bloody well know what your aim is. That's Jung's injunction to understand the story that constitutes your life. Because unbeknownst to you, you might be playing a very pathological game, which is very unlikely to end well for you or anyone else. That's the unconscious grip of an underlying pathological narrative.
- 2.101 You live in a story. You might not know what the story is. You probably want to learn what it is. Jung, for example, pointed out, like the psychoanalysts were wont to do, that many people live out the un-lived wishes of their parents. That's the story they're encapsulated in, right? Or maybe they're the targets of their parents' hatred and vengeance, and they carry that burden their whole life. And that's the story that structures their existence and within which their emotions operate. What's the story? That's the fundamental question. That's part of what we're investigating, a large part of what we're investigating in this course. Another question?
- 2.102 You briefly touched on objective and subjective reality when you talked about Heidegger and phenomenology. I wanted to know, how do you balance those two things in a concise way?
- 2.103 That's a good question. You do that in part by watching your effect on others. I mean, part of the reason that it's useful and necessary to surround yourself with other people intimately is so that the people around you give you a slap when you've deviated too insanely from the proper straight and narrow path. You might think, and the psychoanalysts are probably, and some of the other clinical psychologists, are probably to blame for this, that you're mentally healthy if your psyche is arranged properly. And that is one way of looking at it.
- 2.104 But really, a more accurate way of looking at it is that you're saying, if you've been socialized well enough so that other people can stand having you around, and then all you have to do is surround yourself with other people, and every time you're too dim-witted, they'll just give you a slap. And then so you outsource the problem of maintaining your sanity. And so if you're tilted too far towards your own subjectivity, your friends, if they're friends, are going to start poking at you with increasingly rough jokes, for example, or your wife is going to turn away from you, or your relationship with your children is going to start to suffer. And so you can watch and listen.
- 2.105 This is also what great leaders do, by the way. They watch and they listen, and then people tell them what their problems are, and then they can figure out how to solve them. That's a great technique if you want to run a family or a life or your business or a country. And so that's the logos in dialogos, is that if you pay attention to what other people are telling you, bounded by tradition, as we pointed out, then you don't have to be that wise. You just have to adjust when necessary. You'll hit the straight and narrow path aided by the others who hopefully have your best interests in mind.
- 2.106 It's also useful, by the way, and I think not only your right, but your responsibility, to surround yourself with people who are on the side of your better angels. Often people don't understand

that they have that right, is that if people are pulling you down, walk away. That's even what's best for them, because someone who's trying to pull you down, who is facilitated in that endeavor, fails to learn that that's not acceptable behavior, and it's seriously not acceptable behavior.

- 2.107** You referenced personal variables like IQ and interest, which we can't control. Do those variables impact our individual ability to transform? And if so, what does that tell us about predestination and individual control?
- 2.108** That's a hard question. That's two hard questions. There's no correlation between intelligence and morality, as far as we can tell. No correlation with agreeableness or disagreeableness. Both those could be elements of morality. No correlation with conscientiousness. So intelligence probably has something to do more with the, what would you say? The rate of possible transformation, both positively and negatively. Remember Lucifer. Lucifer is the archetype of the intellect who worships itself. And he is the worst of all subterranean spirits. And that seems to me to be part of the way that the cosmic balance is, what would you say, established and maintained.
- 2.109** You might be given the talent of an IQ of 145, but that comes with its requisite temptation, which is to presume that you're smart enough to determine the course of the moral order itself, let's say, which is Eve's sin and Adam's sin and the sin of every totalitarian everywhere, always. And so there is a predestinarian element in a sense, but maybe in no more a sense than we walk with two legs. There are principles that govern our existence, and some of those principles are the talents that we've been given rather than earned. In the Gospels, part of the explanation for that is that from those to whom much has been given, much will be demanded.
- 2.110** And so the idea is that, if you are rewarded in a particular way by some stellar trait, that you have a responsibility that, if you don't shoulder, will crush you. And Christ says in the gospel of Thomas that what remains unrevealed within yourself will destroy you. And so that's a hell of a thing to understand, too. So if you are a genius, let's say, and that's God-given, biologically instantiated, let's say, which is really what the evidence suggests, then you better use that properly and not take undue pride in it, or it'll be an enemy of yours so brutal you can hardly possibly imagine it.

3. Navigating the Unconscious

AT A GLANCE

Introduces the psychoanalytic tradition through Freud and his historical context: Victorian sex roles, syphilis, and the unmasking trend that he shared with Nietzsche. Presents the id and the basic drives as subpersonalities that can possess perception and memory, sublimation, and defense mechanisms reinterpreted as lies. Reviews Ernest Jones on Freud's self-analysis, the hierarchy from abstract aims to concrete actions that unites behaviorists and psychoanalysts, the creative illness as descent and reintegration, the functions of the unconscious, repression and trauma, psychosomatic symptoms, free association, and why catharsis alone does not cure.

- 3.1 All right, everyone. So this is the analytic tradition, the psychoanalytic tradition. And we'll concentrate primarily on the originator of that tradition, one Sigmund Freud, and also his most brilliant colleague, Carl Jung, who extended and, I think, improved Freud's magnificent contribution. Freud is a very popular whipping boy these days, perhaps especially among more behaviorally oriented psychologists. But that's partly because almost all the truly brilliant things that Freud discovered are so much now part and parcel of what people take for granted that only the places he was wrong still show up.
- 3.2 Now, there isn't anyone in the modern world who's even vaguely educated, who doesn't take the idea of something approximating the unconscious as a given. Well, to a large degree, we owe that to Freud. And if that was his only contribution, that would be remarkable, a remarkable contribution. It's by no means his only contribution. Now, one of the ways of understanding the psychoanalysts is, as I mentioned in the first lecture, you can think about the human personality as a hierarchically tiered structure, which is the same, by the way, as its representation in the nervous system. And there are approaches you can take that are from the top.
- 3.3 We seem to be organized at the top of our personality, let's say, at the highest strata, according to something approximating a story. Whereas at the bottom, in the micro details, we're organized according to microactions. My ability to do this, trivial as it is in a sense, is, what would you say, is the most differentiated sub-element of my personality. If my personality is expressed in actions, that's the expression of all these motor movements that I'm capable of manifesting. And my personality can emerge upward out of the body, let's say, in its actions, or it can emerge, it can be analyzed from the top down, taking into account the broadest patterns of my life.
- 3.4 The psychoanalysts started from the top down. Behavior therapists, and then in psychoanalytic treatment, the psychoanalysts aim often at a kind of radical restructuring of the personality. And sometimes that can happen when you make a particularly profound realization in your life. The behaviorist types, they usually start from the other perspective, which is, well, is there something small that you can do on a daily basis that would incrementally improve you, that

would lead to an expanding transformation of your ability, your productive ability, and your ability to function in the world across time?

- 3.5 Both of those approaches work. I would say for the typical person, because I was trained as a behaviorist and I knew the psychoanalytic tradition, I had the option with my clients of either approaching them from a behavioral perspective or a psychoanalytic perspective. Almost inevitably, for the, most commonly, I would start with the behavioral approach. It's simpler. But I had people for whom the psychoanalytic approach was more appropriate. They were usually people who are more creative and who are capable of and interested in the investigation of ideas and also in the possibility of dramatic and revolutionary transformation. So there are people for whom that's more suitable.
- 3.6 I suspect, as I said before, that the clients that Carl Jung attracted were like that because he was known for his interest in religious ideas and philosophy and attracted creative people. And they're capable of and interested in revolutionary personality transformations for the typical person. And this is not a value judgment for the typical person. An incremental practical approach is more understandable, more desirable, and easier to implement. But that doesn't mean that the psychoanalysts had it wrong. And there's many things they had right, very right, very seriously right, and we'll investigate some of them.
- 3.7 To understand Freud, it's useful to understand something of his historical background, the time. So the first thing we should understand, because Freud is often dismissed with regards to his hypothetically patriarchal views, which I think is really one of the stupidest generic criticisms that can be leveled at anybody of thought whatsoever. It's just an excuse for not paying attention to the details. You can find the odd misogynist thing, for example, at least apparently misogynist, that Friedrich Nietzsche said in the corpus, immense corpus, of his writings—the same with Freud. And if you're inclined, you can throw out the baby with the bathwater as a mere consequence of that. But it's really not that bright.
- 3.8 The devil's in the details. And thinkers as profound as Freud and Nietzsche, it's very difficult to derive the true benefit from their work, merely in consequence of an overview, and very dangerous to dismiss the, what would you say, the body of work because some part of it displeases you. First of all, you might ask yourself why it displeases you, because it might be you and not the author. Walking through the actual writings is extremely useful.
- 3.9 In any case, Freud did live in a society where the divisions between the sexes were much stricter and harsher than they are now. And that was partly because all protestations about the evil patriarchy, notwithstanding, was primarily because birth control was unreliable. And so the fact, the pill, it's almost impossible to overstate how dramatic a revolution the birth control pill actually constituted. Because before that, the idea of equality between men and women, well, that was just an impossibility, fundamentally, for practical reasons as well as philosophical reasons, let's say.

- 3.10 We also, modern people, we're so daft. We don't understand how much of the fact that men and women can basically play on an equal footing now is a consequence of things that we just take for granted, like the existence of plumbing everywhere. That did more to emancipate. Plumbers did more to emancipate women than all the philosophers in the history of the world. And it's also the same thing, the same is true of the peace that reigns on our streets. Historically, it was almost impossible for women in many societies ever to go anywhere at all without someone masculine and powerful right by their side.
- 3.11 And there's plenty of places in the world where that's still true, because a woman alone was a target for any kind of exploitation imaginable. And that's not the case in the West. And that's because we've spent an awful lot of time civilizing ourselves. And it's been very, very successful. And now we take that for granted, and that's not wise. The sex rules in Victorian England were quite differentiated, and so the issue of sex was already somewhat complex because of that and because of the lack of reliable birth control. But there was another factor that also made the Victorians a more repressive society, which is relevant to why Freud, for example, was so convinced that repression, per se, was at the heart of psychopathology.
- 3.12 Syphilis was a terrible plague in Victorian England. The evidence is that syphilis came to Europe from the New World. Mostly, Europeans exported the worst possible diseases to the New World. Mumps, measles, smallpox killed 95% of the native North and South Americans, even before the Puritans landed, 95%, maybe more. The North Americans returned the favor most effectively in the form of syphilis, which was a terrible plague and could also be transmitted from parent to child, from mother to child. And it manifested itself in a plethora of symptoms, very difficult to accurately diagnose and almost impossible to treat, plus a disease with devastating and terrible degenerative neurological consequences, followed by death. And so the Victorians had their reasons to be uneasy on the sexual front. And so that's all background for Freud.
- 3.13 I think this is from Henri Ellenberger, who is a French-Canadian existential psychologist who wrote a great book called The Discovery of the Unconscious. And if you want to know as much as you could possibly know about the psychoanalytic tradition and its history in one book, The Discovery of the Unconscious is the right book. It's a great book. Remarkable work of scholarship. And he does a wonderful job of detailing out the thought of Freud and Jung and of Adler, who we won't talk much about, Alfred Adler, as well as detailing the history of the idea of the unconscious before Freud formalized it, because there was much speculation about the unconscious before Freud's synthesis, let's say, and exposition of the idea in a most fundamental way.
- 3.14 Freud also belonged to what Ellenberger described as that "unmasking trend, the search for hidden unconscious or implicit motivations characteristic of the 1880s and 1890s. In Freud, as in Nietzsche, words and deeds are viewed as manifestations of unconscious motivations, mainly of instincts and conflicts of instincts." That's a different way of looking at the world than the Enlightenment view or the rationalist view, which would presume that the fundamental drivers of your utterances and conceptions are your attempts to rationally understand the world. The

psychoanalysts, let's say, beginning with Nietzsche—this is a more romantic philosophical trend—insisted instead that your words and thoughts are often handmaidens of your emotions and motivations and, therefore, expressions of your deepest instincts.

- 3.15** Now, I think those views can be reconciled in that, if your words are only the handmaidens of a motivation, then you are immature and driven or even possessed. If your words and utterances are a consequence of the integration of your motivations and emotions at the highest possible level, then you're rational and mature. And so the rationalists are accurate in their claims that people are rational when they're talking about mature and integrated people, but completely inaccurate when they're talking about people whose personalities, people whose personalities are fragmented or who have remained immature.
- 3.16** And we know this in part because of our analysis, let's say, of the brain physiology, but also of cortical maturation. When you're born, you're born in a semi-developed state, especially cortically. A baby is mostly subcortical function. That doesn't have any bearing on whether or not infants are conscious, by the way, because consciousness is a very, very old phenomenon. It's not dependent on the cortex. So in fact, if you take a cat and you take out all of its brain except the hypothalamus, which is just a little cap on the spinal cord, so like 90% of its brain, it's hyper-alert and hyper-exploratory. That's pretty weird. The less brain a cat has, the more awake it is. Right? Weird.
- 3.17** Well, a lot of the brain is inhibitory. A lot of it, especially at its higher levels. It's regulating the expression of underlying motivational states. Now, when a child emerges into the world, parts of it, parts of that person, are wired up. The child's mouth and tongue, for example, are already fully functional, which is why children will mouth everything, but also how they manage to latch onto the nipple and not die. And the child myelinates from the mouth outward and from the center of the body outward, developing the more sophisticated and environmentally specific adaptations that will enable them to function in the particular environment at hand. That's all associated with the maturation of the cortex.
- 3.18** The child comes into the world with certain reflex functions, which we can describe, certain nascent abilities that can expand, but also with a set of a priori motivations and emotions. So with infants, for example, rage is very common. So when infants, for example, develop stranger anxiety and cry when someone other than their mother comes into the room, it's not because they're sad, it's because they're enraged that it wasn't their mother who showed up.
- 3.19** And that was discovered by people using a man named Paul Ekman's schema of facial emotional coding. So you can code the position of muscles in a manner that reliably indicates the underlying emotion and infer, for example, with infants. And if you're around infants at all, you can tell the difference between an anger cry, which is usually, the infant is usually red-faced and the cry is quite penetrating and, what else would you say? Well, angry, if you listen to it properly. People can't listen properly because they never think their infant could be enraged because they're so cute. It's like, no, no, they're completely possessed by rage, 100%, like a

toddler having a tantrum, holding his breath till he turns blue and passes out. Try that. See if you can do it. It's quite the manifestation of instinct.

- 3.20** And so children, this is one of the things that's so fascinating about children, is they cycle through basic motivational and emotional states. They're in one 100%, and then they're in another 100%. They laugh, and then all of a sudden they're crying, then they're hungry, and then they want to play. And it's quite an exciting thing to observe, and it's very dynamic and alive. But there's no higher-order integration of those lower-order motivational and emotional states. It's just now, they're in the now completely. And there is something to be said for being in the now, to be engaged like that. But as a medium- to long-term survival strategy, it's not sufficient, which is why you don't see autonomous bands of two-year-olds roving successfully through the woods. You can't rely on your underlying immature emotional and motivational states to orient you in the world.
- 3.21** That also speaks of something we alluded to earlier, which is the idea that there is an emergent ethic that's something approximating universal. You can't survive if you're run only by the short-term demands of your emotions and motivations. That has to be not so much **repressed** or even inhibited in the **Freudian superego** sense, which we'll discuss, but more like integrated into a pattern of attention and action that does, in fact, satisfy those emotions and motivations, but does so not at the expense of other people and in a manner that ensures the viability of the future as well as the present.
- 3.22** And you can imagine that the cortex is necessary to manage that kind of computation in any given unique human environment, and that it takes a long time for a child to learn how to regulate their behavior so other people like them, which is really quite something to manage and also very useful, and also so that they regulate their behavior, so their present actions don't interfere with their future viability. That's something like delay of gratification, let's say. The capacity for long-term planning, the capacity to engage in effortful work. And that's the opposite of immaturity.
- 3.23** So **Nietzsche** and **Freud** pointed to the fact that words and thoughts were not the rational, the manifestations of the underlying rationality that the Enlightenment types presumed was part and parcel of the human psyche, that they could instead be nothing but the verbalizations of underlying emotions and motivations. If you're talking to someone who's immature and manipulative, you run into that right away. They're always after something with their words. And it isn't peace, and it's not the ability, let's say, the willingness to reconcile in a cooperative and productive way. It's not playful. It's an attempt to do what a two-year-old does, which is to get what they want with their words now. And that's not a pleasant person to be around for any length of time.
- 3.24** So, anyways, it seems like there's a parallel pattern between cortical maturation, let's say, and the emergence of a viable sustaining psychological and social ethos. And it makes sense because how could it be otherwise? It's like, you mature, you put all that effort into maturing, and it signifies nothing and it's pointless? That makes no sense whatsoever. There's a point to the

painful process of learning to regulate yourself. It's also interesting and worthy of note that immature people tend to identify with those motivational and emotional states that possess them.

- 3.25 Because the question might be, you might say to someone, I want this. Nietzsche would object, and Freud perhaps too, that no, something within you wants that that you identify with. And that's not the same thing at all. You know, if you're under the influence, let's say, of aggression or sexual compulsion, you can identify with that urge and make the presumption that that's you. But Freud, and even more particularly Nietzsche, would say, well, why is that you rather than the you that's the force that's, say, trying to regulate your aggression, or trying to integrate or trying to be playful with other people? So, just because a want emerges doesn't mean you're that want. Right.
- 3.26 This is something I think is particularly relevant to the current culture war, because part of the expression of the culture war is the insistence of radically immature and hedonistically possessed people, that their essential self is nothing other than their sexual desire, which is just not a viable identity, as you can tell by the eternal fragmentation of identity in the West. "In Freud, as in Nietzsche, words and deeds are viewed as manifestations of unconscious motivations, mainly of instincts and conflicts of instincts. For both men, the unconscious," the unconscious would be the domain of the instinctual motivations and emotions in this regard.
- 3.27 "The unconscious is the realm of the wild, brutish instincts that cannot find permissible outlets, derived from earlier stages of the individual and of mankind and find expression in passion, dreams, and mental illnesses." So that's one definition of the unconscious, which is, that's like the id as definition, right? It's the, what would you say? It's the operation of the instinctual within. And then Freud's point would be that that instinctual operation can also become perverse. Imagine that sexuality or aggression, because those are the two drives, so to speak, subpersonalities, really, that Freud was most particularly concerned with—those are difficult motivations to integrate into a personality, not least because other people object to your aggression, and they may well object to your sexual desires as well.
- 3.28 And so it's a very tricky problem indeed to allow those proclivities to find their expression, but also to do that in a civilized, socialized manner that allows other people to play along voluntarily. High order of demand, and that can easily go wrong. And Freud's observation, and Nietzsche's, was that fundamental motivational states whose expression are blocked tend to become pathological devils in very short order. And that's very much worth considering virtually forever.
- 3.29 And it's another example of that rule that we discussed in lecture one. If you're gifted with a great intellect, for example, and you take inappropriate pride in it, or you don't carry the responsibility that's attendant upon it, it'll turn against you. And the same is true—this is Freud's fundamental realization, I think—the same is true of any of the fundamental motivational states that are part and parcel of your biological makeup. If you can't determine how to conduct

yourself so that those drives, subpersonalities, are satisfied, they will become your enemies and the enemies of other people, and very powerful enemies indeed.

- 3.30 Now, as **Ellenberger** alludes to here, too, **Freud** also noted, and I believe this is accurate, is that these underlying motivational states that can't find expression in a socialized and acceptable manner do tend to make themselves manifest in fantasies and dreams. Now, you can understand this quite rapidly if you watch yourself, which is something that the psychoanalysts would recommend. So for example, if you're at work and you're frustrated, especially if you've been frustrated repeatedly, there will be fantasies of revenge that flash through your mind, and they're really waking dreams. You can catch the images if you watch.
- 3.31 Now, **Freud** would say you're likely to repress them because you like to think better of yourself. But if you watch, you can see that, and you can play with it. You can even allow it to possess you. If you're angry, there'll be a fantasy that goes along with that. Now, it's very useful to allow that fantasy to make itself manifest, because then you can find out what you're up to. Now, maybe you don't want to be up to that, but your anger might have something to say. Maybe you're being bullied at work. Maybe you're not standing up for yourself properly. Maybe you have a tyrant that's ruling you, and you should do something about that. And maybe that's true of your life in general, because you're kind of a pushover.
- 3.32 And so the vengeful fantasies that your aggression will produce are also guidelines to the pathway of adaptation that should characterize your forward movement. That's part of that **integration of the shadow** that we talked about. Same is true on the sexual front. One of the things that bedevils people in their marriages is their unwillingness to admit to themselves what it is that they want, let's say, sexually, and certainly their unwillingness to communicate to their partner. So men, for example, might harbor the fantasy of their virginal, morally pure wife, which is a lovely fantasy in a sense, but very difficult to reconcile with, let's say, the deepest reaches of sexual desire.
- 3.33 And so men of that sort will unconsciously, implicitly, punish their wives for any manifestation of the sexual desire that they would actually like to have happen, and deprive themselves and her of the sexual adventures they might have if they were both more honest with one another. And so it's very useful. This is that **shadow** analysis. It's very useful to observe what the darker parts of you want because, well, not least because the part of you that is uncomfortable with such things might be exactly the moral coward who's pretending to be moral instead of—the coward who's pretending to be moral in the **Nietzschean** terminology, rather than the person who's actually good because let's say they're absent of aggression or inappropriate sexual desire.
- 3.34 Not wise. Much better to put it on the table and figure out what to do with it than to pretend it isn't there. Living things, including parts of yourself that you tend to extirpate, tend to become very annoyed about that and seek for their revenge. And that's not pretty. It's seriously not pretty. So that'll express itself—this is Freud's observation—in increasingly pathological, let's say, fantasies of aggression, revenge, and sexual conduct.

- 3.35 And I think Freud was right in his emphasis on sexuality and aggression, because those are the two fundamental motivational systems most difficult to integrate into socialized being. They're very primordial, too, both sexual desire and aggression. Especially defensive and predatory aggression are instantiated at very low levels of the nervous system because amphibians have sexual behavior and aggression. I mean, we share the neurological systems with animals way back in the evolutionary chain. And so you mess with those, you fail to make those deep-level impulses manifest at your peril and the peril of others.
- 3.36 "Even the term **id**," the 'it', because that's what **id** means, by the way, "originates from Nietzsche." Freud thought of the **id** as, what would you say, nature operating within you. And you can think about this, well, anger is a good pathway to that conceptualization. You might say, I'm angry, but it's more accurate to say, anger possesses me. And it's more accurate to note that the anger that possesses you is not even actually human, not fundamentally, because have you ever seen an angry dog? Anger is a motivational state that's so fundamental that it transcends the merely human. And so when anger possesses you, you are giving rise to the expression of something that's stunningly primordial and ancient.
- 3.37 And so it's very useful to understand that more even as a state of possession rather than a drive. The behavioral types tended to think of motivational states as drives that made you operate algorithmically or in a rule-bound way under their influence. But that's not accurate. If you're angry, you see the world through angry eyes. Your perceptions themselves are transformed by that motivational state. You know this because sometimes you'll have an argument with someone you love. And while you're angry in the argument, possessed by that desire to win, all you can see about that person, even though you love them, is everything about them that's not good, which you'll inform them about and remember.
- 3.38 And even the memories that come to mind will be specific to your, let's say, anger-induced desire to win and to defeat. These underlying motivational systems are personalities. They're subpersonalities, uni-dimensional subpersonalities, that possess your perceptions, your speech, your memories, as well as your actions. They're not just drives. They're better conceptualized as living forces that are partly you and seriously partly not. That's partly why they're expressed in archaic societies, in particular as deities, right? Like eros. It's like, well, is love a deity? Sexual love, let's say—is that a deity? Well, it's going to be around a lot longer than you, right? You're under its sway rather than being its owner, quite the reverse often.
- 3.39 So even the term **id**, the it, originates from Nietzsche. "The dynamic concept of mind with the notions of mental energy, quanta of latent or inhibited energy, or release of energy," the motivational system as an energetic state, is also to be found in Nietzsche." I would say if you're interested in psychological ideas, familiarizing yourself with the works of Nietzsche is an exceptionally effective way to begin because his thought is so multidimensional and pervasive that it has invaded all the other schools of psychological thought, say, that we're going to analyze.

- 3.40 "Before Freud, Nietzsche conceived the mind as a system of drives," more sophisticated. Nietzsche knew they were personalities "that can collide or be fused into each other." "In contrast to Freud, Nietzsche did not give prevalence to the sexual drive whose importance he acknowledged, but to aggressive and self-destructive drives." Freud also took those into account. He wasn't a naive optimist, Freud, and that's also something to be said in his favor. Freud was one of those people who, like Nietzsche, really did grapple with the darker reaches of the human psyche. And that's brave and useful, especially when you're dealing with people who are trapped for one reason or another in cycles of pathological motivated behavior.
- 3.41 "Nietzsche well understood those processes that have been called defense mechanisms by Freud." They're really a variant of lies, by the way, defense mechanisms, repression as well. Freud secularized that idea, idea of lie, and he transformed it into a more differentiated technical language. But one of the ways of approaching the Freudian hypothesis about the generation of mental illness is that you become mentally ill to the degree that you lie to yourself, sometimes by commission, actually telling yourself lies and striving to believe them, practicing to believe them, which will happen to you if you practice them long enough because you become, even neurologically, what you practice, and even more pertinently, by omission.
- 3.42 A lot of the things that you could know, you choose not to know, because you just don't go there. Now, Freud thought of that as repression, which I think was an error. We do repress things, but mostly what we do is we fail voluntarily to investigate when we're being told to. If you have a suspicion, let's say, about your partner in your marriage, maybe you're wrong, maybe it's you. But if you ignore that, what would you say? The tentacles of that suspicion grow and multiply. Better to face it and confront it. Now, you can easily not do that. All you have to do is not do it. It's very simple.
- 3.43 And so Freud thought of much of what people engaged in that pathologized them as active repression of something they knew. And I think that was a mistake. I think what people actually do is just fail to enlighten themselves when they have the opportunity. And you might ask, why would someone do that? And we already know the answer to that is, if you learn something profound, there's no doubt that it will be painful. And so even though it might work very well for you in the long run, there will be a price, and it's highly probable that you will not want to pay that price in the present.
- 3.44 That's why people sweep things under the carpet and let things go, which, if you're interacting with someone and something annoying happens once, ignore it. Attribute it to the situation. If something annoying happens twice and it's the same thing, you should still ignore it. Give the person the benefit of the doubt. If it happens three times, then you should note it and make the case. And when the person says, "I'm not doing that," you can say, "Well, you did it this time, and you did it this time, and you did it this time. So unless you have a comprehensive explanation for that, it seems likely that despite your protestations, you are in fact doing this."
- 3.45 And then you're on much firmer ground with regards to your investigation, which is going to be painful. And you're also much less likely to fly off the handle, right? Because you might think,

well, you should defend yourself against every transgression. It's like, really? Every transgression? You want to make a mountain out of a molehill? You might want to be sure something is there first. And the rule of three is a good, it's a very good rule of thumb. So it also makes you much better at pursuing your argument because you've got some facts at hand.

- 3.46 I would even say the same thing in relationship to yourself. If you do something stupid once, depending on how stupid it is, you think, well, I had an off day. Three times, it's like, something probably needs some **dissolution and reconstitution**. And that might be extremely painful.
- 3.47 "Nietzsche well understood those processes that have been called **defense mechanisms** by Freud, particularly **sublimation**," which is the direction of a fundamental motivational state towards a higher or alternative end. Nietzsche and Freud thought of artistic creativity, for example, as **sublimation** of sexuality, at least in part, direction of sexuality towards a higher purpose.
- 3.48 And they both thought of that as kind of the redirection of energy, which I think is a, not a sufficiently sophisticated conception. Artistic endeavor. Let's say, a particularly proficient sculptor of nudes, you could imagine someone who's operating in that manner, having access to the nude women, for example, that he chooses to sculpt. And then you might draw the relationship between his artistic proclivity and his sexual desire. But at a more sophisticated level, you might note that there's reason for women to be attracted to men who are highly creative. And that display of creativity doesn't have to be directly motivated by sexuality itself as a drive in order to be highly functional in relationship to solving the problem of, let's say, sexual availability.
- 3.49 So we know, for example, it's one of the fundamental differences between men and women, and it's a big one. The best predictor of male attractiveness to females is their comparative socioeconomic status. It accounts for about 50% of the variance in mate choice, which is a lot. It's a lot. The corresponding number for women in regard to men is zero. Zero is a very small number. Men do not find women attractive in consequence of their comparative socioeconomic status. Zero, right? So that's a huge difference.
- 3.50 So partly what that means is that men can strive to be admirably productive and generous, let's say, and that will make them more sexually attractive, but that doesn't indicate that their productive striving is a direct consequence of the influence of sexual drive per se, even though it's integrated in there and operating as it always does.
- 3.51 "Nietzsche well understood those processes that have been called **defense mechanisms** by Freud, particularly **sublimation**, a term that appears at least a dozen times in Nietzsche's work, **repression** under the name inhibition and the turning of instincts toward oneself. Both give a new expression to Diderot's old assumption that modern man is afflicted with a peculiar illness bound up with civilization, because civilization demands of man that he renounce the gratification of his instincts."

- 3.52 That's a dire prognostication, a dire diagnosis. It's derived in part as well from Rousseau, and Rousseau's idea that the person in the state of nature is the noble and uninhibited savage who lives in harmony with nature. It's complete bloody rubbish in every possibly imaginable way. And that what civilization does is inhibit and suppress and repress and tyrannize. And that's how aggression and sexuality are held in check, let's say. That's only true for people who aren't well integrated into their social community and who are radically immature. If you're well socialized and well integrated, your sexuality doesn't have to be **repressed** because it's integrated.
- 3.53 My son was a very disagreeable young boy. He was tough. My daughter, I could just point at, and she would stop. My son, that was just like round one in a 15-round war, if he was doing something that he wanted to continue doing. Very tough-minded kid. The consequence of his intense socialization was that he was very, very socially adept because he played with the lines that defined social conduct and very competitive, but in a manner that made him a desirable **partner in play**, like a desirable team member. So he could take that aggression and use it productively.
- 3.54 That's not the inhibition of motivation, right? That's the successful integration of a powerful motivational force into a functional personality. That's a much more optimistic view of the relationship between society and man. That's not to say that you can't fall prey to a tyranny of your own making at the hands of your wife or husband or your boss or of the state. But the idea that civilization per se requires the renunciation of gratification, I think that's a very bad idea.
- 3.55 It's another expression of the idea that only power rules, only power and force. It's like, no. And Piaget, in particular, did a good job, I think, of demolishing that claim, showing as he did how, when children develop, they integrate their motivations and emotions in a manner that enables them to play well with others and to be desirable partners in play, and then desirable partners and husbands and wives and fathers and mothers and so forth. So there is a pattern of integration rather than suppression. This is also where Freud went wrong, I think. It's not **superego**, the society within, say, against **id**. That's a model of civilization as tyranny, with the poor **ego** crushed in the middle. It's more the complex integration of these albeit difficult-to-manage motivational states into a higher order, heroically oriented, adventurous, romantic personality.
- 3.56 Introspection and self analysis. We talked about the **creative illness**. This is Ernest Jones, who's Freud's biographer, talking about Freud. "In the summer of 1897, Freud undertook his most heroic feat." Jones, obviously an admirer of Freud, and for good reason. "A psychoanalysis of his own **unconscious**. It's hard for us nowadays to imagine how momentous this achievement was, that difficulty being the fate of most pioneering exploits. Yet the uniqueness of this feat remains. Once done, it is done forever, for no one again can be the first to explore those depths."
- 3.57 "In the long history of humanity, the task had often been attempted. Philosophers and writers, from Solon to Montaigne, from Juvenal to Schopenhauer, had essayed to follow the advice of the Delphic oracle, 'Know thyself,' but all had succumbed to the effort. Inner resistances had

barred advance." What's the point? The resistances that would produce insight but require a sacrificial death, let's say. That's the point of the criticism.

- 3.58 "There had from time to time been flashes of intuition to point the way, but they'd always flickered out. The realm of the **unconscious**, whose existence was so often postulated, remained dark, and the words of Heraclitus still stood: 'The soul of man is a far country which cannot be approached or explored.' Freud had no help, no one to assist the undertaking in the slightest degree. Worse than this, the thing that drove him onward, he must have dimly divined, however much he tried to conceal it from himself, could only result in profoundly affecting his relations, perhaps even severing from the one being to whom he was so closely bound who had steadied his mental equilibrium. It was daring much and risking much. What indomitable courage, both intellectual and moral, must have been needed! But it was forthcoming."
- 3.59 Ernest Jones. Well, is that giving too much credit to Freud? I don't know. It's hard to say. I think it's very difficult for us in the aftermath of Freud's revelations to understand just how significant and revolutionary the formalized hypothesis of the **unconscious** in its multiple dimensions truly was. Freud was pushing back against the Enlightenment claim that in some sense we were transparent to ourselves and fundamentally rational in our orientation. And Freud, like Nietzsche, really devastated that presumption in some ways that were good, in some ways that weren't.
- 3.60 And so Freud is one of those thinkers. Much of the utility of his work is really in the details. You really see this, for example, in his book on dreams, *The Interpretation of Dreams*, which is well worth reading, quite a thick tome and worth reading in detail because it does teach you much that you need to know about analyzing dreams, which, well, if you want to understand the workings of your own imagination or the workings of the imagination in general, it's an invaluable source, not sufficient, but invaluable. And it's a very difficult book, very long, very detail-oriented. And he wrote many books like that. A remarkable person, Sigmund Freud.
- 3.61 So here's a conceptual scheme that will help you understand the relationship between, let's say, the behaviorists and the psychoanalysts, and also the relationship between a, what would you say? A normal everyday improvement in personality or transformation and a revolutionary transformation. Imagine this. So each of these little ovals here is a **frame of reference**. The **frame of reference** is something like your conception of where you are, your conception of where you're going, and the pathways between them. That's the little bubble of the reality that you live in for your perceptions and your emotions. And those exist at different scales of resolution.
- 3.62 So for example, you might want to be a good person. Very abstract conceptualization. How could I be a better person? It's not a very useful question, really. Although if you read something particularly profound, say, *Crime and Punishment*, it might help you become a better person in that psychoanalytically transforming way. It's more practical to differentiate that question. So you can answer it at a micro level and work upwards. So let's do that. How do you be a good person? Well, one possible way is to be a good parent. That doesn't exhaust good, but it

specifies it. How might you be a good parent? Well, you'd have a good job and you'd take care of your family. So that's even higher level of resolution.

- 3.63** How might you take care of your family? You could prepare a meal. And how do you prepare a meal? Well, you cut the vegetables, you set the table, you do the dishes, or you play with the baby. And what do you do to do that? Well, you play peekaboo, or you tickle the baby, or you clean the baby, let's say. You can see how that's moving from the realm of the abstract, be a good person, to the realm of the concrete. If you're trying to teach someone to be a better parent, and they really don't know how, maybe they weren't well socialized, you build them from the bottom up, the micro details. Here's 10 things you need to do to be a better parent. Here's their differentiation into actual perceptions and actions.
- 3.64** That's what you do when you're training children. You have a three-year-old. His room's messy. You say, "Clean up your room, kid." And you go back half an hour later and like, all hell still reigns. And you think, that kid, he never listens. And you don't ask yourself, what makes you think he knows what clean means? At a micro level. I used to work in restaurants and we'd hire new dishwashers, let's say, or line cooks, and they'd be tasked with cleaning the kitchen. And they had no idea what that meant. They had no idea when a pot was clean and when it wasn't and whether the range was clean. You had to teach them to, how you scrub and when something is clean, how to perceive.
- 3.65** If you have a three-year-old in a messy room, you might say, "You see that teddy bear?" And the kid goes, "Yes," because he knows how to see a teddy bear. "Pick it up. Yes. Pat. See the hole in the shelf there, the space?" "Yes." "Take the teddy bear and put in that space." He'll do that. You give him a pat. You do that a hundred times in the room. Then he's built up all the micro-routines that are necessary to know what it means to clean a room. Now, maybe he can learn some of that on his own, but I don't know, did you? Maybe you did. Maybe your household is in pristine order.
- 3.66** Maybe there's things that interfere with that that are psychoanalytically relevant, like you're not aiming up. Or maybe there's elements of your failure that are behavioral. You just don't know the micro-routines. Best bet always when dealing with people is to assume, to begin with, that they don't know the micro-routines, that their failure is a consequence of ignorance rather than malevolence. If it's not ignorance, it might be malevolence, and that's also worth delving into. But that's a consideration and conclusion you might leave for when it's strictly necessary. That's also true with regard to yourself. So this is very useful.
- 3.67** See, you can see the hierarchy here of personality. That's a good way of thinking about this diagram. The closer you get to the micro details, let's say, cut vegetables or set table, the more you're concentrating on something that's literally an action rather than a conceptualization. How does the mind meet the world? How does the mind meet the body? Abstractions ground out in actions. Right, and that's the solution. That's the solution to the mind-body problem. The mind is the realm of abstractions. The body is the realm of embodied action. Well, they unite in that concatenations of goal-directed actions are labeled with abstract conceptions.

- 3.68 Now, part of being a good person is being a good parent. Part of being a good parent is perhaps making the odd dinner and doing it gratefully and properly. And so that whole hierarchy needs to be fleshed out. Now, it's possible, and the psychoanalysts would say this, it's possible to swap a conception at the higher levels of abstraction and to produce a shift in behavior and personality that's quite transformative, sort of all at once. That's what happens when someone says, "I was moved to the depths and transformed suddenly," a flash of illumination. But those are hard to come by.
- 3.69 And it also presumes that you, in some ways, already have those micro-abilities at hand, even though you're not using them. So sometimes I'd have socially anxious clients who were well socialized. They had to remember that they knew how to act. So they'd go to a party and get all self-conscious, partly because they were too concerned with how they appeared to other people and not concerned enough about whether or not other people were comfortable, which is a very great treatment for social anxiety. Try making other people comfortable. That's an unbelievably successful antidote for social anxiety. If you're nervous in a social situation, you're way too concerned about what people think about you.
- 3.70 And that might be because you're doubtful about yourself, but it also might be a mask for a certain kind of egotism. If you try to put other people at ease, that will disappear. So sometimes, when you're dealing with a socially anxious person, they've just forgotten that they know how to behave. They're not making eye contact. They're not implementing the things they actually know how to do because they're nervous. Sometimes you're dealing with someone who's socially anxious, and they just, they don't know how to shake hands. I have lots of clients who I had to teach how to shake hands and say their name.
- 3.71 It's way more complicated than you think. And lots of people do it wrong. They have a hand like a dead fish, and they mumble their name, and they don't pay attention when the other person says who they are, and then they don't remember it. Then they can't get the conversation going. So start at the bottom, work up. Now and then, you can make a radical transformation at the top. It's a very good way of thinking about the relationship between the abstract and the concrete.
- 3.72 This **creative illness** is a descent in reintegration. So here's a way of thinking about it. Imagine that you're going about a given task. So that's your **frame of reference**. You're setting up the world as a place to undertake this task. OK, so now imagine that you fail in one approach, but you have another one at hand. So you're a little anxious because you failed, but you can swap in another approach. Imagine it fails. Now you're a little more anxious because two approaches have failed, but you still have a third possibility. So you swap that in, and it fails, too. So now what do you have to do? You have to reevaluate the whole plan. That's a much bigger descent into **entropy** than moderating one of the micro details. The bigger the plan you have to disrupt, the more **entropy** is released.
- 3.73 So here's a way of thinking about that. Imagine you're married and one of the presumptions of your marriage is fidelity, and that's violated, and that's very anxiety-provoking and destabilizing.

Why? Because the presumption that you know the person, your wife or husband, that you understand your relationship, that you understand your past relationship, and you can map the future together, that's all predicated on the viability of that assumption. You kick that out from underneath, the whole thing falls. So it's very upsetting for that to happen, something you might be likely to turn a blind eye to because you don't want to face the reality.

- 3.74 And so that's a good way of thinking about the difference between a shallow belief and a deep belief. A deep belief is one on which many other beliefs depend. And the fundamental arrangements you make with people are of that sort. When a presumption collapses, that's that **creative illness** that Jones discussed with regards to Freud. You throw everything up in the air, there's a collapse into the underlying **chaos** of various magnitude, depending on how much you threw up into the air. And then with any luck, if you're of the **shamanic** type, let's say, and successful, you emerge out with a new destination in mind and a new way of looking at the world.
- 3.75 And so that's that **descent and reintegration** upon which the world depends. We'll return to this again, particularly when we get into the underlying neurophysiology, because the emotions and perceptions that accompany the perception of aim are very well specified now. We understand them almost down to the neuronal level.
- 3.76 How else did Freud conceptualize the **unconscious**? As a dynamic spirit. That's a good way of thinking about it, something with a certain degree of autonomy. You understand this if you understand how you can be possessed by hunger or you can be possessed by lust or by aggression. You see that that's an active and living force that shapes your perceptions and your memories and your actions and your emotions, for that matter. If you're angry, you can be happy hurting someone you love. So that's a very good indication right there of how dependent even your emotions are on your aim.
- 3.77 Now, you might be conflicted about that, and hopefully you would be. But if you are a person with any aggression and you've ever had any relationships at all, you understand what that means. The Freudian landscape is the psyche and its subpersonalities. That's a good way of thinking about it. It's a very good thing to understand, that you're composed of competing subpersonalities, you know, that are more or less integrated. Some of them are completely alienated. They're not your friends, not least because you've ignored them, you haven't attended to them, you haven't developed them. They react to you like they react to your **ego**, let's say, your integrated **ego**, as if it's an enemy. Because it is. You failed to take something vitally important into account. The psyche and its subpersonality. Freud concentrated primarily on sex and aggression for the reasons that we described earlier.
- 3.78 By 1900, when Freud was doing his main early writing, some of the functions of the **unconscious** had already been well delineated. So how would we characterize the **unconscious**? Well, one way is that it's the repository or dwelling place of these motivations and emotions that can express themselves as personalities. Another is that it's the place where memories that aren't

coming to mind reside. So it's the storehouse of memories. The other place is that it's the place of fantasy. It's the place that produces fantasy and dreams. That's its **mytho-poetic** aspect."

- 3.79** What are the functions? "Conservative: stores memories." "Dissolutive: it's a container of habits once voluntary, now automatized." Different kind of **unconscious**. Here's a way of thinking about that. You know how when you look at a word, you hear it in your imagination? The reason for that is that your eyes are activating part of your auditory cortex. You silent-read with the part of your brain where the visual systems and the auditory systems overlap. Now, if you look at a word multiple times, say a new word, and you say it to yourself, you'll automate that. So now you can hear it in the theater of your imagination without verbalizing. And soon you'll be able to have that happen automatically.
- 3.80** What's happening is, you're utilizing a very wide pattern of neurological activation. And as you practice, that pattern gets smaller and smaller until it shrinks to almost nonexistence, mostly in the back of the left part of your brain. You build a little machine that does that perception automatically. So this is something to also note very carefully because you literally become what you practice, right? You automatize your habits. So that's another reason to be very assiduous about your aim because you don't want to build something dark and unpleasant that operates within you automatically, unconsciously.
- 3.81** You might say, well, do people know what they're doing? Well, they did at one point. They may have forgotten in consequence of repeated practice and now are running like automatons, but that doesn't alleviate their moral culpability, and it certainly does nothing to mitigate the damage they're doing to themselves and others. So part of the reason, again, to be very clear about your aim is to make sure that you don't generate the monkey on your back, you might say, if you're an addict, which is really like a living force within you that's a neurological structure that's got a life and will, that may be working at serious counterpurposes to your welfare, let's say.
- 3.82** "Dissolutive: container of habits, once voluntary, now automatized, and dissociated personality elements, leading a parasitic existence." I showed you that hierarchy moving from action to abstraction. The higher you up, you go in that hierarchy, the more it's like personality rather than action. So personality is an abstraction, but consists of collected actions towards a unified goal. It's a good way of thinking about personality. "Creative: it's the matrix of new ideas." The **unconscious** is the place from which new ideas spring. "**Mythopoetic**: generates narratives or fantasies that appear religious or mythic."
- 3.83** **Freud** also promoted the idea of ideas and emotions as pathogens, that you could have a concept, an abstraction from action, let's say, that has an autonomous existence and works at counter purposes to yourself, and that you could be a veritable storehouse of such things. If you ever meet someone deeply confused, often someone who's never been listened to or attended to, they're a loose collection of incoherent and contradictory ideas. And they'll believe one thing at one moment, like a bad undergraduate essay, believe one thing at one moment and something completely different the next moment. And there's no coherence. And that's a very

unpleasant way of living because something you're doing is going to work at cross-purposes with something else you're doing. There's no success in that.

- 3.84 And so you can easily be possessed by systems of ideas or systems of autonomous, motivated ideas that have their own spirit. This is partly why people get conspiratorial in their political theorizing. A system of ideas has the proclivity to possess and to express itself in action. And so to the degree that you're ideologically motivated and you're ideologically motivated, the same system of ideas has control over your perceptions and your actions. So it'll look like you're conspiring, even when you haven't communicated because the same underlying implicit structure has you in its grip.
- 3.85 That's also a very useful thing to know. It's like, what devils possess you? And you might think none. It's like, yeah, none is very few devils. It's highly unlikely. And it's a terrifying thing to actually begin to understand just how possessed you're likely to be. I would say the default condition is almost total possession. So that's why Jones, for example, regarded Freud's achievement as relatively stellar. It's a terrifying thing to come face to face with your own invitation to possession.
- 3.86 Repression as a source of pathology, another Freudian insight. What is repressed? Unbearable memories, usually sexual. That's not that difficult to understand. Let's take it apart. Imagine that you have an uncle, you're a young boy. Just to make it worse, perhaps worse, you have an uncle. The hypothesis is that the uncle is your father's brother and someone who takes care of you because your father takes care of you because that's what a good father does. And that's like the essence of good itself. And so you turn to your father's brother, and he happens to be pedophilic in his orientation and sexually assaults you and then insists that he's your friend and that you should keep it secret.
- 3.87 OK, just what the hell are you supposed to do with that? What's the right attitude for a five-year-old to take with regard to that? There isn't any possibility of understanding that. First of all, there's this obvious touch of a serious malevolence that's enough to cause post-traumatic stress disorder. Really? People that hypothetically love you can do that? What does that mean about the world? No five-year-old can sort that out. You don't have to repress that for it to have a pathological effect.
- 3.88 And I would say this is where Freud got something wrong, in my estimation, is an event like that just brings a certain development to a halt. It's right, like, how do you trust after that? How do you solve that problem? You have to be one sophisticated moral philosopher to contend with the problem of evil. It's a hell of a thing to ask someone who's five to manage. It's like, what are you supposed to make of the world after something like that happens? You could say, well, it's part of man's fallen nature and our moral—the moral requirement that's laid upon us is to aim upward, no matter what suffering and malevolence characterizes the world.
- 3.89 And fair enough, but that's not something you're going to come up with all by yourself when you're five. And so the traumas that people experience, their deep traumas, that violate very

fundamental assumptions, often bring their development to a halt. And then part of what Freud observed, and I think rightly, was that if you've been hurt in a particular way, betrayed, if you've been hurt in a particular way, things that echo that betrayal in the present will have a more profound impact on you than might be obviously necessary. So if someone's been hurt in a particular way, they tend to be touchy about such things. Unsurprisingly, obviously, but still often incomprehensibly to the people around them.

- 3.90 And they'll tend to assume, if you're married to a woman, for example, who was hurt as a young girl, and you act in a manner that's reminiscent of her victimizer, even in a trivial manner, the specter of that victimizer will make itself manifest in her imagination and be confused with you. And that's a very difficult thing to understand. If you're, if it's untrue, and it's awful, too, because everyone is tainted to some degree, and it's very difficult for someone who's self-aware not to be guilty in the face of such accusation, like guilty for being a man, say, or guilty for being a woman. And there's plenty to be guilty about on both fronts.
- 3.91 And so we know, too, that if you're very badly hurt, your nervous system can become sensitized to that hurt. In fact, the brain areas that deal with that hurt can grow, and the other brain areas that inhibit that emotional response shrink. Now, when you recover, as you can, the inhibitory centers can regrow, but the reactive centers never shrink again. So once bitten, twice shy. And so that's a rough reality as well. One of the things that happens if you've been hurt, betrayed, destroyed, touched by malevolence, and you're traumatized, and you recover, stress can re-instantiate the sensitivity. So, brutal.
- 3.92 **Defense mechanisms.** Here's Freud's elaboration of how people lie to themselves. They repress. If you don't like it, lie about it, especially to yourself. They deny. Well, that didn't happen. The truth isn't so bad. He didn't really mean it. They engage in **reaction formation**. A sibling who's in the throes of intense sibling rivalry with a sister might insist continually, despite all evidence to the contrary, that their abiding sentiment towards said person is nothing but admiration and love. It's a forceful attribution to the self of the moral proclivity that runs contrary to the actuality.
- 3.93 Displacement. My boss yells at me. I yell at my wife. My wife yells at the baby. The baby bites the cat. It's the expression of that proclivity for aggression, but not to its appropriate target. Even animals will do that. If you irritate a cat, which is a very confusing thing to do with a cat, and one of the primary reasons to actually have a cat because they're so comical in that regard. If you play with a cat, tease it a bit, it'll often lash out at something. Sometimes animals will even lash out at their own paw because they get all charged up with anger and it's got to find a source of expression somewhere. And you know how it is if someone irritates you repeatedly, that builds up a charge that wants to be expressed. And then maybe some little thing they said, some little thing emerges that they said, and it's like all hell breaks loose because the whole dam breaks. Yeah, well, that's partly displacement.
- 3.94 Identification. You're bullied as a kid. You become a bully. It's not the only pathway forward. If you're bullied as a kid, you could learn to not bully just as easily, and most people do.

Rationalization. Everybody knows what that means. That's the finding of a reason for what you're doing that has nothing to do with the actual reason, but sounds good. Intellectualization. Woody Allen was a master at that. Smart people can deceive themselves very effectively and invent all sorts of high-flown reasons for, high-flying reasons for what they're doing that have nothing to do with the truth. Sublimation. OK, then I'll sculpt naked women. That's a Freudian joke. Projection. I assume that it's you because I know it's true of me.

- 3.95 Those are various forms of lies. And really, Freud talked about this as repression. I think that was a consequence, really, of his secular bent. He was a lapsed— his Jewish faith had lapsed, and he was a secular Enlightenment intellectual. And so he dispensed with the notion of sin and moral evil. But he replaced that with the idea of repression, and I think really somewhat ineffectively, because all of these defense mechanisms, they're just lies, fundamentally, "just". And lies, well, lies corrupt the world.
- 3.96 And Freud, it would have been better in many regards had Freud continued in the classic ethical tradition and described these processes that generate psychopathology, which is not exactly a medical condition, even though it's now medicalized, described psychopathology as the consequence of ethical perversion of aim rather than something quasi-medical—repression, which it really isn't. It's really lies.
- 3.97 And neurotic manifestations, another part of Freudian theory. Unconscious ideas are at the core of psychological conflicts. Incomprehensible distress. You're way more upset than you should be. Psychosomatic symptoms, right? You're expressing in your physiology. Imagine this, is that you're dealing very badly with something for various complex reasons, right? And the consequence of dealing with that badly is you get more stressed, more and more stressed, right? Your body prepares more and more diligently for emergency action. That puts a lot of pressure on your physiology. You're going to blow out at the weakest point. And in a sense, that's a manifestation of an underlying psychological conflict. But this conflict produces the stress, and the stress makes itself manifest in a physiological manner.
- 3.98 Freud noted, and this does happen, that sometimes people's symptoms seem to have a symbolic relationship to the underlying psychological conflict. It's like they're driven to dramatize what's wrong with them. That strikes me as highly probable, and I've seen it in my psychotherapeutic practice. We act out things when we try to understand them. I mean, that's the primary form of understanding, is acting out. When you're a little kid, you act like your father, you act like your mother, so that you can become them, so that you can understand them. There's every reason to assume that you'd be driven to do that implicitly when you're trying to puzzle out something very, very complicated.
- 3.99 One of the things you'll find if you're married, say, and you're trying to solve a problem that emerges repeatedly in your marriage, maybe your wife reacts to you in a strange manner for reasons you can't understand. She's upset with you or vice versa, and you want to get to the bottom of it. You allow or encourage the person and yourself to say everything they have to say

about their observations of the situation. That's something like the Freudian free association principle. And what you'll find is the constellation of observation circles the problem.

- 3.100** And as you lay them out semantically and you assess them, feel them out, you'll see that some of those hypotheses don't seem to fit the observation that can be dispensed with, and others seem more core or crucial. And then you build around that core of pertinent observations, other observations that flesh out the territory, and you spiral downward in consequence into more and more painful territory until you get to the crux of the matter. And that often involves tears and anger. And then if it's successfully resolved, the resolution, the resolution of the problem, which may appear again, but in lesser form—and if the same process is applied, will attenuate across time.
- 3.101** That's a descent into the unconscious. That's a descent into the underworld. That's a descent into Dante's inferno. So Dante, when he portrayed hell and the journey into hell, put betrayal at the core. That was the fundamental essence of the satanic spirit, was betrayal. And you'll find, if you investigate the pattern of problems that besets you or perhaps the person in your relationship, is that if you get the bloody bottom of things, you'll often find some betrayal. That has to be admitted and strategized through, forgiven, perhaps, accepted, reconfigured in an adult manner before that complex of problems. A complex is another psychoanalytic idea. It's a constellation of symptoms, including emotional symptoms, before that complex will vanish.
- 3.102** It's a very painful thing to do. But if you do it successfully, you only have to do it a couple of times instead of having to suffer from its recurrence for the rest of your life. So it's worth the trouble if you can manage it. This is partly what you're doing in psychotherapy, when you just listen to someone in a free association way. Let them wander. You'll see that their conversation has a thread. It might be very difficult to track because at the beginning, especially if they're people who haven't been listened to, they go way off the track when they're talking. It sounds like random wandering. But if you listen to them, sometimes for hundreds of hours, which is the cost of psychoanalytic therapy, they'll tighten and tighten and get to the point.
- 3.103** They don't know what the point is to begin with. It's something upsetting that's attracting this system of expressed ideas. And often when they get to the bottom of things, they'll cry. They'll have a memory of the source of the problem, and then maybe they have to strategize about how to solve it. And Freud discovered that. That was brilliant. It's a brilliant thing to discover.
- 3.104** We've talked about the id. Id, bottom up, superego, the pressure of society, in the middle of the ego. Freud viewed the ego—you, let's say, your conceptualization of yourself—as this victim in a way of titanic forces, social pressure from the outside world and the pressure of biology from within, you tormented in the middle of those two titans.
- 3.105** You can understand that conceptualization, but I do think it's a conceptualization of the human experience that's derived fundamentally from psychopathology, because if you're a well integrated person, well situated socially, you're not tormented by your id and crushed by your superego. That is the case. That is the experience of someone who's not doing well. They're not

integrated socially. So the external world appears harsh and judgmental, and they can't give expression to their most fundamental longings because they're not adept or for any number of other reasons.

- 3.106** So Freud believed that there was a **talking cure** that emerged in consequence of **free association**. And what Freud believed was that, if you let someone get to the bottom of something and they express the emotion associated with the trauma, that that would be curative. That's wrong, but it's close. Further analysis of the **catharsis** idea has revealed this experimentally. Identifying the source of the trouble is very useful, but you have to think through why the problem emerged deeply enough so that you would no longer be susceptible to it now. And it's that thinking through of the causal pathway to the trauma that's curative and not the mere expression of the emotion.
- 3.107** So if you go to therapy and you do nothing but emote, let's say, with no reconfiguration of practical strategy or perception, there's no evidence whatsoever that you'll improve. And so merely complaining, that's a more cynical way of thinking about it, isn't the pathway to cure. You have to identify the cause or the problem, but you have to identify the cause, and then you have to reconfigure yourself so you're no longer the victim.
- 3.108** Let's say you're traumatized because you were bullied when you were a kid, and that comes to mind, and you understand it. It's like, well, how do you overcome that? Well, maybe you're no longer bullied because you're not small. That might be one reason. Or maybe you've learned to stand up for yourself. And so you walk through that and convince the part of yourself that hasn't developed that that's an unnecessary preoccupation. Or perhaps you haven't learned yet and you're still being bullied, in which case just being upset about the fact that it happened in the past is obviously not going to fix it because it's a problem that still is built into you in a way.
- 3.109** There are bully victims. That's a stable pattern. There are bullies, a stable pattern, remarkably stable pattern, actually, and very difficult to rectify. And there are bully victims. The bully victims tend towards depression and anxiety, towards easy tears as children. The bully types are aggressive and hostile and **sadistic**, and that's very difficult to rectify. If you're a bully victim once, maybe you still are. Maybe not, too. Almost all kids are bullied. Almost everyone grows out of it, partly because you're not little anymore.
- 3.110** Anyways, it's the rectification of the problem that is curative and not the expression of the emotion. But Freud, so often, he's right beside the truth in a very interesting way, and you have to give people credit for that. You're this far from the truth and you get this close. It's like, that's a radical improvement. You can criticize someone for not getting right to the bloody mark the first time. But Freud definitely furthered our understanding of the human psyche and psychopathology in a remarkable way.

4. Integrating the Shadow

AT A GLANCE

Takes up dreams as the royal road to the unconscious, contrasting Freud's repression view with Jung's compensatory view and connecting both to how language models cluster associated images. Explains dream analysis, knowledge embedded in a dream, and religion as the dream of a culture. Lays out Jung's ego, persona, shadow, anima and animus, and self; the shadow's roots in twentieth-century evil; the alchemical dictum that what you need most is found where you least want to look; Job, the bronze serpent, Noah and Ham, and Abraham's promise. Ends with questions on sexual cowardice and on practicing upward aim.

- 4.1 Dreams as "the royal road to the unconscious." Another stellar realization. So cool. Here's a way of thinking about this, I think, that fits in with the Jungian analysis, too. Imagine that there's information coded in the way that people interact, and you understand some of that information, but not all of it, because the totality of the pattern of human action, interaction that you've experienced exceeds your explicit comprehension, right? That's why you're interested in fiction. You can see representations of people's behavior. And by engaging in the enjoyment of fiction, you expand your explicit understanding of human motivation.
- 4.2 OK, so this is what this implies. There's information coded in social interaction. A lot of it. Great dramatists extract out that information and present it to you in an interesting form. Your dreams do the same thing. You encode the manner in which the world operates in image. You don't understand all those images. Not semantically, right. That's why you don't understand your own dreams, which is a weird thing, because you produce them. So why don't you understand them? Where does the information come from if you're not generating it?
- 4.3 Well, imagine that the images, the moving images, code the behavioral, the patterns of behavior, that characterize society, OK? And that supersedes your comprehension. OK, now you have a problem. There's something about your semantic understanding that isn't your verbal understanding, explicit verbal understanding, that isn't serving you well in the world. Well, where could you find new information? Go to the image because the image contains the behavioral information. That's what dreams seem to be doing. You go to sleep. The most common emotion that people express if you awaken them when they're dreaming is anxiety. Why? Because the dreams are trying to flesh out the landscape of the problem.
- 4.4 Now, Freud thought that dreams were a symbolic manifestation of material that had been repressed, and that that's why they were mysterious. But Jung believed that the dream was just doing the best that it could. It's a phenomena of nature. It's part of the way that knowledge reveals itself, first in behavior and then in image. You don't understand everything that happens in a movie. Why would you understand everything that happens in your life? You have representations of things that have happened in your life that you don't understand. That's a source of new information. The dream can enlighten your explicit knowledge.

- 4.5 That's why Jung believed dreams were compensatory, that if you had an attitude and it wasn't working out for you, that your dreams would highlight the contrary position in a way that would illuminate your limited misunderstanding. And I think the Jungian perception is much more accurate. Conceptualization is more accurate and complete than the Freudian perception. I think that dreams do demont themselves upon occasion as a consequence of active repression. But mostly, they're mysterious because they're doing the best they can, right? It's—
- 4.6 I think we understand this now, by the way, as a consequence of these artificial intelligence systems. So I said before that a given word is surrounded by a cloud of words that exist with some high probability in relationship to that word. Right, that's how you understand a word. Witch. Cauldron. Cat. Familiar. Darkness. Swamp. Right? That fleshes out the image of witch. And so if you're trying to develop a deeper understanding, let's say, of the conception of witch, you'd refer to those corresponding words, and then there'd be less, less directly relevant words surrounding that.
- 4.7 Same is true in the world of images, which is why you can go to see a movie, a fictional world, say, like Harry Potter. The fictional representations make sense, and the reason for that is the concatenation of images bears a meaningful relationship to one another. It represents a true statistical regularity. In the large language model mathematics, there are now up to, I think, 2 trillion parameters, 2 trillion terms, in the mathematical equations, insanely complex. It seems to be something like how our brain works, is that we're tracking the statistical regularity between behaviors and images, behaviors and behaviors, images and images, words and words, and then across all three.
- 4.8 One way of fleshing out your understanding of something that you don't or were unwilling to fully understand is to look at the associations that you may have been ignoring. That's partly how Freud and Jung interpreted dreams. And you can do this yourself. So let's say you have a dream and you come to tell me the dream. So the first thing I'll do is listen to the whole dream, right? And then I'll watch for what springs into my mind while you're talking, assuming that the images that you produce have an analogous meaning to me that they do to you, because otherwise there'd be no possibility of our understanding.
- 4.9 So I look and see what I remember because of your dream. And maybe I'll note that down. And it's helpful if you're a dream analyst, to know as much as you can about the symbolic world, about literature and art and religious ideas and the whole world of imagination and art, because that's the domain of the image world. Then I'd ask you, OK, walk through the dream. Tell me the first thing you remember. OK, now see if you can see what comes to mind, what images are associated and what ideas spring forward or emotions spring forward to you. Tell me what they are.
- 4.10 So I'd flesh out the dream on the personal side and then on the archetypal side. And as a consequence of doing that, you can, you have a higher probability of getting to the point of the dream. It's very much what you do if you're criticizing literature, for example. Same idea. And so you're amplifying and investigating the compensatory images that appear to counterbalance the

one-sidedness of your structures of knowledge. And the dreams, that's why part of the reason you dream at night, is to balance yourself out. The parts of the brain that are active when you're dreaming are the parts of the brain that are active when you process anomalous or unknown information.

- 4.11 So it's like the absolutely unknown, about which you can say nothing. Right? Then it's the dream, then it's the poem or the piece of art. Then it's the philosophy, then it's the explicit understanding. That's the pathway that knowledge takes when it emerges out of nothingness. And Jung was the person who figured that out, that the dream was the intermediary between conscious, consciousness and the absolutely unknown. Right? The, what would you say? The wisdom storehouse of the gods, the dream.
- 4.12 And Freud—Freud laid the groundwork for that, partly with his free association technique, because he would do that with dream analysis. Tell me the dream. Tell me what comes to mind. If you're interested in investigating your dreams in a, let's say, what would you say, disciplined manner, one of the things you can do is track them across time. Write down your dreams in the morning. You're much more likely to remember them then, and then before you go to sleep, just in that time when you're, when images are starting to come into your mind, it's just before you fall asleep—hypnagogic state, it's called—you can remember the images that were associated with the previous dream and then let that develop. And sometimes the dream will continue in the same vein and move towards, you know, its next realization.
- 4.13 Now, some people are, I had people in my clinical practice who were stunningly coherent dreamers. I had one client who, man, he'd remember enough dreams per night to talk about them for, like, three hours. Every night. Very, very detailed, coherent, sophisticated dreams. It was a genius-level dreamer. I had clients who could become conscious at will in their dreams. That's where they call that lucid dreaming, which is a skill that you can learn, by the way. There's books on lucid dreaming. LaBerge, Stephen LaBerge, wrote the first experimental books on lucid dreaming.
- 4.14 So the dream is the theater of the imagination, right? And Jung's hypothesis was that it compensated the inadequacies of the conscious mind. Fantasy compensates for a too-narrow reality, which is why we escape into fantasy when our realities become too narrow, and why we can turn to our fantasies, to flesh out our self understanding and our knowledge of our own desires. So.
- 4.15 Jung was influenced by Nietzsche even more than Freud. Freud's thought had parallels with Nietzsche, but there wasn't a lot of direct influence. It was more indirect. Jung knew Nietzsche's work well, and so Jung is best regarded, in my estimation, as a hybrid student of Nietzsche and Freud. And it was Jung who really discovered the means whereby the imaginative productions of the unconscious and the dream state could be allied with investigation of the realm of mythology and religion. So Jung believed that a religious system was the dream of a culture, and it's a stunningly brilliant hypothesis, radically underappreciated.

- 4.16 So, there are things you know, right? And there are things you don't even know you don't know. Right? They're way out there in the yonder, in the beyond, right. Now, you could imagine that there's a clear demarcation—things you know, boundary; things you don't know. Or you could imagine that one shades into the other. That's a much more accurate representation, right? There are things you kind of know. There's things you barely know that you're beginning to apprehend.
- 4.17 So what's the structure? Specific semantic knowledge, very highly defined, like the center of your visual field. When you look at the world, what you directly look at is very high resolution, and around it everything is increasingly vague until it disappears. So if I look at you, your eyes, I can't see the eyes of either of you unless you move them. And yes, as soon as you—try that. It's so weird. It's such a weird phenomenon. Look at my finger. Here. Try this. Look at my finger. But pay attention to my eyes, OK? It's a hard thing to do without looking at them. But don't look at my eyes. Look at my finger. OK.
- 4.18 You see that? So how does that work? The sides of your eyes are like a frog's eyes or a dinosaur's eyes. They can only see, that part of your eyes can only see what moves. Why? Well, you should probably pay attention to what moves, right? Because it'll jump on you. Right? And so the farther out you go in your peripheral vision, the more you're detecting prey, predators. Right. And so there's more negative emotion associated with your peripheral vision. The center of your vision is very tightly focused. The periphery fades into nothingness.
- 4.19 Out here, let's say, you see in black and white, even though you can't tell that. You've got no color detection at the absolute periphery of your vision, and you actually aggregate the world by taking snapshots with your fovea, which is very highly innervated. Anyways, your conceptual systems are very much similar. At the center there's a, what would you say, a very differentiated field of semantic knowledge, the things you know and can explain. OK. Outside of that, there are what? The things you intuit and grip, maybe in fantasy, the things you only dream about? So, what you know is embedded in a dream, and the dream shades out into what you don't know at all. And that's the human cognitive landscape.
- 4.20 The same applies to cultures. There are cultures have their explicit knowledge, their scientific knowledge even, but they're embedded in a dream. They have to be. That dream is the religious substructure of the culture. Brilliant. It's so brilliant. It's such a brilliant realization, right? So stunningly underappreciated, that—see, because you have to be able to contend with things you only sort of understand, right? So how do you do that? Well, you do that with fantasy. You do that with fiction. You do that with mythology and literature, and partly you act it out. That's what an actor does. Or a dramatist. You act out the things you still can't understand completely. You imagine them.
- 4.21 And that also makes the dream the birthplace of new ideas or the vision or the theater of imagination. And of course, that makes perfect sense, because we know that our imaginations are the handmaidens of our discovery. You fantasize about it. That's where you get hypotheses. You're wondering about something, wondering, wondering about something, right? And

something comes to mind. It emerges out of the imagination. It becomes clearer and more coherently formulated. It springs out of the whoa. It springs out of the void. Just like this clicker, apparently. So, and that's how knowledge progresses.

- 4.22 And the Enlightenment types believed that we could detach our explicit semantic knowledge from that dream and dispense with it. And that's not the case, because the dream is actually the foundation of our knowledge. Our knowledge only retains its validity within the confines of a shared dream. So when the **Tower of Babel** is erected in the Old Testament accounts, it's the construction of presumptuous engineers aimed at deifying themselves. The consequence of that is that everyone comes to speak a different language, right? Words no longer maintain their referent. The only reason that the words I use are understandable by you is because we're embedded in the same dream. And if we dispense with the dream, the words themselves cease to have the same meaning. Not good. Or if the dream becomes pathological.
- 4.23 All right. How did **Jung** characterize the field of personality? His definition of the **ego** was really something that was approximately equivalent to how you do conceptualize your personality. **Jung** didn't use the **ego**, **superego**, **id** conceptualization. **Ego**. That's the real you. **Persona**. That's the mask that you show the world. Remember in the story **Pinocchio**, when **Pinocchio** first goes out on his big adventure, his first temptation is to become an actor, right? To become a showman. Someone who isn't what he claims to be, but is using that mask to gain unearned status and purchase on the world. That's the temptation of the **persona**. The **persona** means mask.
- 4.24 **Jung's** fundamental claim was that most people think they're their **persona**, right? So most people confuse themselves with the face they show the world and try to convince others that it's real. So what do you discover from the **Jungian** perspective, once you peek beneath the hood of the **persona**? That's an investigation of the **unconscious**, both personal and **archetypal**. The first thing is the discovery of the **shadow**. It's like, you're a lot worse and better than you think you are. And probably the way to discover that is to discover first how you're worse. So, how do you do that?
- 4.25 Watch your fantasies and admit to them and see just what's there. Watch your resentment, your bitterness, your proclivity to deceive yourself, your undeclared motivations, your jealousy. All the things that make your countenance fall. That's the fate of **Cain** when he's bitter because his sacrifices are rejected by God. Who are you, really? Why did **Jung** investigate this? Partly because he was obsessed by what happened in the 20th century. Right? That radical expression of evil that characterized the arguably most civilized state in the world. If you regard Germany in that light and there's some reason to.
- 4.26 What the hell happened? How did these ordinary people turn to be, turn toward such a deep malevolence? It's like, maybe they weren't so nice to begin with. And maybe if you presume that you are that thing you show everyone else, you're precisely the sort of person who can be tempted by that darkness when it makes itself manifest. No apprehension whatsoever of your

own capacity for evil, which is, from the Jungian perspective, sufficiently profound to really be soul-shattering.

- 4.27 When Christ is crucified and descends, part of his shamanic mission, you might say, is the harrowing of hell. The story of Christ is an archetypal tragedy. It's a story of the full encounter with the catastrophes of the world. Malevolence. Sorry. Mortality, pain, betrayal, suffering at the hands of the mob, right? The worst of all possible unjust deaths. But that's not bad enough. It's followed by the harrowing of hell. What does that mean? To live fully in the world, you have to encounter and accept all the painful aspects of your mortality and the full realization of the human capacity for evil.
- 4.28 A brutal requirement, right? And one that requires everything from you. Right? And so that encounter with the shadow, that's the plunging into the depths. That's to regard yourself as the concentration camp guard who really enjoyed his work. And you think, not me. It's like, really, not you? You're so certain of that, that in that situation you would have been, what? The rare hero who dared to rescue the Jews at the peril of their own skin? Not bloody likely, certainly not statistically. And so if you're not that person, just exactly who are you? Are you the person who just turns a blind eye when terrible things are happening? Or are you the sadistic person who avidly jumps in there and really has quite a gay old time?
- 4.29 And so Jung was very interested in the idea of the shadow and the persona because of what World War II had revealed about the structure of the human psyche, civilized though it may be. Now, he discovered some interesting things in relationship to that inquiry. One of the things that Jung posited was that in the parts of you that you refuse to recognize are unrevealed possibilities about who you could become. So, for example, perhaps you're a chronically nice person. You avoid conflict. You don't do a good job of defending yourself. You live for others. And the aggression that you could be capable of manifesting only makes itself known as resentment. And you discover the existence of that resentment, and you take that aggression and you start to integrate it into your character.
- 4.30 Well, in the case of a woman, so we'll use that case, that would masculinize you to some degree, right? It would help you incorporate the contrasexual elements of your personality that might be part and parcel of your implicit psyche that hadn't been fully developed as you were socialized, and that wouldn't interfere with your femininity, let's say. It would just add another dimension to it. It would flesh out your personality.
- 4.31 Same thing is true on the masculine side. Hyper-attractive men often have feminine characteristics. You know, you see that in people like Joaquin Phoenix, for example, who's got that kind of feline grace that isn't, that is reminiscent of femininity, but just exaggerates his attractiveness. There's medieval speculations that the ideal person is hermaphroditic, in a sense, taking the best of femininity and the best of masculinity, and uniting them.
- 4.32 Jung's hypothesis was that, as we throw out parts of our personality or fail to develop them because they don't comply with social norms or with how we want to present ourselves to the

world, we dispense with what much of what is good. And he learned that from Nietzsche, who proclaimed in his writings that the task of the future men and women would be to revalue good and evil, and to restructure the manner in which they oriented themselves in the world. A dangerous supposition, but one that has a certain utility. It's like, are you everything you could be? Well, one answer to that is, well, how much of your life is characterized by pointless suffering? Because that might be an index of your inadequacy.

- 4.33 And then let's say, well, if you decided that you were going to bring everything to bear on the task at hand, where would you gain the additional strength and courage that would flesh out your personality? Jung's hypothesis was, look where you don't want to look. Why? Well, you've already looked where you want to look. And if you're missing something, it's likely to be hidden where you've refused to look, right? That's the fundamental dictum of alchemy, which Jung devoted his life to studying. *In sterquiliniis invenitur*. What you need most will be found where you least want to look.
- 4.34 That's the *hero myth* in a nutshell, right? The greatest treasure is guarded by the worst of all possible dragons. So you look within, in the Solzhenitsyn sense, right? "The line that divides good and evil doesn't run between people or states, but down the heart of every individual." To discover that in yourself and to find out, this is a useful thing to know, because you're worse than you think. You should be a lot more careful with what you do, right, and I don't, what does it say? The beginning of God is the—the fear of God is the beginning of wisdom. Why fear? God only knows what you're capable of, right? By omission or commission. And if you really became aware of that, you would be a much more careful person.
- 4.35 And if everybody was careful in that manner, and this was Jung's hope, then we would be much more immune to the kind of pathologies that possess Germany, let's say, and the Nazis and the Soviet Union and the Maoists, those pathologies of ideological possession that come sweeping in and carry everyone away in their idiot *enthusiasm*. Right? You have to regard yourself as the locus of the evil in the world, and that's a walloping thing to undertake, you know. So, Jones complimented Freud on his courage with regards to his investigation into the *unconscious* and its implicit structures. But Jung is to be commended for identifying the source of, I would say, Luciferian evil within the human soul.
- 4.36 Very, very serious material indeed. And I think part of the reason that his work hasn't had more impact on the academia, on academia in particular, is because as soon as you start to understand what he's talking about, you're going to be highly motivated to close the book and do something else.
- 4.37 So now, Jung on the positive side, and this is another representation of the, of the *shamanic* story, is the descent into, no, the ascent to the highest place is preceded by the descent into the lowest abyss. And that's a good thing to know. It's like, why bother investigating the dark side of things? Maybe so that you can become the master of the dark side of things. Maybe so that the dark side of life no longer intimidates you, or at least doesn't intimidate you to the point where

you lose your moral virtue in your cowardice. Right? And so you look at what's darkest, and you do that voluntarily.

- 4.38 And the consequence of this, and I believe this to be true physiologically, is that you will develop into the sort of person who can withstand that exposure. So we talked earlier about the different psychophysiological pattern that characterizes your being, if you voluntarily undertake a challenge rather than have it inflicted on you. OK. So now imagine that you practice that voluntary exposure. Now you embody that pattern of reaction more and more habitually. So it starts to become built into you, right? Because you become what you practice.
- 4.39 OK, built in at what level? If you undertake new adventures—so you live on the edge—new genes turn on inside you. So in your genetic code is a repository of possibility, which will not be coded on unless you put yourself in a situation that challenges you, such that that revelation of possibility becomes necessary. That's true all the way down to the molecular level. So imagine that you conducted yourself in this shadowy manner, so that you were attending to everything that terrifies you and others in the most diligent possible manner. That turns you into the sort of person who can do exactly that.
- 4.40 And so, then what? Then what? What does that imply? That you can handle anything that comes your way. Right? At least without becoming corrupted. And maybe in a manner that's useful to yourself, maybe even a manner that's grateful. Job, in the story of Job, Job is tormented by God and Satan, right? Job is regarded by God as a good man. And Satan comes along and says, "I don't think he's so good. I think he's just lucky." And God says, and Satan says, "Why don't you just give him to me for a little while and we'll see if he rejects you?" And God says, "Yeah, I don't think he will. Have at 'em."
- 4.41 And so Job loses everything, right? Everything collapses around him. He doesn't deserve it. His children die. His businesses are demolished. He gets a terrible disfiguring disease. He's sitting in the ashes, and his friends come along and tell him how he deserves his fate. And Job's response, magnificent response, is, number one, to point out to himself and the observers and God that his ignorance is total about the fundamental meaning of things, and that he has no right to judge existence in its essence, regardless of what happens to him, that he determines that he'll maintain faith in his own fundamental character and in the spirit of being itself, no matter what happens to him.
- 4.42 And he manages that. It's a remarkable moral achievement. And the consequence, by the way, is that he gets back everything he lost and more. You know, and you might say, well, the ends don't justify the means, let's say, with regard to God. But part of the story is, if you don't lose faith when the trials of fate come your way, God only knows what vistas of possibility might open up in front of you.
- 4.43 I'll tell you one more story on the Jungian side to close this off. This is something truly remarkable and the kind of thing you learn if you throw yourself into Jungian, into the Jungian analytical world, which opens up the meaning of great literature in a bottomless manner. And I

think partly does that by highlighting the associations between literary themes that are universal, in the same way that AI language model systems do it.

- 4.44 There's a scene in Exodus. So the Israelites are making their way to the Promised Land. So they're on a journey. They're going from point A to B. They have a destination in mind and it's upward, right. And they've wandered through the desert, which they encountered after dropping their tyrannical presuppositions. And they've been lost for generations. And now they're finally, they're finally on the edge of attaining their end. But they lose faith. They lose faith, and they revert to a kind of immature bickering and complaining. And they long for the reliable and secure days of the pharaonic tyranny. And they accuse [Moses](#) and his compatriots of being nothing but tyrannical powermongers who've led them astray.
- 4.45 And they've done this multiple times while they're lost, wandering stupidly through the desert. And God and [Moses](#) are both kind of tired of it. And so God sends snakes amongst the Israelites, poisonous snakes to give them a good biting. And you might think, well, that's kind of cruel, because they're already having a rough time. And why make it worse, especially if you're God? And the proper rejoinder to that is, people have free will, and there's always something stupid you can do to make a bad situation worse. And the Israelites are definitely doing that, and they know it.
- 4.46 And so in come the snakes and biting them like mad. And after they get good and tired of that, which I suppose takes a while given their intransigence, they go to [Moses](#), whom they know to have a pipeline to God, and they say, "Do you want to see if you can get the big guy upstairs to call off the snakes?" And [Moses](#) says, "Well, I'll see what I can do." And he goes and has a conversation with God.
- 4.47 And God says, "I don't think I'm going to get rid of those snakes, but I'll tell you what I'll do. I'll tell you what you can do. You gather up all the bronze that the Israelites have in their possession. You make a gigantic staff like the staff of [Moses](#), which is the staff of tradition, and you put a serpent on that, a poisonous serpent, and then you have the Israelites go look at that. Gather them around so they can see it and gaze at it. And then the poison of the snakes will no longer affect them."
- 4.48 OK, so what's the idea, now that state, staff with a symbol around it? We already said that's the symbol of healing. A little of the poison that kills you protects you. If you gaze upon the things that are terrible and challenging, you become immune to their poison. That's the message of that story and more. God is constituted such that he would rather make people strong than safe. That's a definition of God, by the way. The paternal spirit that would rather make his children strong than safe, right? That's emblematic of that story. Take the Israelites who were being poisoned by their own iniquity. Have them contemplate what's poisoning them, and they will become stronger in consequence. OK, so that's a remarkable story of the beneficial consequences of voluntary exposure, right? But there's more to it.

- 4.49 This is miraculous and mind-boggling, I think, both at the same time. Christ himself in the Gospels says to his followers that the world can't be redeemed unless he's lifted up like the serpent in the desert. Now, this is a very strange thing for someone to say. It's like, what in the world does that possibly mean? Why make that oblique reference to something that happened thousands of years previously, especially something so strange? And what possible connection could there be between the crucified and resurrected Redeemer and the snake in the desert that the Israelites gaze upon?
- 4.50 OK, so now imagine this. And this is an indication of the way that a culture is embedded in a dream, like your psyche is embedded in your imagination. For 2,000 years, the symbol of the crucifix has been at the center of our culture. It's been what people are gazing upon. OK. What's it emblematic of? The Jungian take on that. The story of Christ is an archetypal tragedy. What does that mean? Take the set of all possible tragedies. Every tragedy has something in common, right? That's what makes them all tragedies. Take that common element out of all the specific tragedies, and make a generalized tragedy that's emblematic of tragedy itself, so that the essence of tragedy is encapsulated in the story.
- 4.51 What would that be? The worst possible suffering inflicted on the most innocent possible person. Right? The essence of tragedy. OK. Is that bad enough? No. Because exposure to mortality isn't sufficient. In the Christian passion story, there's the mythological insistence of the harrowing of hell. It's not only that you're called upon to face the catastrophe of existence on the tragedy side, you're also compelled to face it on the malevolent side. Right. What's the consequence of that? You become immune from the poison. Right. That's the heroic journey into the heart of darkness. Right. To fortify yourself at every level of your existence simultaneously.
- 4.52 And we know, like I said, we understand the physiology of this at quite a micro level. Now, it's definitely the case that you're a different person when you take on challenge voluntarily. How different? All the way down to the microscopic. Right? From the highest levels of the spirit, all the way down to the molecular, you can literally transform who you are. How thoroughly? God only knows, right? What's the ultimate extent of your potential manifestation of a personality, if you flinch from nothing. Well, that's what you're here to find out, right? And that's the core message of the Jungian analytic narrative. Revolutionary.
- 4.53 The Postmodernists, right, the literary critics—they made the assumption, as I indicated in the introduction, that there's no uniting metanarrative. The thinkers of the Jungian school, including Mircea Eliade, said something different. They said, no, no, that's not true. The motif of voluntary self-sacrifice and exposure to darkness is the, is the uniting metanarrative. And it's not arbitrary at all. It's true at multiple levels simultaneously, and it is the fundamental redemptive story. And so, Paglia, Camille Paglia's response to that, because she understood it and is a very rare intellectual in that regard, was that, had the French literary critics turned to Eliade and his school, the Jungians, let's say, for their interpretation of the literary canon, the culture war would have never occurred.

- 4.54 Right. Because we would have united our understanding of our own stories with our own tradition, and carried on without the fractionation that's characteristic of, what would you say, a kind of hedonistic, blind, arrogant secularism, and its casual— what would you say? Casual, derisive, derisive contempt for the past. I can say something about that too. When Noah lands the ark, he's an agriculturalist. He plants a vineyard and he raises his first crop of grapes and he proceeds to get rip-roaring drunk.
- 4.55 And you can imagine why, right? Having lived through, having shepherded his family through the ultimate cataclysm, you know, it's time for a break. And so he drinks too much and he ends up in his tent, splayed out naked, and his son Ham comes along and gets a glimpse of his father and thinks that's pretty damn comical, and then brings two other brothers, Shem and Japheth, if I remember correctly, to have a laugh at his father's expense. But when they come to the tent, instead of laughing, they take a blanket and walk in backwards and cover their father up.
- 4.56 Then he awakens and he says to Ham, "I know what you did." He brings his three sons together, and he says to Ham, the faithless son, "Because of what you've done, your offspring will be the servants of my other sons' slaves in perpetuity." Why? Because those who deny the validity of the past will end up the servants of slaves. Right. And that's what we're doing in the West, at least from the Jungian perspective. We've divorced ourselves from this underlying tradition, which isn't arbitrary and which isn't superstition. Quite the contrary.
- 4.57 And in consequence, we've elevated ourselves to the highest possible place, and we risk the dissolution that goes along with that. And that's what's happening. Arguably, that's what's making itself manifest in the culture war that insists that all truths are relative, that, what? That there's no hierarchy of values, that merit is illusory, that nothing but power reigns, that there's no uniting metanarrative, and that the God whose worship established the Western tradition is dead, and finally so.
- 4.58 It's like, quite the contrary from the perspective of the deepest of analytic thinkers. It's like, there's no more profound truth than the security. The integrity of your psyche and the security of society depends on your willingness to hoist the most difficult burdens onto your own shoulders and to walk uphill, regardless of the cost. Right. Well, that's a, what would you say? A shallow introduction to the stunning depth of the analytic tradition. Now there are endless volumes of material, Eliade perhaps in the highest echelons of those writers. Erich Neumann, Carl Jung, whose study is so illuminating that it's an absolute mystery that everyone doesn't just do it all the time.
- 4.59 So I'll end with this, the last archetype. Shadow. Anima, animus. So what's unconscious in a woman is the potentiality for her masculinity. And what's unconscious in a man is his potentiality for the development of the feminine elements of his personality, the expansion of personality into the contrasexual domain. What's the image of totality? That's the archetype of the self. The self is, the self is who you could be if you were everything you could be. Jung, this is a fascinating idea. One of the most brilliant things he conceptualized and such an optimistic idea.

- 4.60 So imagine the self exists as the totality of your potential. And you might say, well, what sort of reality does that have? Because it's only potential. And Jung's answer to that was, the potential of the self calls to you and appeals to your **conscience**. So as you're making your way through life and something grips your attention and compels you to investigate, that's the attempt by the thing you could be to lead you down the pathway to become exactly that, and it makes itself manifest in your own life by what grips your attention autonomously.
- 4.61 And that's exactly the same thing that calls **Moses** off the beaten track when he encounters the **burning bush**, right? Which is the symbol of life itself, with the divine in its depths. It's a remarkable thing to think, that the, the things you encounter that grip your attention and compel your interest and pull you forward are manifestations of the spirit that's attempting to transform you into everything that you could be.
- 4.62 And then you think, well, how could it be otherwise? I mean, is your counter-hypothesis that you're compelled, by what? By what? By what? By what has no bearing on your development? You'd think that was true of children. Aren't children interested in exactly the things that lead them out into the world and make them more competent and more developed and more mature, more reliable, more curious, more grateful? Why would it be different for you?
- 4.63 And the promise that God makes to **Abraham**, which is a remarkable thing. Here's the promise. God comes to **Abraham** as the spirit of adventure, right? The **calling** to adventure. And God makes **Abraham** a deal. It's a remarkable deal. He says, look, if you leave your zone of comfort, if you leave your infantile security—because **Abraham** is the child of wealthy people and doesn't have to lift a finger—if you go out into the world and have your terrible life, here's what will happen. You'll become a blessing to yourself. That's a good deal and a rare thing. You'll become a blessing to yourself in a way that will make your name justly renowned among your peers. That's a good deal, right? To have that social appreciation surround you and to know that it's actually valid?
- 4.64 Not only that, you'll do that in a manner that will allow you to establish something of enduring significance. That's why **Abraham** is the father of nations, right? He establishes a dynasty because his pattern of being is emblematic of the successful father. And not only that, you'll do that in a way that will be of optimal benefit to everyone else. And so the calls line up. If you follow the spirit of adventure that pulls you towards your **quest**, then your personality expands. Your being transforms upward to the point where you're something qualitatively different from what you are. That will reveal itself in a manner that makes your life a blessing to you, that makes you renowned, that establishes something permanent, and that does that in a manner that's maximally beneficial to everyone else. That's a good deal.
- 4.65 And what's the cost? **In sterquiliniis inventur**, right? Face what you avoid. Pursue the darkness, in search, in faithful search of the light. That's the heroic tradition, the personality that makes itself manifest. The personality that compels that is the self; the personality that makes itself manifest in reality, in consequence of that **quest**, is the incarnation of that self. Right.

- 4.66 So I'll cap that with one observation. The pattern of Christ's life is voluntary encounter with mortal tragedy and malevolence. Christ represents himself as the incarnation of the spirit of the law and the prophets. And so what does that mean archetypally? The law is the tradition that stabilizes and constrains. The prophets is the prophetic voice that established the law and that updates it. The combination of those two embodied is the force of personality that enables someone to voluntarily shoulder the burden of existence and to face evil and prevail. Right. That's the hero's journey and the manifestation of the self.
- 4.67 So I know that you've talked in the past about, like, the Machiavellian, I guess, traits that someone upholds when they're using people for sexual gratification.
- 4.68 Yeah.
- 4.69 And I feel like there's some overlap between the, like, the, like, what you were talking about with, with Freud and like, sexual cowardice and things along those lines. So I feel like there's some middle ground between, like, sexual cowardice and, like, looking for something meaningful. And I was wondering if you had, I don't know, any thoughts on that or how you'd, like, flesh that out, because you know what I mean? In one aspect, like, I know that, like, there's truth in saying that utilizing people for, how do I say it, for sexual gratification is a, you know, a negative thing all in all. But at the same time, like, you can't hide yourself from that altogether.
- 4.70 Right, right, right. Well, this is why people like Andrew Tate are particularly attractive to the so-called incels, right? OK, so here's a Nietzschean observation. Most morality is cowardice. OK, so what does that mean? It doesn't mean morality is cowardice. It means that people cloak their cowardice in the guise of morality to justify it to themselves. So then let's say you take the typical sexually frustrated young man, who is the typical young man, by the way. And so he says to himself, my unwillingness to sleep around is a consequence of my moral virtue.
- 4.71 It's like, no, it's not. You have no opportunity. If you had the opportunity, you would throw yourself into it. Because that opportunity isn't there, you don't. And because you're ashamed that you can't and don't, you justify your own inability, even on the pathological side, to yourself and call it morality. Right. That's a low form of existence. Then you have someone who's on the more psychopathic side, let's say, like Andrew Tate, who is an electronic pimp with women at his disposal, so to speak. And the incels think, that looks like a pretty good deal. And the perverse thing is, they're right because they're in a lower level of hell than he is. Right? Because they would be what he is if they could be. But they can't. So they're like failed psychopaths.
- 4.72 Well, is a failed psychopath a better person than a successful psychopath? I mean, they're both nothing to admire, but it's not obvious at all that the failure is on a higher moral plane than the success. This is part of that attractiveness of the shadow. You know, if you're—I'll give you an example. If you look at adolescents, imagine there's a distribution of adolescents. Some of them break rules all the time, and some of them never break rules. And then there are the kids in the middle. And then you might ask, well, where's the best place to be? And you might say, well, with the kids that never break rules. It's like, no, those are kids who are so temperamentally

inhibited for one reason or another that they're dependent and they're prone to depression and anxiety as they develop.

- 4.73 They're not good. They're just terrified. And so they do nothing. And then there's the kids on the other end of the spectrum who are just breaking rules all the time. Antisocial types. That's bad long-term outcome and very stable. The kids in the middle, they experiment, right? Which means sometimes they're not exactly as good as they should be. But if you're a good parent, don't you hope that your kids will have the sense to break some rules now and then intelligently, to experiment and to gain knowledge? Well, of course you do. And you hope that they have enough courage so that they test the rules to see if they're real and necessary, and don't just kowtow to them out of their cowardice or inability or fear.
- 4.74 And so, on the sexual front, which was the more specific question, having no one at your disposal is failure. Having people at your casual disposal, well, that's the successful integration of a certain degree of shadow. Is it optimal? No. Right, it's still, it's still a form of dwelling in the darkness. But all things considered, it's probably preferable to the first category. Right. And this is, I think you can see this, by the way. I think you can see this in the unconscious attractiveness of men to, especially to naive women. Naive women are easier to fool by psychopaths. So the psychopathic predatory types who are falsely confident are better at deceiving inexperienced women.
- 4.75 So as women get older, they're better at separating the wheat from the chaff on the male side. Psychopaths succeed with women because they act confident, and women use confidence as a marker for competence. And it's a pretty good marker. But it can be gamed and the psychopaths game it. It's still telling that women prefer bad boys to dependent infants, right? So if you imagine that women's sexual preference for men is at least somewhat of a reflection of their moral suitability, women implicitly judge the bad boys as more desirable than the useless, craven, basement-dwelling, resentful cowards. Right? And fair enough.
- 4.76 Now, is that the fullest expression of masculine attractiveness? No, but it shines in comparison to the alternative, which is a pretty damn dark thing to say when you're talking about, say, someone who made part of his fortune being an electronic pimp, right? Other questions?
- 4.77 You talked about prayer being a form of upward aim, and you also added some ways to be introspective. The chart of broad thought to action. But these things, on a personal level, are hard to act in a disciplined and consistent way for someone who's maybe time-constrained with a lot of responsibilities. In your opinion, as a busy person in your life, how do you implement these in an effective way?
- 4.78 The first thing I would say is don't underestimate the increment in efficiency that such things provide. Like, it's very good to have your, what would you say? Your priorities in order. You don't waste time. And so if you spend half an hour a day focusing on your priorities, there's no reason to assume that that's going to interfere with your efficiency. Quite the contrary, because

you'll waste less time and you'll be more efficient in your implementation, and it will be more effortless.

- 4.79 So I watched this with my wife because she was very ill a few years ago, and one of the consequences of that, along with many other things, was a deepening of her religious faith. And she spends a fair bit of time putting herself together in a formal religious manner in the morning, maybe an hour. But the consequence of that is she really floats through the whole day. So I don't see that it's a misuse of time at all.
- 4.80 So look, I'll tell you a story. It's a very interesting story. So Adam and Eve were thrown out of paradise because they're prideful, right? They, they try to— Eve, under the dominion of the serpent, tries to usurp the moral order and take the right to determine the difference between good and evil to herself. And then she tempts Adam to do the same, and in his cowardice, he agrees, trying to please his wife in the most craven possible manner, and in consequence they get thrown out of paradise. Why? Because pride goes before a fall.
- 4.81 The moral of the story? How much of your suffering is a consequence of your presumptuous overreach? Well, it's an open question, right? Have you bit off more than you can chew because you're narcissistic? And are you suffering in consequence? Well, one of the results of the fall is that God tells Adam that he's going to toil for his sustenance. He's going to work, and that the earth will bring forth thorns and thistles. OK, so that's interesting because you might think, well, it's a flaw in the structure of existence that we have to toil so effortfully for the maintenance of our survival. To work so hard in a world that doesn't open itself up easily to our machinations.
- 4.82 And that points to a fundamental inadequacy on the part of being itself, and maybe points to, what would you say? An error on the part of God, which is what Cain claims, by the way, when he's so bitter and resentful. But there's another way of thinking about it. Maybe things are effortful to you in precise proportion to the degree that your aim is wrong. That's something worth thinking about, you know. And I've certainly seen this most particularly in my relationship with my wife, because when our aims are aligned properly and upward, our relationship is all play.
- 4.83 And so then you might think, well, you know, the Israelites are slaves, right? And they labor under the thumb of a tyrant and may free themselves from tyranny. That story is emblematic of people. We toil in the, in the world like slaves. If we freed ourselves of our tyrannical presumptions and our pride, maybe we would learn to interact with the world in a constant state of play. And I think, like, I don't know how true that is. In my experience, the better I get at it, the more it's true. And I don't know what the upper limit to that is.
- 4.84 And I certainly know that you can make your life a hell of a lot worse than it has to be, as a consequence of being blind and arrogant and stubborn. That's for sure. So maybe— see, when God throws Adam and Eve out of paradise, he bars the pathway forward. Now, we talked about pathways forward in perception, right? Is that, when you specify an aim, a pathway opens up. So imagine there's a pathway to the highest good. That's the pathway to the Garden of Eden that

people have been thrown out of, to the paradise we're all searching for. God puts a guard on that road. It's a cherubim, which is a kind of monster and a sword. And it's a sword that turns every which way and burns.

- 4.85 And so what's a sword that turns every which way and burns? Well, first of all, it's an implement that cuts and an implement that burns. So it's an implement that cuts and burns, which is quite a formidable implement. Why? Well, so that everything that isn't worthy is cut away, so that paradise can establish itself. And so it means that it's inevitable that on the road to paradise, you'd encounter a sword that burns and cuts everything that isn't divine away, because only that which is divine can be in paradise by definition.
- 4.86 And so that begs the same question. How much of the misery that shapes you in the world is a consequence of things about you that need to be cut and burned away? And how much is your fleeing from that a refusal to undergo that? Well, we know what that is. That's a descent into the abyss, right? And the more paradisaal, this is certainly possible, the more paradisaal the aim, the deeper the initial descent into the abyss could be. Seems likely. That's the Inferno and Paradiso in Dante, down first, then up.
- 4.87 And that also explains why people are resistant to change. You know, because you might say, well, if enlightenment is possible, why isn't everyone enlightened? Because it seems like such a good thing. What are the barriers? And if the barrier is down first, then up, well, then you have an account for it. You see that in the story of Exodus, because the Israelites escaped from the tyrant and you think, oh great, no more tyranny. It's like, no, it's not so great. Now it's three generations in the desert, lost and without direction, right? Wandering around stupidly on a journey that should only take a couple of days if you're properly oriented, and so you can be so confused that it takes you forever to get anywhere. And that's the story of the Israelites.
- 4.88 So sorry, that's a long answer to your question, but it's likely the case that there's nothing you can do with your time that's more efficient than to polish your upward aim. So, and like in my experience, the clearer my priorities, by far the more things I can do. And not only that, the more opportunities open themselves up. And I think that's a never-ending upward spiral. Right? Because I had a vision of paradise at one point, you know, and it was a vision that helped me understand something paradoxical about the conception of heaven, because heaven is the place where everything is perfect. And you think, well, what the hell are you going to do there? Everything's perfect.
- 4.89 It's like, no, heaven is the place where everything's perfect and still getting better, right? Right. So it's being and becoming in a manner that's perfect, like a piece of music. And I think that's the pattern of a life well spent. And you accomplish that as a consequence of perfecting your aim, and that comes before anything else. So there's an insistence in the Old Testament, in particular, that you consecrate the firstborn to God. It's a very strange idea, and it's a very concrete idea that illuminates something profoundly psychological, and that is that your intent determines the course of the mission. This is a very important thing to understand.

- 4.90 You know, during the day you do a number of different things. You'll kind of remember your day as a sequence of different things. OK. What determines how each of those things unfolds? Well, how about the intent that establishes the aim in the first place? And that's going to be accompanied by a sacrifice. Why? Because when you aim at one thing, you forgo everything else. Like, every aim is a sacrifice. There's no way around that. Every perception is a sacrifice. Every glance is a sacrifice. And so you remind yourself, what are you sacrificing for? And the obvious answer to that question is something. Why would you answer anything other than the ultimate good? However you conceptualize that. Like, any other answer to that question is obviously of secondary import.
- 4.91 Now you might say, well, I don't believe in the ultimate good. That's the atheistic claim. It's like, well, do you believe in a proximal good of any sort? And if you don't, then why are you doing anything? And if you believe in a proximal good, is there no relationship between that proximal good and the ultimate good? That's your hypothesis? All good things share nothing in common. That's a stupid claim.
- 4.92 So I'll close with this. One of the things Christ tells his followers in the New Testament, which is a very difficult thing to understand, is that they have to forego even their brothers and sisters and parents in the pursuit of what's highest. But I think that's a reflection of what we've been discussing, is that what's best comes first, no matter what, right? So then the question is, well, what would your life be like if you lived according to that principle? And the answer to that question is, really, that's what you're here to find out, or not, or to fail to find out, which you will regret. Like, profoundly. And God only knows for how long and at what cost.
- 4.93 OK. Good enough. Thank you for coming today. Much appreciated. I guess we're half done. We got a long way to go yet. Thank you very much for coming today. Yeah.

5. Dialogue as Transformation

AT A GLANCE

Opens the humanist, existential, and phenomenological traditions with health redefined as harmony across levels, and Carl Rogers as a secular Protestant whose therapy rests on the transformative logos of dialogue. Distinguishes existentialists from phenomenologists, and facts from valued facts organized by a story. Covers Heidegger's Dasein, Binswanger and Boss on meaning attributed versus disclosed, blindsight and perception as motivated action, magical transformative agents, phainesthai and the burning bush, the Quidditch seeker, and ezer kenegdo. Introduces the frame-of-reference scheme of aim, obstacles, positive and negative emotion, and the integration of competing motivations.

- 5.1 So we'll cover three topics concentrating primarily on Carl Rogers and the humanists, but also talking about the associated conceptual, philosophical, and psychotherapeutic fields of existentialism and phenomenology, weaving those together psychologically and sociologically. I suppose psychologically and sociologically, because you could make the case that a harmony necessarily exists between the individual and the social structure. This is an important thing to understand and changes your conceptualization of mental health.
- 5.2 I think I mentioned at some point in the previous two lectures that it's easy to consider mental health as something that you have inside you that's like a biological phenomenon that might be associated with neurological health or a psychological phenomena that's, means that you can be a mentally healthy person in some ways in isolation, that it's something that you carry within you, but that's a mistake. It's a misapprehension. It's better to think of health as something like the harmony that's established at multiple levels of existence simultaneously.
- 5.3 So if you were psychologically integrated, we alluded to this yesterday, the motivational, your habits, your motivational states, your emotions would be integrated so that there was no contradiction within them, but they would simultaneously be integrated so that, for example, if you were married, the same would be true of your relationship with your wife, and then the relationship of your wife and you with your children, and then the relationship between your family and the community, you know, maybe the local community and then the broader community, then the natural world, and then, well, whatever's underlying, let's say, the natural world itself, that there's a harmony established across all of those levels.
- 5.4 And then what would constitute health and not just mental health would be the harmony across all those levels. And so what that implies as well, that there's a, that there's a concordance between how you conduct yourself individually and how the social community lays itself out. And so it's the harmony that's the health and not something that you carry around inside you. And so that's a very useful, that's a very useful thing to consider when you're trying to analyze, let's say, the relationship between the psychological and the sociological. The existential and—the humanist existential and phenomenological schools, I think, are more useful with regard to conceptualizing that harmony than the psychoanalytic schools.

- 5.5 The psychoanalytic schools tend really to concentrate on what you carry within you, whereas these other schools broaden the conception of health out to include something like the relationship between the individual and society, not in that **superego** versus **id** way that **Freud** conceptualized, but in a manner that I think is more balanced and less, that falls less into that **Rousseauian** insistence, let's say, that the human being in his natural state or her natural state is, you know, a **noble savage**, or the **Hobbesian** conception that man and woman in their natural state is in a necessary state of conflict and war, and only the domination, top down domination, of the state can bring harmony. It's like, no, there's an emergent harmony that can exist between all levels of existence, you might say. And I think the **phenomenologists**, the **existentialists**, the **humanists** were striving towards that realization.
- 5.6 We'll start with **Carl Rogers**. We'll organize our discussion primarily around **Carl Rogers**, because I think he was the most effective practical psychotherapist, whether he was the most effective conceptual philosophical thinker of all of those in the existential, **humanist**, phenomenological realm is debatable. But he was a very effective, practical psychotherapist. And part of the reason I want to structure this discussion around **Rogers** is because much of what he said is of extreme practical relevance. I'll read you some of Carl Rogers' writings on listening in particular, which I think contain the most profound practical strategies for organizing your relationship with yourself and with other people that I, that I know of from the clinical literature in terms of their simplicity and immediate, profound practical utility in application.
- 5.7 So **Rogers** was a devout fundamentalist Protestant, evangelical Protestant, essentially, whose father was a very successful farmer, who was an early devotee of application of the scientific process to his agricultural practices. And so **Rogers** grew up in an environment that was characterized by a devout and literalist evangelical Christianity, but also by the, what? Practical demonstration of the utility of the scientific method. When he was an adolescent, he was on his way to China to serve as a missionary and had a religious crisis and developed an atheism, an emergent atheism, partly as a consequence of his inability to reconcile his more literalist evangelical views with what he knew about science.
- 5.8 And the consequence of that, really, was that he became, I would say, he became what was essentially a secular Protestant. He took—Rogers' view is really evangelical Protestant in its essence. It's predicated on the idea, although **Rogers** never made this explicit, it's there in the philosophical background of his thinking. Rogers' therapeutic presumptions are predicated on the idea that "**dialogos**", dialogue, is transformative in a positive direction.
- 5.9 Now there's an idea, deep Judeo-Christian idea, that the existence of the world itself, insofar particularly insofar as the world is good or very good, is a manifestation of the redemptive word. Right? And that's the **logos**. And Rogers' fundamental presumption is that communication, honest communication, is, produces harmony and transforms. And so you can see underneath that that there's an implicit assumption that the **logos**, which is the word, is precisely what brings the order that's good to the world.

- 5.10 Now, much of what Rogers determined, you can utilize in your relationship to yourself and also in relationship to the people that are very close to you, because his fundamental presumption, like that of the existentialists and phenomenologists in general, is that if you integrate your experience into your verbal communication, and you communicate that forthrightly to yourself and to other people, that you'll set things in order around you and that that will produce a harmony, a psychological harmony and a sociological harmony. And so one of the existentialist presumptions, and the same thing is true of the psychoanalysts, is that truth itself sets you free, particularly insofar as that truth is embodied in verbal communication.
- 5.11 And, you know, Freud had utilized a similar principle because he believed that the free association technique, which was the free expression of whatever ideas emerged spontaneously in imagination, was curative. Freud didn't insist so much on dialogue, right? Freud wanted the person, the target of therapeutic practice, to reveal him or herself, whereas the Rogerian approach is more dialogical. It's more a negotiation approach. And behavioral psychologists also use a more dialogical or negotiation approach. Freud wanted to hide himself from his client so that his reactions wouldn't interfere with the self-disclosure of the client, whereas Rogers engaged in direct dialogue and negotiation.
- 5.12 The key of, the key to Rogerian psychotherapy, then, is not only the transformative characteristic, let's say, or power of the logos, but the transformative potential of dialogue and negotiation as such. And so the notion might be, for example, when, if we consider you as an isolated individual, there may be motivational states that are warring within you, pulling you in one direction rather than another. Maybe you love and hate your parents, for example. Or maybe you're deeply conflicted about, well, your relationship with someone you're attracted to or your job. So you're warring against yourself, and there's the possibility of negotiation between those warring states so that you could produce something like a synthesis.
- 5.13 And the same thing would be true with your relationship with other people. And so the Rogerian practice is essentially, adds the possibility of strategic negotiation to the self-revelation that the more analytic psychologists, the psychoanalysts, had concentrated on. So what would you expect Rogers' background to produce? An empirically minded thinker, which he was. Rogers tested many of his clinical presumptions in the research literature and published those findings as well. He was one of the first people—because the analytic psychologists didn't do this—he was one of the first people to bring a real empirical approach to the analysis of the psychotherapeutic process per se, to see if the presumptions were actually, you know, made themselves manifest in therapeutic improvement in a measurable manner.
- 5.14 An empirically minded thinker with a devout, implicit Protestant morality. That's Rogers. Some basic Rogerian concepts. This is what makes him a phenomenologist rather than an existentialist. An existentialist is someone who, what would you say, presumes that conflict is endemic to life. That'd be the first presumption. So strife and trouble can emerge in the absence of trauma, that they're endemic to existence, that there is sufficient suffering within life itself, so that no additional explanation for people's misery is necessary.

- 5.15 Freud had a sort of implicit idea in a way that you'd be fine if something terrible hadn't happened to you. The **existentialists**, they don't believe that. They think your life is troublesome enough to be able to generate pathology just because of its structure, because of, say, the intrinsic limitations of human mortality and ignorance and, and, but also on the more positive side that the honest confrontation with those problems, especially in negotiation, can produce, can transcend the problems and result in something like, what? The production of a harmonious unity. Yeah.
- 5.16 Now, insofar as Rogers was a **phenomenologist** rather than an **existentialist**, he tried to grapple with the fact that the reality that we inhabit, that we experience, so isn't objective. And this is a very complex problem. It's part of what makes Rogers and the **phenomenologists** not empiricists. They don't believe that we live in the world of facts, precisely. We live in the world of **valued facts**. Now, and the fact of the value, let's say, brings the subjective into the objective. Now, the way of understanding this is to first understand that there is a plethora of facts in the world, right? There's, there's, like, one fact per phenomena. Phenomenon. That's one way of looking at it, or there's one fact for every combination of phenomena. That's a lot of facts.
- 5.17 And so the problem with the purely empirical view that you orient yourself in the world of facts is that there is a lot of facts. And if you're dropped in the middle of a desert, all the facts are there. But that doesn't mean you know which direction to go in. And the ability to extract out a direction from a set of facts is a mystery. **David Hume**, very famous philosopher, famously said, "You cannot derive an ought"—what you should do—"from an is"—what is. And so the facts themselves don't have a directionality. You also don't know how to weigh the facts.
- 5.18 Maybe you're very, very attracted to someone sexually in a relationship, but you don't really like them. Well, how do you weight that, right? That's a very, very complex problem. And it's the same problem of how you deal with the world in general. How do you rank-order the importance of the things that you encounter? That's the problem of value. That's the introduction of subjectivity into the field of experience. Now, for the **phenomenologists**, the world that you inhabit is an amalgam, you might say, between the world of facts— what presents itself concretely—and the manner in which those facts are prioritized and valued. And so you live in a value hierarchy of facts, and the value hierarchy is the subjective element.
- 5.19 And there's no doubt this is true. Like, I would say, one thing we can be certain of in consequence of the last 60 years of intellectual endeavor, is that we value, we rank-order facts, according to their value. There's no escaping that. I think we also know—this is a revolutionary realization—that the description of the structure that you use to rank-order the facts is a story. So, for example, when you're going to a movie and the writer portrays for you the manner in which the protagonist attends to things and acts, that protagonist is dramatizing for you a hierarchical structure of facts. What does this person regard as important?
- 5.20 And what you're doing in the movie is embodying that **phenomenological field** and experiencing the emotions that are part and parcel of it. So you adopt the person's goals when you watch a fictional representation, and then you use your body as a computational platform to compute

the perceptions and the emotions that exist in accordance with that aim. And then you practice being alternative others, which is also what you do when you adopt someone else's viewpoint, and that expands your conception to practically deal with the world. A story is the verbal description of the structure that prioritizes facts. A crucial realization because it also implies that we live inside something that's best described as a story.

- 5.21 And that's, see, this is why the **postmodernists** have been able to upset modern culture, because the Enlightenment presumption was either that we lived in the world of facts or that we were rational, right? So that we had facts, but we rationally organized them. It's like, that's not true. We live in something that's best interpreted as a story, conceptualized as a story. Of course, that begs another question, which is what story do and should we live in? You know, the **postmodernists** jumped to the conclusion that we live in a story that's dominated by power.
- 5.22 The **existentialists**, they were all, they had already laid out an alternative hypothesis, something like the **Jungian** analysts, which is that, no, we live in a world that strives for a kind of upward-aiming harmony. It's a way more optimistic story and a more realistic one, I think, than one of power. OK, we live in a **phenomenological field**. The field is something like the manner, the what would, what would you say? The way that your visual perception is organized. As I described yesterday, when you look at something, there's a center point of vision that's very well delineated, surrounded by an area of decreasing resolution.
- 5.23 You focus on something. The thing that you focus on—this is the case for your consciousness as well, much of which is visual—you focus on the thing that you make of primary importance. It's the thing that springs to consciousness. It's surrounded by a penumbra of decreasing resolution until it fades into nothingness. That's true for every concept that you have. It's true for every object perception you have. There's a field in the center that's clear and distinct, surrounded by a penumbra of decreasing resolution, and you are in that field with every glance, like literally with every glance, because you switch the object of central perception every time you move your eyes.
- 5.24 And human beings are very visually conscious. You know, much of what we experience as our consciousness is actually the, what would you say? The, the, well, the field of, the field of visual objects that presents itself to us. And so the description of that field of centrality and penumbra, that's, that's a story. Or the acting out of that is a story. What does the protagonist prioritize? The deep analysis of the structure of priorities of a given protagonist. That's literary criticism fundamentally, right. So what's the story?
- 5.25 "Man lives essentially in his own personal and subjective world. And even his most objective functioning in science, mathematics, and the like is the result of subjective purpose and subjective choice." Scientists study phenomena objectively, but they choose which phenomena they study, right? So there's this weird dance between the subjectivity of the scientist. The scientist studies something that makes itself manifest to him or her as interesting, at least if they're going to diligently attend to what they're doing, so they may lay out their objective observations in consequence of their scientific, of the means of their scientific inquiry.

- 5.26 But that's all framed within a motivational structure, because they chose what it was that they were going to attend to. And you can imagine, too, that the evil scientist that's a literary trope is someone whose choice of objective analysis was determined by malevolent, underlying motivational forces. Right. And so, yes, the world they're laying out is objective fact, but it's still nested inside something that's subjective and has to be analyzed not only with regards to value, but with regards to ethics. I'll give you an example.
- 5.27 There were scientists in the Soviet Union. So the story goes. An ex-KGB officer wrote a story about this, who were trying to hybridize smallpox and Ebola and aerosolize it to make a maximally transmissible, 100% fatal disease that could be rapidly distributed as a biological weapon. Now, is that an objective analysis? Well, you have to be a fool if you try to separate that from the underlying ethic. And what was the underlying ethic? Well, you know, it's very difficult not to regard it as something that borders on the satanic. It's like, oh, that's your plan, is it? You're going to assess the objective world so that you can produce a terribly destructive bioweapon that can be aerosolized. Right.
- 5.28 Well, anyone who thinks that's a merely objective, what would you say? A merely objective process is a fool and likely a dead fool if things go pathologically wrong. Now, so one of the things the phenomenologists, existentialists, humanists were trying to solve was that, to resolve the dichotomy between the subjective and the objective, but to insist that both of those played a role in the field of experience that characterizes human, what? The field of human consciousness.
- 5.29 Now, the people who worked within these philosophical realms, see, they don't, they don't believe that we live in the objective world. They really don't even believe that reality itself is the objective world. They believe that it's more functionally appropriate and maybe more ontologically accurate—so a better description of reality itself—to note that reality, insofar as it concerns us, which is maybe reality itself, at least insofar as human beings have anything to do with it, is actually the phenomenal field that we live in and not the objective world.
- 5.30 Now, even scientists know this to some degree because they understand that there are many objective facts, let's say. So things that are objectively real that we don't understand, that are beyond us. And so whatever it is that we inhabit is obviously not the totality of the objective world. Because if it was, we would know everything objectively, and we obviously don't. So, now, you know, you can have a very serious debate about whether it's better to think of reality as that which you experience or the objective world. The problem with the latter is, well, what the hell do you do with the subjective? And one of the answers to that is, you ignore it or you regard it as secondarily real.
- 5.31 But then that leaves you with the problem of your suffering. It's like, well, if your subjectivity isn't real, then what the, like, of what ontological status is your life? And even more importantly, if you're just a secondary phenomena in an objectively real world, how do you attribute meaning to your life when it's rife with suffering? That's a prime existential problem. The phenomenologists, existentialists, the humanists, they flip that and they say, no, no, you've just

got to dispense with the idea that the fundamental reality is objective. You have to accept the idea that whatever reality is, is essentially equivalent to this **phenomenal field** that we inhabit, the story of our life, something like that.

- 5.32 And that resolves the contradiction between the subjective and the objective, and grants a fundamental reality to your, to your existence, to your, hence **existentialism**, to your existence. It makes the suffering. It's one way of thinking about it. It grants the suffering that characterizes life something like primary reality. Primary ontological reality. Now you're still stuck with the problem of how you deal with that, but that's the sort of thing that **Rogers** and the rest of the people associated with this school of endeavor were trying to—that's the problem they were trying to answer. And I think in many ways did answer.
- 5.33 Other notable figures. **Ludwig Binswanger** and **Medard Boss**, they were the European psychotherapists, somewhat less influential in the UK and the West, who took Heidegger's ideas, the philosopher **Heidegger**, and applied them in the therapeutic world. **Heidegger** was the philosopher who returned the idea of—he was a **phenomenologist**—he returned the idea of the primacy of experience to the philosophical realm, which is a radical transformation of philosophy in the aftermath of the Enlightenment. The **phenomenologists**, **Binswanger** and **Boss**, regarded—they took a **Heideggerian** concept, "**Dasein**", which means being there. That, that was Heidegger's attempt to characterize the **phenomenological field** that constituted our experience.
- 5.34 **Heidegger** attempted to take apart and characterize the quality of our experience, which is a different endeavor than the nature of objective reality. What are the presumptions of the notion of **Dasein**? Past and future are implicit in the present **Dasein**. OK, so your experience has a certain quality. Part of the quality of that experience is the fact of whatever's happening now. But part of the quality of that experience is a consequence of the framing that you bring to bear on the present as a consequence of the totality of your previous experience.
- 5.35 So, you're structuring your experience as it lays itself out, and that, that means that your perceptions itself are tuned and characterized by the, the totality of, of your, not only of your past personal experience, but as your, but as a consequence of your instantiation as a historical being. You bring a culturally determined framework of interpretation. You inhabit that framework of interpretation, right? So that's part of the **Dasein**, is the past is implicit in the present. That's a good way of thinking about it. You have a way of looking at something. You have a stance that you take towards the manner in which the present is unfolding. We are our experience.
- 5.36 If you think about things objectively, you tend to fall into the trap of assuming that there's a dichotomy, let's say, between mind and matter, which is the same as the dichotomy between the subjective and the objective. If you reduce the world to the objective, you can't account for the subjective. That pulls you into a kind of duality. The way of rectifying that is to presume that your experience is the primary reality, and that the subjective and the objective are melded

within the confines of that experience. So that makes experience itself. That makes experience itself the central reality.

- 5.37 It's a very different way of looking at the world than the objective world, which makes subjective experience a secondary epiphenomenon. And it's a fundamental—in a way, it's a, it's a, it's a consequence of two different axioms of faith, like, what's most real? The objective or that which you experience. You can make a very strong case for both. The justification for the assumption of the prime reality of the objective is the overwhelming success of the technological enterprise that's based on that viewpoint. But the evidence for the primacy of the subjective is that, insofar as I assess your motives and your behavior, I will conclude that there's nothing more real to you in all likelihood, than pain, right? That that, you will act when pushed as if that experience is of primary reality.
- 5.38 Now, you could be more optimistic and you could say, well, you're more convinced of the primary reality of the things that help you deal with pain, like love and beauty. But the point is, is that, if you watch how people conduct themselves, they act as if their subjective experiences are the primary reality. And insofar as they do that, they tend to survive and reproduce, which makes them, let's say, functional Darwinian organisms, which is certainly another way of approaching what constitutes the most real.
- 5.39 "Without a subject, nothing at all would exist to confront objects and to imagine or represent them as such." True, this implies that every object, everything objective and being merely objectified by the subject, is the most subjective thing possible. **Boss** there is trying to wrestle with this notion that there's an irreducible element of the subjective, even in the most objective observation. This is true neurologically. So, for example, you might think that when you look at something, you see an object, and then you determine its emotional significance and then you determine its functional significance, let's say its use, that the object perception is primary.
- 5.40 And then the utilitarian analysis, the value analysis, is a projection on that, a secondary projection. It's like, that's actually not true. When you look at an object—so imagine there's a pattern that characterizes the object recognition that makes itself manifest on the retina. Right, so there's a two-dimensional retinal representation of the object. That's a pattern. That pattern is propagated down the optical nerve and then distributes itself neurologically. Right? The pattern is replicated at multiple levels in the nervous system. It's replicated on your spine first without conscious vision. This is a very weird thing.
- 5.41 So for example, there are people who have a phenomenon called **blindsight**. And so these people tell you they can't see. But if you ask them to guess at which hand you're holding up, they can do it with 95% accuracy. And if you do psychophysiological recording of their skin conductance response when you flash faces of different emotional significance at them, or different stimuli, if you flash threatening faces, angry or fearful, or primordial stimuli that evoke fear, like snakes, they'll show a skin conductance response. But they're blind.

- 5.42 Well, are they blind? Well, they're not blind insofar as their retina maps onto their spinal cord, so they have reflexive responses to their visual input. Now, if you're walking down a pathway and you catch a snake out of the corner of your eye, and you have to see the snake consciously and then decide to jump, that takes somewhere between half and half a second and a full second, and snakes can strike in much less time than that. So you're dead. Now, if you detect the snake with your snake pattern recognition on your retina and map that onto your spinal cord, you can leap away before you even see the snake, and then you don't die.
- 5.43 And so there's a motor output that's directly associated with vision and an emotional evaluation that occurs either at the same time in a functional nervous system or before conscious vision. Now we think you see something consciously and then decide what to do. It's like, no, that's not how it works. That's also how it works. But it's not only or fundamentally how it works. And that's also true for emotional mapping. So that, now it's more. It's even more complex than that, because when you look at something like a cup, this maps onto the **Piagetian** theories that we'll discuss.
- 5.44 One of the things that happens when you see a drinking glass is that the pattern of the glass activates the pattern of grip that would characterize your use of the glass in your motor cortex. So part of the perception is actually the relationship between the object and its functional utility to you, part of the perception, not the second order application of value to the world. The theorists of the primary reality of the objective world think we see objects and then determine their use. It's like, no, that's not how it works. It's simply not how it works.
- 5.45 So even our object perceptions are inextricably, inextricably associated with our valuation of what we're perceiving. There's no separating those two. And it's worse than that, even, because the idea of stimuli and response, which is a behaviorist idea, is predicated on the idea of the primary self-evident reality of the objective world and the secondary reality of the response. The stimuli is self-evident in such conceptualization. It's simply not true. When you look at something, you're actually engaging an act of exploration, even though you can't actually tell. Like, I'm sampling you with my eyes constantly, just like a blind person touching something repeatedly to map it.
- 5.46 You can't, there's no perception separate from motivated action. There is no perception separated from motivated action. Not at the micro level. Not at the micro level, macro level. You can't say primary perception, secondary response. That's not how it works. And so, **Boss** is right. There is, "everything objective—in being merely objectified by the subject—is the most subjective thing possible." And so part of what the people in this school of thinking are doing is trying to think through the implications of such things.
- 5.47 "What we perceive as well are first and foremost not impressions of taste, tone, smell, or touch, not even things or objects, but meanings." That's a very revolutionary statement, too, that the primary object of perception is significance. You could think the primary perception isn't matter. The primary perception is what matters. Now, again, it's hard to escape this conclusion, neurophysiologically. So if I'm engaged in an action and I hear a loud noise behind me, I'm going

to stop, crouch, which is a prey protection reflex. Then I'm going to turn unconsciously and orient towards the place that my auditory system has determined the noise emerges from.

- 5.48 It's just like catching motion in the periphery of your vision. Something will grip your attention and orient you, and it's something unexpected often that grips your attention. Right? And so what that means is that the first manifestation of the reality that you will eventually perceive as a differentiated object is actually its emotional significance or its meaning. That's the first perception. That's way different than you see an object and think about what it means. It's, no, it's the object grips you, captures you. The phenomena, the phenomenon grips you and captures you. Then you attend to it, then it differentiates into objects.
- 5.49 If you hear a noise behind you when you're walking down a busy street, you want to know if the thing you hear is going to run into you or over you, right? So what you're interested in is its functional significance. Now, Binswanger and Boss had a distinction in presumption about just exactly how this relationship between the meaning of an object and the object made itself manifest. Binswanger believed that we endowed the world with meaning, and that would be something like the effect of your a priori framework of presumptions on the world.
- 5.50 What makes itself manifest to you is unexpected, is dependent on the purpose of your action. Right, if you're doing A, some things will be unexpected in relationship to A, and if you're doing B, then other things will be unexpected in relationship to B, right? So what that means is that even what manifests itself as novel is somehow dependent on your aim. Now, Boss took the opposite perspective, which was that the world that revealed itself to you had a kind of autonomy and structure of its own, that things will call to you, even independent of your aim.
- 5.51 So, for example, you might be—imagine you go into a bookstore because you're looking for a particular book to fulfill your goal-seeking behavior. But as you're wandering through the shelves, something else attracts your attention, and you're subverted off your path. And you open the book and it takes you down a whole new pathway. Boss's observation was that the world discloses its meanings autonomously and will pull you along as a consequence of that.
- 5.52 Now, if you know the mythological literature, you see that both of those things are true at the same time. Some of the time it's useful to think of the way that meaning makes itself manifest as a consequence of your aim. And some of the time, it's useful to think of the world as something that can disclose meaning to you and transform your aim. Both of those things can be true. You could argue that the deeper experiences of your life occur when you encounter something that discloses a new meaning to you autonomously. This is what happens to Bilbo Baggins in The Hobbit. He's living his ordinary life, right? And the wizard shows up and transforms his aim. This is, this is what a magical creature does in mythological representations.
- 5.53 So we talked a little bit about narrative and the way it lays itself out. You have an aim. Your perceptions reveal a pathway to you. Along the pathway, there are obstacles and things that move you forward. There are foes and friends. OK, so that's sort of the narrative world. The way forward, things that get in your way, things that help you, irrelevant things, foes and friends. But

there's another category, which is the category of something like **transformative magical agents** or experiences. And what they do is transform your aim, right? So they move you from one world to another. They're **psychopomps**. They're agents of the gods. That's another way of thinking about them.

- 5.54 They're manifestations of the spirit **Mercurius**. That snitch that **Harry Potter** chases as a seeker, that winged ball. That's a game-transforming phenomena. It's partly why it's associated with gold and wings. It's a symbol of the spirit Mercury, by the way, and Mercury is the winged messenger of the gods. So there are things that we can encounter that have their own autonomous being that transform the subjective worlds that we live in, and those are magical things. Now, why are they magic? It's so interesting. It's so interesting.
- 5.55 So imagine that the given frame that you inhabit is like a game. It has certain rules, right? The strategy that you're undertaking has a structure that's dependent on your particular aim. So it's an aim with a set of rules that go along with that aim. Now, that aim can transform, and when it transforms, a new set of rules becomes relevant. That's a different world. The reason that the agents that bring you into a different world are magical is because they don't play by the rules of the current game, and so they're magical in that they're playing a different game.
- 5.56 So is magic real? It's like, well, magic is real insofar as the magical players transform the landscape of the game, and those are transformative experiences. And we really think of something as magic when it doesn't play by the rules. It's like, well, there are different sets of rules for different situations. And so the magical moments of your life is when your aim changes and the game structure changes in consequence. So how magical can things get? Well, that's the same question as, what's the upper limit of the transformation of the games that you can play? And the answer to that is we don't know.
- 5.57 You know, imagine that there are a series of stepped games that you can play that are incremental. It's pretty easy to get from game A to B and easy to get from B to C and D and E and so forth. But there's a huge gap between A game and, say, G game. Right? So if you're in A game, and a G game, G game player shows up, they're going to appear pretty damn magical to you. So because partly you're going to think, how the hell do I get from where I am to there? It seems impossible. That doesn't mean it's impossible. It just means you don't know how to do it.
- 5.58 The word phenomena upon which the concept of phenomenological, phenomenological is based is from a Greek word, "**phainesthai**", and **phainesthai** means to shine forth. Right, and that's a representation of the spontaneous grip of the object. That's the same idea as the **burning bush** in the story of **Moses**. When **Moses** encounters the **burning bush**, he's going about his job as a shepherd. He's an escapee from Egypt, living an ordinary life, a credible, responsible, married, responsible, married, ordinary, conservative, secure, admirable life. And something knocks him off the beaten track, right? Something glimmers to him, and he decides to go investigate.

- 5.59 So that means he, what would you say, responds to the call of this thing that's shining forth, the **burning bush**. That's the dynamism of life. The tree, the bush being something alive and the fire being something that's dynamic and transforming. **Moses** decides he's going to attend to the call to go off the beaten path. As he approaches this thing that calls to him, he starts to understand that he's on sacred ground. He takes off his shoes, which is an indication of his willingness to transform, because shoes are emblematic of an identity, and he investigates this thing that compels him. And as he investigates it, he falls more and more deeply into it until the voice of the sacred itself reveals itself to him and transforms his character into the leader, who voluntarily takes his people from tyranny through the desert to the Promised Land. Right. So that's a good story to know.
- 5.60 Partly what it indicates—this is what you do if you're a seeker in the **Harry Potter** sense. So there's a game that everyone's playing. That's the sort of low-level Quidditch game where the goal is to put the balls through the hoops, and there's the high-level game, which is to chase what's difficult to catch, that compels you. The Quidditch game is set up so that if you win the higher-order game, you simultaneously are very likely to win the lower-order game, but not the reverse. Right? And that speaks to a kind of metaphysic that's relevant to what we're discussing now, which is something like the nature of the higher good. At the lower level, winning is the good. At the higher level, playing the game optimally is the good.
- 5.61 And that's partly because you can win a game, or you can conceptualize your life as a sequence of games that doesn't end, and you can figure out how best to play the sequence of games that doesn't end. And you don't do that by trying too hard to win any single game. That's the situation of a kid who, you know, is a very good athlete, but who stakes everything on local victory and who will tromp over anyone in his pathway to get there. It's like, maybe he'll win the game, but no one is going to want to play with him again. A very good player, and you know this if you have children, is you want to teach your children to be good sports. Right. You say, it isn't whether you win or lose, it's how you play the game.
- 5.62 And the kids are confused because they think, well, what the hell do you mean, it doesn't matter if you win? And you say, that's not what I said. What I said was, don't subvert the goal of winning the set of all possible games to the particulars of winning any given game. Your goal is to be the sort of person that people invite to play, so you can play an unending sequence of upward, upward-ascending games, instead of sacrificing everything to local victory. Right?
- 5.63 And so, now the idea here, and it's like Jung's idea of the revelation of the **archetype** of the self. So **Jung** had this idea of a, like a superordinate pattern that characterized your potentiality. And Jung's idea was that that would make itself manifest in your life in the form of what calls to your **conscience** or what grips your interest. And the **phenomenologists** were making the same observation in a way, that there are things in the world that disclose themselves to you as meaningful, which serve as markers. They're magical markers.
- 5.64 It's like those things you encounter in video games that give you more energy if you, you know, if you click on them. It's the same thing, represented abstractly. You discover those signposts in

your life, and they're portals to a new adventure. That's a good way of thinking about them. Is the thing you're encountering an object, or is it a portal to a new adventure? Is it an object that's a dead material entity, or is it a doorway to another dimension? It's like, you think, well, there's no such thing as a doorway to another dimension. It's like, you just don't know what you're talking about.

- 5.65 There are doorways like that everywhere, and those beckon to you as opportunity. The opportunities that make themselves manifest to you, by the way, are also—this is Binswanger's point—they're also dependent on your aim. And so this is something to reiterate. This is so important to understand. Your perceptions align with regards to your goal. And that's the true, even with regards to, let's say, magical opportunities. So if your aim is demented and bent by the domination, let's say, of anger or resentment, dark motives that are, couldn't possibly produce harmony if they were manifested even successfully, if your aim is characterized by those, by possession, by those states, then the opportunities that will make themselves manifest, they will be doorways to that end.
- 5.66 And that's a terrifying thing to understand. It's something like, if you're aiming at hell, the pathways there will make themselves manifest in your life, right? And if you really understand, maybe it's so perverse the way this works. Like so, if you're motivated in a dark manner, for example, even if you don't fully realize it and you probably won't because you wouldn't want to, you'll run across someone at a party, maybe even a potential mate whose attractiveness, unknown to you, is dependent on the fact that their mode of being will allow you to attain your vengeful ends, and then you'll end up fatally attracted to someone who's really pathological.
- 5.67 And you'll wonder, why did this happen to me? And the answer is, you set yourself up, right, however unconsciously. And you might say, well, if it was **unconscious**, I didn't deserve it. And then that begs another question, which is, well, to what degree did you allow that to remain **unconscious** when you could have figured it out? You know, like, that, that touches on that idea in some ways of **Freudian repression**. Maybe you're unhappy in your marriage because you don't have the courage to establish good communication with your wife about your aggression, let's say, or about your sexuality or hers, for that matter.
- 5.68 And so you leave many things unsaid that you could explore and say. And then resentful and vengeful fantasies make themselves manifest, but you don't explore them, but they're still there and they're perverting your aim. And so now they twist the way that you look at the world. So now you go to a party and you're unhappy in your marriage, but you don't want to admit it. And you find someone who's really dark but extremely attractive, and then you're fatally drawn to them, and you have this catastrophic misadventure and you think, "Oh my god, how did that terrible thing happen to me?" It's like, hey, you set the playing field, so look the hell out.
- 5.69 And that's, it's worse than that because—the **existentialists** knew this—those perverse motivations that grip you in consequence of your own ignorance not only warp you, but warp the social surround. I'll give you an example of that now. So we know that the troll types, the anonymous troll demons that pollute the social media landscape, the personality of those

people has been assessed, right. So these are frequent posters who are anonymous, particularly who use derisive and divisive language, attracting undue attention to themselves. Who are they? Narcissistic, Machiavellian, psychopathic, and sadistic.

- 5.70 Right, and so they have this constellation of personal psychopathology and you might say, well, that's sort of locked inside their—it's a brain disorder, or it's locked inside their psyche. It's like, no, it's making itself manifest in the social world and polluting the entire domain of social discourse. So it's not separate from the social structure. There's a dance. See, the rectification of this conundrum that the phenomenologists, Binswanger and Boss, had is meaning something you attribute to the world, or is meaning something that discloses itself to you. The answer to that is actually put forward in the biblical corpus.
- 5.71 So in our deep mythological stories, in the insistence that our relationship with the ground of being is best characterized as a relationship. Right? That our, yeah, that our, the manner in which we interact with being itself is best characterized as a relationship. That's portrayed as a covenant, an agreement, a contract in the biblical stories. And what it means is that there's a dance between the manner in which you interact with the world and the manner in which the world shows itself to you. Some of that's a consequence of your aim, like it is when you're moving someone around on a dance floor, and some of it is a consequence of the manner in which your dance partner has her own feelings about how things might unfold as you're dancing, right?
- 5.72 It's a dialogue. It's an interaction. That's why there's an insistence, for example, in stories like that of Abraham and Moses, for that matter, that God can be bargained with. That happens frequently. Can you negotiate with fate? Well, that is what you're doing when you're moving forward. You're negotiating with fate. Like, you seem to have some autonomy and control over what happens as you move forward. But it's not complete. Right. You still have to encounter the structure of the world itself, and you have to contend with that. And is that a relationship? Is it an agreement? We act like it is.
- 5.73 So one of the things, for example, that you learn to do as you mature is to make a contractual relationship with the world. The deal is something like, I'll forego, I'll forego my immediate gratification right now—that's what you do when you work—in the belief that that will pay off at some future point, right? That's the deal when you work. That's the deal when you put your money in a bank. That's the deal when you establish a reputation with other people. Right. You're assuming some medium- to long-term payoff for the sacrifices you make in the present. That's clearly equivalent to something approximating a contractual or covenantal relationship.
- 5.74 And so then you think, well, you make a deal with the world and you also feel betrayed, right, if it, if it doesn't lay itself out. I worked so hard and yet I didn't attain my end. You feel that something fundamental about the structure of reality itself has been violated. We exist in relationship with ourselves in the future. We exist in relationship with other people, but we exist in relationship with the structure of existence and even the spirit that gives rise to that structure itself.

- 5.75 Then the question is, in part, how should you conduct yourself so that that contract is most likely to be fulfilled? And that's really the, that's, what would you say? That's the question that underlies the psychotherapeutic endeavor, but even more generally underlies the idea of ethic itself. How should you conduct yourself in the world so that your sacrifices, let's say, are most likely to be accepted? That touches on issues of, again, issues that are associated with something like **fair play**.
- 5.76 You know, if you have a son who's the star on the soccer pitch and he hogs the ball and everything's about him, he might be the best player. He might even win the game. But you're still embarrassed about how he conducts himself and when he comes off the field, if you have any sense, and he won, and maybe he's the star, you give him a cuff and you say, yeah, you know, you're very skilled, but you're not that wise. Your, your friend who's a pretty good soccer player, not quite as good as you, but maybe he could be with some help, he was open, you know, when you took that shot and scored. He was open. You should have passed, and everybody noticed it.
- 5.77 And so why do you do that? And you think, well, there's a way of playing the game that goes beyond the game, right? This is partly why athletics can be used to develop character. It's like, there are lessons you can use from the game that are broadly applicable to the set of games, and a good coach is someone who says, don't sacrifice the long-term game, the uphill striving, the kingdom of heaven. That's its absolute maximum extent, let's say. Don't sacrifice that for any proximal victory, no matter how tempting. That's wise. That's wisdom itself speaking.
- 5.78 So, and this is the sort of thing that the **phenomenologists**, the **existentialists**, are trying to puzzle out, especially after World War II, because everyone's twisted upside down, because of what happened in the concentration camps and the emergence of the nuclear age, right. Our capacity for mass destruction, the question of how we conduct ourselves ethically, and what relationship that has with the broader world—that starts to become paramount. And the mystery of what constitutes an ethic, given its subjectivity, and how you might characterize an upward-striving ethic in a manner that's philosophically rigorous and defensible. That starts to obsess everyone.
- 5.79 And the **phenomenologists**, the **existentialists**, **Rogers**—they got a long way with that, a long way. Now I'm going to turn to a scheme that will help you understand everything that we've talked about already, and the **phenomenologists**, and also lay the groundwork for our investigation into neuropsychology. So **Dasein** is the frame that you, within which you experience the world, or **Dasein** is the, is reality itself, insofar as reality is defined by experience. That's the world you inhabit. You can think about it as your visual field. Like, that's a good analog, although your consciousness is broader than your visual field. You're hearing things and touching things and feeling things as well, when you're seeing things. But we're very visual human beings, so that's a good, a good way of conceptualizing the field.
- 5.80 You have this visual array. I can't see what's behind me. I can't see what's out here. Some things in the center are clear. OK. What is it that I see? OK. Depends on where I'm going. So, for

example, if I look at you, I see the things around you. If I look over there because I want to walk to the camera, I see this empty space in front of me. You people become peripheral. Right, so the objects of my perception are dependent on my aim, at least in that dance-like manner that we described.

- 5.81** We specify the place we're at, what is. We specify where we're going, what should be. We can't see, which means the world of objects doesn't present itself to us without making those a priori axiomatic choices. Every time it's built into the structure of perception itself. I'm looking at you because I want to communicate with you. That's why I move my eyes towards you. I can't perceive without aim. I can't focus my eyes. Because if, when I'm looking at you, I could look here, if I look here, it's very close to looking to you. You're blurry. I can't see you. The act of focus itself is dependent on aim as well as the act of glance. So no perception without aim. Hell of a thing to understand.
- 5.82** OK, so what do we aim at? Depends on our motivations. But let's say, generally speaking, we devote our attention and action towards making something better than it is now, right? That sets up the motivational state. Why am I endeavoring in this direction? It's the Promised Land story. I assume that wherever I'm heading, unless my aim is perverse, I assume that wherever I'm heading is better in some manner than what I'm doing right now. That sets up a gradient, right? The gradient is insufficient present, desirable future. That sets up an emotional landscape because it means that every micro step I take towards the goal is now charged with positive emotion.
- 5.83** That's how positive emotion works. That's dopaminergically mediated **incentive reward**. It's the same system activated by drugs like cocaine. So that **incentive reward** system, which is very old, is what impels us forward insofar as we're enthusiastic and curious and committed. You establish an aim. Now you have a landscape of reward. You also have a landscape of negative emotion. What causes negative emotion? Anything that gets in the way. And anything that upsets the frame, right. Now, the frame-upsetting experiences are complex. They produce negative emotion. Because what the hell's up, right? Everything's thrown topsy-turvy.
- 5.84** But they also have an element of positive emotion, which is, I don't know, maybe you're dating someone and you're not that happy. You're sort of happy with them, but not particularly. You go, so you're ambivalent. You go to a party and you meet someone new and exciting. Well, you're anxious about that because it's going to destabilize your relationship, but you see it beckoning to something better. So you're trapped in that ambivalence of novelty. Is the thing that upsets you and your current plan a good thing or a bad thing? Well, it's bad because it upsets your current plan and throws you into the **underworld**. But it's good because, hey, maybe you've got a better plan, right?
- 5.85** So there's an ambivalence. That's the emotional landscape. You're here. You're heading there, always, no matter. With every glance, there's no escaping it. And then you lay out the behaviors, often habitual, that you think will move you from one place to another. The psychoanalysts would be more concerned, let's say, about your aim and the structure of your aim. The

behaviorists would think, OK, well, you've established an aim. What's the mechanics of the behaviors that will get you there? That's that micro analysis that we talked about yesterday.

- 5.86 How do you conceptualize this frame? Well, this is where motivation, subjectivity plays a role. So what's your, what's your frame and your aim dependent on? Well, maybe you're lonesome. And so your frame is motivated by the desire for companionship and sex. And so there's an underlying system that grips your **frame of reference**, establishes your goal, and sets up the object perceptions and the emotional landscape. And that can toggle between different states of motivation.
- 5.87 You know, you're hungry and tired in bed. So is the bed an obstacle or a facilitator? Well, it's an obstacle if you need to eat and it's a facilitator if you need to sleep. You can see the conflict there. Right? And so then you have to flip between **frames of reference**. It's like, should I just go to sleep or am I too hungry? And then you get up to eat and then you go back to sleep and, right, you're flipping between these different frames, and the world lays itself out differently within each of those frames.
- 5.88 And then the underlying issue becomes, you have multiple states of motivation and emotion that can produce frames. The frames conflict, like being hungry and being tired. The frames conflict. How do you integrate the things that motivate the frames, so that they don't bump into each other, so that they can be satiated, so that that satiation can occur in the medium to long run and ensure your future, and so that you can do that while cooperating and competing peacefully and productively with everyone else?
- 5.89 So that's that drive towards underlying unity, so you can think of your motivation, not only as you're hungry or you're tired, or you're in need of companionship or sexual gratification, or you're cold or you're too hot. You know, you're bouncing between primordial motivational frames like a toddler dominated by one emotion or another. Or you can think, well, wait, that's one way of construing motivation and a real one. But there's another motivation that's a meta-motivation, which is the motivation of integrating all of those motivations. So they, so that your actions are most effective in the broadest possible range of situations amongst the greatest number of people and across the longest possible span of time.
- 5.90 Now you can imagine that there's a, because of the necessity of doing that, for ensuring long-term survival and long-term reproduction, a new set of motivations emerges, even on the biological front, that are the motivations that devote you towards integration. Curiosity is one of those, right? That desire for adventure is one of those. The, the, what would you say? The grip of the impulse to explore is one of those. Those are, I wouldn't call them secondary motivations, but they are higher-order motivations that speak of the necessity of integrating primordial motivations over the long run.
- 5.91 That's the impetus to mature, right? That's the **quest**, for example, that **Pinocchio** goes on when he's striving to become a real boy. That's the **quest** that **Bilbo** and **Frodo** go on when they're striving to become more than these narrow inhabitants of the, what, of the ignorant and and

too-bounded Shire. Right? That's the **quest** motif in general. That's the, that's the, the same, it's exactly the same adventure that the **Harry Potter** crowd goes on as they wrestle with evil and deal with their magical kingdom and try to become the people who can confront malevolence, overcome it, and regenerate the kingdom.

- 5.92 That's so, and that's a reality. It's not some fictional landscape. It's a reality that reflects the necessity of integrating these underlying motivational states. Otherwise, you stay like a two-year-old. A lot of psychopathology can be understood as protracted immaturity. So, many two-year-olds are aggressive. There's a subset of two-year-olds who are particularly aggressive, 5% of them, almost all male. They bite, hit, kick, and steal spontaneously if you put them with other two-year-olds. Most of them are socialized by the age of four. They learn how to integrate their behavior and to make friends.
- 5.93 Some of them aren't. The ones that aren't become juvenile delinquents, then criminals, and there's no redressing it. And so what's the criminality? They're two. Except now they're 14 or 30. And so it's pretty damn ugly because it's one thing to be a pushy two-year-old. You're only this tall. It's like, what the hell can you do? But if you have the same motivational structure when you're 25 and powerful, look the hell out. And the hedonistic types, they're the same. Two-year-olds, pre-social, are hedonistic. They're dominated by a specific motivational state. They're dominated by the present. They want what they want now, and they'll stomp their feet and kick and scream and have a temper tantrum to get it.
- 5.94 What's the problem with that? No one else wants to be around that. Right. And that's a fundamental problem because we're so social, human beings. We're so social that you can take **psychopaths** who are, like, the least social people, and you can put them in social isolation, which you'd think they'd want, given how antisocial they are. And they regard it as a punishment. That's how social human beings are. You can take the worst of us and punish them by putting them in isolation.
- 5.95 And so the notion that we have to adapt to the social environment, that's not some arbitrary, what? That's not some arbitrary **superego** injunction of the power-dominated patriarchal state. It's like, oh no, if you don't get along with other people, you are—like, what the hell are you going to do on your own? Seriously, you know, you don't know how to fix your car. You don't know how to fix your dishwasher. You know, you're lonesome. You can't straighten yourself out; like, no one can do that. We're social to the core, and so we have to integrate our self-centered, instantaneous motivations for the long run and for the community.
- 5.96 And there's a pattern to that. There's a pattern to that, the pattern of the **playable game**. OK. So you have this **frame of reference**. The frame itself and the goal is established by these underlying motivations, right. What have I got here? Self-propagation, the desire for companionship and sex. More basic biological instincts. These are **hypothalamically** mediated, as we'll see when we go into the physiology. Thermoregulation, temperature, thirst, hunger, elimination. Basic, the basic motivations that a two-year-old is grappling with regulating. Set the frame.

- 5.97 Then there's the necessity, as I said, of integrating those. That's the higher-order **quest**, right? And so that's the subjugation of any particular **frame of reference** to the fact that **frames of reference** transform across time and have to be sustained and improved while interacting with other people and the future, right? That produces its own set of fundamental motivational impulses. That's the motivation for the **quest** or for adventure, for the **hero's journey**. That's a good way of thinking about it.
- 5.98 Here's how the emotional landscape lays itself out. So this is the relationship between the subjective and the objective that the **phenomenologists** are talking about. You know where you are. It's not quite good enough. If it was, you'd just sit, maybe like you do after Thanksgiving dinner, and your motivation would be mostly to fall asleep. That's what you do when you're satiated. When everything's being satisfied. There's no reason for consciousness. Consciousness is a grappling phenomenon. It's a seeking and a **quest**. It's active. And so there has to be a gradient between where you are and where you want to be.
- 5.99 Partly what you do to establish a good relationship with yourself. Very much worth knowing. Behaviorists are very good at. This is you want to establish that gradient in a manner that's interesting— I would like to do this. I think it would be worthwhile—that's also moderately attainable. Think about this. You're, you want to play one-on-one basketball, OK? And maybe you're six foot five and you think, I want to win this game. And so you get your little nephew who's like five foot two, never played basketball in his life, and you take him out on the garage, on the pavement in front of your house where the basketball hoop is, and you just stomp the hell out of him. It's like 100 shots for you, zero shots for him, and you pat yourself on the back and away you go because you won.
- 5.100 But he doesn't want to play with you ever again, right? So that's a stupid strategy. And it's also not any fun unless you're really, you got to be pretty damn unsophisticated to want to stomp someone in a game who you know you can defeat with no effort. And you think, well, that's weird because you want to win, so why not just pick a partner that you can just wallop? And the answer is something like, well, it's not any fun. But then the question is, well, why the hell not? And the answer is, you don't want to just win. You want to get better while you play, right? So you want to find a partner who's as good as you, or maybe even slightly better.
- 5.101 And then that puts you on the edge. Right, edge of what? Edge of the development of your perceptions, your attention and your action. So you become a more skilled player, not only with regards to the mechanics of that particular game, but to the whole sequence of games that it's emblematic of. So maybe you want to, you have someone, you're an adolescent and you're not a bad basketball player. You're a little selfish and not so skilled, and you find the, you know, the captain of your team who everyone admires in your class, and not only because he happens to be better at basketball than you, but also is the sort of person who conducts himself, let's say, as a mentor on the field and off.
- 5.102 And so you hope to be friends with him, and then you play one-on-one basketball, and he teaches you how to be a better player. But while he's teaching you, he teaches you how to play

better. And that's a good deal. That's the what, that's the basic plot of, like, every sports film that's ever been made in the United States, right, is the construction of these hapless but somewhat skilled athletic adolescents into the men that they could become. Right. And it goes beyond the confines of the game, obviously.

- 5.103** In the biblical account, when Eve is derived from Adam, she's pulled from his rib. OK. Why? Partly because it's emblematic of inequality, and partly because the biblical insistence is that women are also structures, beings that have a patriarchally structured element. Right? Because there's a biological reality about femininity, but it's also socially constructed. It's also a phenomena that emerges from the male hierarchy. That's a good way of thinking about it. Eve's appellation in Hebrew is "ezer kenegdo", and ezer means something like partner in challenging play, right? So that's so cool. That's such a cool thing to understand.
- 5.104** And kenegdo—I'll tell you, the combination of the words ezer kenegdo means partner in play. Voluntary play. Challenging partner in voluntary play, but has a military aspect, too. And so the military aspect points to the idea of who you would want as an ally in battle. Right? So there's a voluntary play element to that, but it's more serious. It's like, who do you want by your side in normal times, but also in times of strife? And that isn't someone you can dominate or exercise power on. You remember, in the biblical corpus, man and woman are both made in the image of God. They're made as equals.
- 5.105** So then, you know, that begs the question of their precise relationship. And the relationship that's indicated by the etymology of the words is something like partners in the most challenging play. And that's not domination. And it's not subordination, but it's definitely challenge. Now, that's an interesting thing because one of the things that heightens sexual satisfaction is novelty, right? That's the origin of many fetishes. That's also why people often heighten their sexual pleasure by using incentive reward-facilitating chemicals like stimulants. Novelty can do the same thing.
- 5.106** So one of the ways of introducing the novelty into a relationship that will heighten sexual satisfaction over the long run is to keep the novelty occurring. And the way to do that is to ensure that there's optimal playful challenge within the relationship. So that's, what would you say? There's a search for diversity that characterizes particularly male sexual seeking. That can be satisfied in part by ensuring that there's enough novelty within the relationship to keep it alive. Right, and that's a challenge. It has, something that has to be maintained and facilitated.
- 5.107** OK, so what's the emotional landscape? You've got an aim. There are things that can confront you that will facilitate the aim. You're happy to see those things. There are things that can get in your way that are obstacles and challenges. You're unhappy to see those things generally, insofar as there are obstacles. There are things that happen that you can't predict and that are unknown. Those are the things that can take the bottom out of the quest itself. That's the portal to the underworld, the emergence of the unexpected in the midst of a frame.

- 5.108 That's, you wake up in the morning. Your world is all in alignment. You have an ache in your side. You think what the hell's going on? Maybe you're a bit concerned about it. You go to the physician and he says you have cancer. Well, that's the emergence of something obviously entropic and anomalous that blows the frame into bits and pulls you down, in that case involuntarily, into the **underworld** of complexity that underlies the particulars of your ordered and structured world. That's the **chaos** from which everything emerges. That's the dragon that you have to confront constantly in your life to make order.
- 5.109 So you could say your aim defines the phenomena and attributes determinate emotional significance to what you see. Most things are irrelevant to a given aim. That's how you deal with the complexity of the world. Most things are irrelevant. When the bottom falls out, you don't know what's irrelevant anymore. That's a terrible thing. Everything's chaotic and mixed up, and everything's up for grabs, and you're overwhelmed with anxiety. And that's partly the physiological state of preparation for the worst.

6. The Human Experience

AT A GLANCE

Continues the emotional landscape of the frame: the rabbit hole of the unexpected, the Tyrannosaurus and the zone of optimal development, and meaning as sword and shield. Reads Pascal on thrownness and the existential problem beneath every proximal pursuit, then Rogers on organismic enhancement, anxiety as incongruity, and psychopathology as internal disharmony. Draws the practical lessons: define your conditions for satisfaction, take the smallest step you will actually take, reward what you want more of (Skinner), and Rogers's listening rule of restating the other's view to their satisfaction, with Sleeping Beauty and play as the mark of a walled garden.

- 6.1 There's a whole emotional system that orients you in relationship to things that move you towards your goal. There's a whole emotional system that orients you in relationship to things that get in the way and that are unexpected, right? So this phenomenological landscape is so constant that your biology has adapted to its reality. It's so interesting because you think, well, emotions are subjective. It's like, yeah, but you have brain systems devoted to them. And the brain systems evolved and they evolved in response to the environment. And so does that mean the environment, that the emotional landscape is the environment, the objective environment? Well, your brain adapted to it.
- 6.2 So you can see the conundrum that the phenomenologists were trying to wrestle through. It's like, well, just exactly what's real here? The fact of the unexpected is so real that a huge part of your brain is devoted to its processing, right, from the level of reflex all the way up to highest conceptualization, the whole negative emotional system, which is like half of you. And it's the same with the positive emotional system. The positive emotional system signifies things that move you forward.
- 6.3 And those two systems, positive and negative emotion, they're tapping you and regulating you 100% of the time. And they're very ancient. It's not like they only evolved with human beings. They're there, way down early in the evolutionary pattern of development, way down early. Now, I don't know how primordial an animal you have to be before you don't have anxiety. And you might have something like pain, even when you're an amoeba. You at least have the proclivity to move away from what's noxious, even as a single-celled organism, to approach what's good and to move away from what's noxious. That's the foundation for emotional response, that approach or avoidance. Let's approach freezing or avoidance. That's the embodied understructure of emotion itself.
- 6.4 Within that frame, there's a hole. You might say, this is the rabbit hole that Alice goes into in Alice in Wonderland. That's down the rabbit hole. What's the rabbit hole? Things you don't expect. Where do, where does the pursuit of things you don't expect take you? Into a landscape where the Red Queen is at the bottom of the rabbit hole in the story of Alice in Wonderland.

She's the queen of horror who says, in my kingdom, you have to run as fast as you can just to stay in the same place. Right. That's Mother Nature herself.

- 6.5 That down the rabbit hole. That's a very old idea. That's the shamanic idea that we talked about already. That's the descent into the abyss. It's like there's a strange and mystical underworld under every frame of reference. You fall into that when weird and unexpected things happen to you. You're out in a territory that you haven't defined where anything is possible. Death and the possibility of radical transformation. Right? That's that hole. How does your nervous system respond when a hole like that appears?
- 6.6 My son, when he was three, I took him to the Boston Science Museum, and there was this skeleton of a Tyrannosaurus rex there. And he was a little ambivalent about that skeleton. It was fun to watch him, because there was a distance that he wanted to be away from it, but it wasn't so far away that he couldn't see it. Right, and you think, that's kind of interesting. He's three, and this is like, this is a monster. You know, its teeth are the size of his head. And you'd think the right place for a three-year-old to be would be not in the museum. Right? Or not even a place where he could think about the Tyrannosaurus.
- 6.7 But that isn't how it was. He would approach it and slow down, and then at some point, he was close enough to stop. OK, that's the zone of optimal development. That place. That's what you do to people in psychotherapy. You put them on the edge of what they're afraid of, so they're compelled by it. They want to look, but they don't need to run away. And then you say, OK, just watch yourself now that you're on that edge.
- 6.8 And what you'll see is, you will adapt to being there. OK. So your curiosity will grow and your apprehension, assuming the thing doesn't turn its head and look at you, your apprehension will decrease. And when your curiosity grows and your apprehension decreases because you voluntarily exposed yourself, you can take a step forward, right? And then you can keep doing that until you're looking at the heart of darkness itself, right? That's the transformation of psychotherapy.
- 6.9 And that's allied. This is so interesting. It's the same thing. It's a manifestation of the same process that integrates you across time. So you can imagine that there's no difference between that willingness to take a step forward in the face of ambivalence and participating in the process that organizes all of your emotions. So, for example, you could imagine some variant of the Tyrannosaurus rex that's the dragon. And then you could imagine that what you need to discover to take a step forward, when you're confronting the dragon that guards the treasure, is the aggression that would allow you to wield the sword properly, and the care that would enable you to use the shield appropriately.
- 6.10 Right. And so what's going to be called on you to develop, as you approach the thing that threatens you and terrifies you and compels you, is the integration of everything that would turn you into the sort of person who could continue to advance. See, and that's emblematic of the ethos that's not relative, that underlies genuine moral striving. How do you become a better

person? Well, what do you mean, better? It's like, more able to confront the transforming horizon of potential. More able to, more able to confront it in a way that makes you better in the future and continuing to get better. And that does the same thing to all the people around you in a way that they are pleased about and will get on board voluntarily with.

- 6.11 Right. The definition of a genuine leader. That's a pattern. And it's not, it's not arbitrary. Obviously, because of its significance. And it's also not relativistic. It's a pattern that exists across virtually every domain you can possibly imagine. And so, and that's the **quest** pattern, down the **rabbit hole**. What's the emotion associated with that? It's paradoxical. Some of it's, what the hell is this? Right, that's that alertness. That's mostly anxiety and some negative emotion.
- 6.12 You're awake. Right? That's what jars you out of sleep when you hear an alarm, for example, in the middle of the night or a baby crying. It's like, snap, you're awake, ready to contend. So there's the negative emotion that alerts you, puts you on your toes. And then there's the positive emotion that calls you forward. Now you could say, and I think you should say that, when you optimize those, that's when your life is optimally meaningful, right? That's the phenomena that, phenomenon that makes itself manifest to you as meaning. If you deepen that meaning—this is an existential claim—if you deepen that meaning, you can use it as the weapon that, what? You can use it as the sword and the shield that protects you and makes you capable of dealing with the worst that life can throw at you.
- 6.13 And so that's way different than the vision of happiness, let's say, or of harmony or of satiation. Right? That's way different than if you just had what you wanted, you'd be happy. It's way different than, what would you say? Subordination of everyone around you as a consequence of your striving for power and hedonic self-gratification. It's the notion that you can derive sufficient engagement, meaning, from the stance that you take with regard to the complexities of life to propel you through the worst that life can throw at you, and to continue to develop upwards while you do so.
- 6.14 Right. That's what is, that's what **Rogers** is attempting to facilitate in his clients, in his psychotherapeutic practice. That's what the behaviorists are doing too, when they expose people voluntarily to the things that they're afraid of. That's **exposure therapy**. That's what the psychoanalysts are doing when they walk people through the traumas of their past voluntarily, or get them to account for their experience in a manner that investigates every quadrant of their being. Right. It's all aimed at the same thing.
- 6.15 That hole that you can fall through, the existential, **existentialist** claim is that's not merely a consequence of the tragedies or traumas of life. **Pascal**, existential philosopher, says, "When I consider the brief span of my life, swallowed up in the eternity before and behind it, the small space that I fill or even see, engulfed in the infinite immensity of spaces which I know not and which know not me, I am afraid, and wonder to see myself here rather than there. For there's no reason why I should be here rather than there, now, rather than then."

- 6.16 That's a statement of the existential problem known as **thrownness**. There's an arbitrary element to life, right? Why are you here now, in the specific conditions of your life, in this, say, mortal frame surrounded by the infinite? Is that meaningless? Is that—what's the significance of that sort of arbitrary set of facts, your subjugation to the limitations of mortality and malevolence? How do you make sense of that? And you could think of that as the hole, in a way, that's underneath every proximal frame, right?
- 6.17 Because when you're engaged in something, a doubt can enter your mind, which is, why am I doing this? Why bother? Why do anything? You can ask that question about anything. And that's that realization of the mystery of the relationship of your finitude to the infinity that surrounds you, right? That's the existential conundrum. And the answer to that is something like **Jacob's Ladder**. It's something like participation in the continual upward spiral towards the ineffable infinite, as the medication to the, as the medication that, what would you say, heals? What would you say? Fortifies you in relationship to your recognition of the abyss that lies below you, right? That's the establishment of a relationship with the upward infinite.
- 6.18 Right, and that makes itself manifest, according to the **existentialists** and the **phenomenologists** as the, or **Jung** for that matter, as the instinct that impels you towards adventure and further development. You make an alliance with that. That's the same thing that the seekers are doing in the snitch game, when they chase the golden ball that zips this way and that, right, following the thing that glitters to them. Right.
- 6.19 That's the existential adventure, right? To have that, to not be considering satiation and satisfaction or hedonic gratification or power as the goal of your life, but participation in that seeking process that continues to expand you and to bring harmony intra-psychically and in your family and in the community. And the insistence is that there's nothing more real than that, including suffering. And so that's a remarkable thing to contemplate, and likely the case insofar as we can deal with suffering.
- 6.20 "Rarely has the existential question been put more simply or beautifully. In this passage, we see, first, the profound realization of the contingency, the arbitrariness of human life, which **existentialists** call **thrownness**." To be thrown into the world, is the derivation of that idea." Secondly, we see **Pascal** facing unflinchingly the question of being there, or more accurately, being where? Third, we see the realization that one cannot take refuge in some superficial explanation of time and space,"—some objective account with no existential significance —"which **Pascal** scientist that he was, could well know, and lastly, the deep shaking anxiety arising from this stark awareness of existence in such a universe."
- 6.21 Right. So that's the—see, the existential hypothesis is something like a set of problems beset you merely as a consequence of being human. So you can categorize them. There's the problem of you, right? You have to contend with yourself, your abilities, arbitrary though they may be, your inadequacies, your complexity, your suffering. You have to contend with the structuring of your intimate relationships and the social world, with all the benefits that are a consequence of that, and all the inhibition and struggle that goes along with it. The subordination of your own

will to that of others at every level of your social existence, and you have to contend with the stark realities of the natural world. That's the eternal landscape of the human being.

- 6.22 The religious enterprise, the religious narrative enterprise, lays out that landscape and tracks the pathway through. The **existentialists**, **existentialists** were in many ways trying to reconstitute that vision in the secular world. Right. And I think the **Jungian** school in particular is the, provides the capacity to fundamentally integrate across those views, especially with regards to the narrative of the hero that we've been outlining to some great degree.
- 6.23 That's the collapse. That's the **descent into the underworld**. That's part of the **shamanic tradition**. It's like the fact that you can fall down that **rabbit hole**, let's say, of doubt, at any time during your proximal pursuits. You could say that that's the beginning of wisdom. You know, like, you can hide from that in your narrow pursuits. You can refuse to address the more fundamental questions of existence, even though they'll haunt you when you're pursuing any proximal thing with the doubts about whether your material security is worth the suffering. For example, even if you're radically successful in your narrow way as a businessman.
- 6.24 Maybe you're an executive at Coca-Cola and you're making \$1 million a year and you think, "Why the hell am I selling sugar water to fat people?" Which is a perfectly reasonable question. And you think, well, you know, that's a question for the philosophers, and fair enough. And you can stay within that frame, but the doubt haunts you. And so then the question is, and maybe at some point in your life when things collapse around you, the doubt will overcome you and take you down into a pit of depression. That will happen involuntarily, and then you're in serious trouble.
- 6.25 Or maybe your marriage will collapse because you've been too narrowly focused on your executive career. Or maybe you're too materialistic and shallow, so you can't withstand any suffering. Or maybe you're so hedonistic that you have sequential affairs, right? So your fundamental existential orientation is fragile, but you reject any engagement with the deeper questions, the **rabbit hole** questions. And then you might say, well, what would happen instead if you took those doubts seriously? If you sat down and said, OK, what, what's everything I doubt?
- 6.26 And if you laid that out and you wrote that down, which you can do, and then you tried to address all those doubts—Why am I doing this? What's the fundamental reason? What's the extent of my doubt? Is there something there I can grapple with? Is there a philosophical solution to the ultimate question, something like the purpose of my life in the face of suffering—and you do that voluntarily, that's that process of coming to know yourself that **Socrates** recommended.
- 6.27 Well, you might think that's a hopeless endeavor because there's no final answer. But the problem with that is the question will chase you. And if you don't pursue it voluntarily, it will corner you at the worst time of your life when you're weakest and you will be in trouble then. And the alternative is to go down the **rabbit hole** and to—that's the voluntary **shamanic**

transformation— and to take it on voluntarily and to discover what's down there. The deepest hole, the abyss, Dante's Inferno, right, where the greatest treasure also lies. And having done that, you're initiated. That's a baptism in fire. And you're ready when seriously terrible things actually come your way. That's the promise.

- 6.28** And what's the guide? The sense of meaning that is characteristic of the markers of the **quest** on the way to the ascent. The goal is, how can I be a better person? What do I have to give up in order to manage that? That's a prayer, that's for sure. You realign your perceptions in consequence. Then the markers that demarcate that pathway forward show themselves to you in the form of what plagues your **conscience** and what calls to you to move forward. Right, once you get that orientation in mind.
- 6.29** That's what you're trying to do with people in psychotherapy. What's your problem? That's the first thing you ask when someone comes in. It's like, why do you think you're here? And you have to listen to the person because you don't know why they're there. You don't rush to diagnosis unless you want a bill from the insurance company. It's like, you have a problem. It's like, well, what's your problem? Man, that can take three months just to figure out what the hell the problem is. Is the problem your wife? Is the problem your job? Is the problem you? Is it your father? Is it your mother? Is it some physical illness that you have? Is it your existential condition? Is it the political landscape? God only knows.
- 6.30** And then after you delve into that, it's like, what the hell is the problem? What do you want to do about it? Like, if you could have what you want, what would that look like? Well, there's another six months of discussion to be had about that. What would actually satisfy you? This is something to really understand if you're fighting with your intimate partner because you're annoyed at them. It's like, if they have any sense, they're going to say, is there something I could say that even in principle would make you happy? And your partner will say, if you loved me, you'd know. And that's a terrible answer. It's like, I can hardly understand myself. Don't be expecting me to be able to figure out what would make you happy when you don't even know.
- 6.31** So what do you want to do? Figure out your conditions for satisfaction and play a straight game, including with yourself. Because otherwise you won't know when you succeed or when you fail, and the other person will only be able to figure you out by impaling themselves on your thorns. And that's a terrible way to conduct yourself. And so you have to ask yourself, it's like, OK, you get to have what you want, hypothetically. But here's the rule. You have to figure out what it is. Now, people won't do that. They won't define themselves, partly because they don't want to know what their conditions for failure, failure are. If you leave yourself vague, you don't know when you're inadequate, and that's a good deal for you.
- 6.32** The problem with that is you don't know when you're progressing and you have no idea where you're heading, and that means everything's vague and ill-defined around you, and you will suffer and you'll have no hope. That's a stupid deal. It's like, if you could have what you want. There's a gospel proclamation about the nature of God. Knock and the door will open. Ask and you'll receive. Seek and you'll find. So what does it mean? You have to want to know. You have

to open the doors when they make themselves manifest, which means, you have to have the destination.

- 6.33 That would, what would you say, manifest itself behind that door in mind. And what is that? Hopefully it's your decision at the base level of your soul that you'd rather re-enter the garden of paradise, let's say, than live in purgatory or hell. And you'd think, well, obviously. It's like, don't be fooling yourself. It's not so obvious. We already know that it's down the **rabbit hole** first, and God only knows what you'll have to sacrifice. So it's no trivial game, because everything's on the line, and there's always the sword that cuts and turns every which way. What would you say? Confronting you as you try to move forward. That doesn't mean it's impossible, but it's not something that's light and easy, that's for sure. But that's OK because you don't want that anyways. There's no light and easy solution to the problem of suffering in your life.
- 6.34 "**Existentialism** is not a comprehensive philosophy or way of life, but an endeavor to grasp reality, immersed in and arising out of Western man's anxiety, estrangement, and conflict." You could say in the aftermath of the death of God, that's the historical context for this utterance. "Like psychoanalysis, **existentialism** seeks to utilize these conflicts as avenues to more profound understanding of Western man." That's the transformation process. Aim. **Rabbit hole. Descent into the underworld.** Reconfiguration of aim. Reemergence with new aim. Right? That's the **death and resurrection.** Then you can think of that as sequential and upward-moving and never-ending. And that's the process of transformation.
- 6.35 And then the fundamental moral rule is, never substitute success in any proximal frame for movement across the set of frames. Right? Always prioritize upward-seeking transformation over proximal victory. Right. The fundamental moral presumption. That's, what would you say, that's prioritization of the spirit of the law over the law. That's another way of looking at it, because the spirit of the law is what gives rise to the law to begin with, right? And that's allegiance, primary allegiance, to the culture hero. That's another way of thinking about it.
- 6.36 OK. **Rogerian** psychotherapy. What's the motive? **Organismic enhancement** is central motive. All living organisms strive to maintain further and actualize their experience. The self and the organism is best construed as positive, creative striver. Right, so the fundamental motivation isn't escape from pain or movement towards pleasure, or even adaptation to reality in that **Freudian** sense. It's something like upward-striving integration. That's the big contribution of the **humanist** movement in the psychological tradition. Right? The idea of **self-actualization.**
- 6.37 Now it's a shallow ideal if it's only focused on the narrow intrapsychic self. It's all about you putting yourself together, you being the best you you can be. It's like no, because you have to get along with other people, right? And so it's much better to think of that **self-actualization** as the internalization of a kind of harmony that makes you a very good husband, a very good brother, a very good son. Right. A positive contributor to your family, a great mother, a grandmother, a caretaker of the broader community, at the same time that you're attending to

your own needs in a manner that makes you even more effective at being of service to other people, right?

- 6.38 So that's the problem with the psychological tradition, as such. All of these clinical theories, they're very, very individual focused. And that's a mistake. Piaget is a good antidote to that, because they don't take into account the necessary concordance between the internal psychological integration and the integration, say, within a family. I had a neighbor on my street once say to me, "You're never any happier as a mother than your most miserable child." Right. And so you think, well, you want to get your act together and be happy, but your child is suffering. It's like, well, you're not going to manage that without fixing that suffering and your relationship, because your psychological integrity is actually dependent on the harmony of your social relations. And so the reparation isn't just self.
- 6.39 So Rogers also defined anxiety not so much as response to threat or punishment, which is a more behavioral definition, but as incongruity. If you're racked with internal conflict between your different motivational states and frames, that's going to produce anxiety. And that would be a marker of the kind of internal— internal incongruity that makes you a house divided amongst yourself. And why is that a problem that would be marked instinctually with anxiety? It's like, well, if you want to do A, and simultaneously you do want to do B and C, and you can't do them at the same time, or they conflict, then something should mark that. And what marks it is anxiety. You don't know which way is up.
- 6.40 Well, why is that a problem? Well, how are you going to get somewhere when you're trying to get two contradictory places at the same time? Or 10? You have to not only prioritize, so that one thing becomes paramount in any action, but you have to prioritize so that's sustainable across the long run and then that everything that needs to be done is simultaneously accomplished. Very difficult, a very difficult thing to manage. But that production of that harmony eliminates existential anxiety.
- 6.41 And it's partly because, if the pathway forward is clear and the obstacles are minimized and all that's left on the landscape, the frame landscape, the existential landscape, is the pathway and friends and things that facilitate your movement forward, or even things that facilitate your movement forward, friends and magical entities that transform you even further, there's nothing that you experience that isn't positive or even meta-positive, right? So that's the advantage of that harmony, is you start to exist in a state that's fundamentally characterized by excitement, curiosity, courage, faith, humility, gratitude, incentive, reward, all the advantages of the positive element of the quest, allies, friends, right, profound relationships, and an ever-expanding framework of opportunity.
- 6.42 Right, and that's a reality. And it speaks of the consequence of sufficient exploration to subdue everything properly and put it in its proper place. Right. And to cast your attentive eye on the obstacles that would have stopped you, and to transform them into irrelevance, or into things that move you forward, right, to solve your problems. Rogers viewed in psychological pathology as something like internal disharmony. Right, so it was the war of all against all internally and

socially. You have no way of integrating or even of recognizing your own motivations, your own emotions, your own desires, your wants, your wishes. It's a landscape of competition, and you're in competition with other people, non-productive competition.

- 6.43 And so you're stymied in your advance. No positive emotion, and everything's too complex. So that's stressful. And much is punishing because you're encountering nothing but obstacles. So that's the landscape of suffering. And so, how does Rogers address that? Rogers construed the therapeutic relationship. And so this would be true of relationship generally. This would be true of dialogue generally, and that would be dialogue as a manifestation of **logos**. And that's the redeeming word.
- 6.44 Now remember that Rogers was a Protestant seminarian. So that metaphysic permeates the manner in which he looks at the world. There's a statement, I believe, again, that it's in the Gospels, that wherever two or more are gathered in my name, there I am amongst you. OK, so what does that mean? It means something very specific. So I had a friend. Scandinavian. He married another Scandinavian. They're from northern Alberta. They went to Sweden to be married. And in their marriage ceremony, they held a candle aloft. OK. A candle is a symbol of illumination and light. Right? Light in the darkness. You decorate Christmas trees, which are a sign of life in the darkness of winter, with candles.
- 6.45 That's the reemergence of the sun at the darkest time of the year. The light is associated with illumination and **logos**. You hold it aloft if you're married. Why? Because the two of you as a married couple make one thing. What's the thing? The light. Right? The light is the union between the man and the woman. What's the union dependent on? **Logos**. What is that? Communication. Right, dialogue. Negotiation.
- 6.46 The Rogerian psychotherapeutic enterprise is negotiation. It's negotiation between all of your internal disharmonious motivation and emotional states, which need to be given voice, which need to have a dialogue, so they can settle their differences, come to agreement, and play the same game. The same is true within the confines of a relationship. The advantage of the "**ezer kenegdo**" relationship, the fact that you have to battle things out for harmony with your wife, is that if you do that, you also refine your own soul, and you set up the platform so you can bring children into the world, so that they can play harmoniously and develop properly.
- 6.47 There's no difference between struggling with your wife for harmony in relationship to how your domestic affairs might be settled, and how your life might progress. There's no difference between that and getting your own house in order. They're the same thing. That's why in my books I recommended to people that, if they're trying to start cleaning up their life, they can start by making their bed. You think, well, what the hell does that have to do with anything? It's like, well, if your existence is your **phenomenological field**, and your goal is to make order, an order that's good, you can make order anywhere, and you might as well start where you can.
- 6.48 And you think, well, that's beneath me. It's like, really? Is it? Why is your bed unmade, then? If you're so superior, why isn't your closet in order? Why is everything around you a chaotic mess?

That's all **pre-cosmogonic chaos**, right. Potential that hasn't been cast into actuality. One of the things you do as a behaviorist is you say, well, let's look at where your world is disordered, like all of it, practically speaking. No one wants to go work in an office that's a chaotic mess. Now, some creative people have stacks everywhere, you know, but they know where everything is.

- 6.49 And there's pathological forms of order, too. But you want to set up your working environment so that it's inviting to you, so that it's not anxiety-provoking when you enter it, and so that the design and layout are emblematic of your goals. And you can do that very practically. You can do that in the confines of your space. And the behavioral rule with regards to upward movement is start where you're willing to, and you can play that game with yourself, you know.
- 6.50 I had a client once. He was very immature, still lived at home. He was like 35. He had a baby out of wedlock and he wanted to be such, not such a useless person because now he had a child, and he hadn't cleaned up his bloody room since he was in high school. You know, it was just a mess. And so that's what we started with. It's like, well, could you vacuum your rug? And he took the vacuum out of the closet and brought it to his room and left it in the bloody doorway at 45 degrees and stepped over it for a week. That was the hero who ran from the task at the threshold of the opportunity.
- 6.51 Right, because he knew that if he vacuumed his rug, it was like, well, that was the beginning of, what, his maturity? And so he got it all the way to the door and then left it as an obstacle. And so what do you do with someone like that? It's like, could you move the vacuum this week into your room? Do you think you could do that? It's an empirical question; that's **collaborative empiricism**. Go try. Maybe you can and maybe you can't. If you can't, well, we'll draw the conclusion from that. Can you shift it one inch? Right. So part of the trick is, if you start to move upward, is, what's the minimum step that you will actually take?
- 6.52 And there's humility in that too. You know how embarrassing it is to be 35 and to come back to your therapist and say, you know, I was supposed to vacuum my rug, which would have taken me like ten minutes. And I agreed that I would do it. And I'm 35. And yet what I did was leave it in my doorway. Well, that's a humbling experience. And you can see that that might destroy your hope and your faith in yourself. It's like, no, we'll be able to find a small step that you will take.
- 6.53 And the advantage to that—progress doesn't increase linearly and neither does collapse. The world is structured so that progress looks like this. And so does collapse. That's the abyss, right, and heaven. So once you start moving upward, every step you take increases the probability that you'll take the next step. And so that's an exponentially increasing process. And so the positive side of that is, it doesn't matter where you start. It matters that you start. And the humility is, hey, if you're not doing something, keep cutting the task down until you'll do it.
- 6.54 If you have a stack of papers in your office that are full of things that you've been putting off for like five years, you know, you won't even look at that bloody stack when you go into your room. You notice this. You'll, like, you'll do this. It's an embodied avoidance. And one of the things you

can do is just like, go to the stack and open the top folder and just sort through the papers. Just look at them. And that's enough often to overcome that initial terror of the beast of the abyss and to start moving forward. So you have to play this.

- 6.55** You can do this with your wife, your husband, your kids. It's like, what's the minimum step in the right direction you're willing to take? That's a negotiation. That's one of the things you discover in psychotherapy. Here's the theory, "assuming a minimal mutual willingness to be in contact and to receive communications." OK. So this is the dynamic for a relationship that's sustainable. You will talk to me. You will tell me what you think, the best you can, and I will listen, and you'll do the same. That's the contractual, that's the marital relationship. That's the contract that underlies any harmonious, potentially harmonious and productive relationship. Those are the axiomatic preconditions.
- 6.56** You're willing to let that process of communication take place. OK, if you're willing, "we may say that the greater the communicated congruence of experience, awareness, and behavior on the part of one individual"—honesty, the better I am at actually telling you what's going on with me and what I want—"the more the ensuing relationship will involve a tendency towards reciprocal communication with the same qualities." Well, you can understand that. If you model for me the process of honest self-disclosure, then even if I'm not very good at it, I can watch what you do and I can learn to imitate it, and I can reciprocate.
- 6.57** And, you know, in any intimate relationship, you'll be teaching each other because there'll be some things you're better at contending with and admitting to, and some things that your partner is better at. And if you engage in that dance, and that's what people are mimicking when they dance, by the way, the better you are at doing that, the more the relationship will grow and grow in a positive direction. "The more the ensuing relationship will involve a tendency towards reciprocal communication with the same qualities, mutually accurate understanding of the communications, improved psychological adjustment and functioning in both parties, and mutual satisfaction in the relationship."
- 6.58** That's the axiomatic presumption of this psychotherapeutic bond. But it's basically the bond of honest relationship, predicated on the idea that the truth will set you free, and that the spirit that's in the room when honest communication takes place is, you could say, the God of Isaac and Abraham that marks the pathway upward on Jacob's ladder towards the infinite—what would you say? The infinite expanse of heaven upward.
- 6.59** And you have to, you have to decide if you believe that, because you're stuck with belief in this situation. Because here's your options. You can believe that communication is unnecessary. That's a statement of faith. You can get along in the world without communicating. You have no evidence for that, right? It's an a priori conviction. You can believe that you can manipulate and lie your way to what you want. Or you can believe that if you communicate in a manner that's honest and real, that you can do that, and that things will improve. Those are your options.

- 6.60 And every single one of those options is a variant of philosophical faith or axiom. Because there's—is there evidence that lies work? Well, people wouldn't lie if there was no evidence that lies work. Obviously they work. Every three-year-old figures out they can get away with something by lying about it. Is that the rock upon which you should build your house? That's up to you. Do you have to tell people what you need and want? Do you have to take that risk? Not necessarily. Your life will unfold in some particular way if you don't. Or you can believe, you can have the courage, let's say, the existential courage, to assume that if you knock, the door will open, that that's how the world is constituted.
- 6.61 And in the fundamental final analysis, that is a proclamation of faith in the redemptive power of the word. OK. Now, I said I was going to teach you something very practical from Rogers. So let's do this. This is very much worth understanding. If you master this and you can, it'll change your life. Maybe you already know how to do it. Probably not. Most people don't, and they're not taught. It's a stunning thing. It's one of the things we do unbelievably badly in our culture, is teach people how to negotiate.
- 6.62 We'll teach them how to attain victory, or even that they should. It's like, if you want to have a successful business, the pathway to that is actually fairly straightforward. How do you do it? You conduct yourself so that people are thrilled to be interacting with you—your employees, your colleagues, your customers, your suppliers, everyone around you, the people you're communicating with in marketing. You want to be hospitable. You want to make them happier to deal with you than with anyone else. And you can do that if that's your aim.
- 6.63 And you do that by listening, just like Jimmy Carr, when he's collecting jokes before he goes out on the road. Your customers will tell you when they're dissatisfied. Your partner in marriage will tell you. They'll signify that by their behavior, your children as well, when you're doing something they'd like you to continue. Here's a hint, too, for your life. You watch this, you learn to do this, and it'll change your life too.
- 6.64 B.F. Skinner noted that when he was training animals, it was more effective to use reward than punishment, but reward took attention. So the way that Skinner would train a rat to climb a ladder—he could get rats to do anything he could possibly imagine—as he'd watch the rat, and a hungry rat, by the way, he'd watch the rat, and as soon as it was near the ladder, he'd give it something to eat. And soon it was hanging around by the ladder, and then it would be hanging around by the ladder, doing rat exploratory things, and it would put a paw on the ladder. It's like, food.
- 6.65 Soon the rat was doing this, and every time it did that, Skinner would give it a food pellet. And so now he's got a rat that's doing this, and soon it did this. Food pellet. And then he could get the rats to go up ladders and dance and do everything. He taught pigeons to guide guided missiles in World War II, pecking at photographs, so you can train an animal to do anything with reward. Same with you. Same with the people around you.

- 6.66 So here's here's the lesson from that. Watch the people around you. This is, assumes that you know what you want. Whenever they do something that you would like them to do more of, tell them, say, "Ha, I saw you do that. Here's exactly what you did. I'm very pleased to see that." You do that with children, man, they'll just—first of all, they're thrilled that you noticed. Because even though you don't know it, people are throwing out little positive gestures all the time, but they're terrified that no one will notice. And so they're kind of timid about it. They kind of hide it. It's like they sneak it out. And if you're smart enough to say, "Ha, I saw what you did, and that was good," it's like, those things will just start to happen around you all the time.
- 6.67 Grading essays. One of the things I used to do because I'd, you know, highlight the things that people did wrong. And there were plenty of them. It's like, now and then, you'd see in the worst essay, the student decided to emerge from the land of hackneyed cliché and actually put down a thought, and it was like they were terrified. They hid it under all this foliage and garbage, like Adam hiding from God behind a bush. It's like nonsense, cliché, nonsense, cliché, thought, nonsense, cliché. And they're hoping, the part of them that generates something original, is hoping that someone would notice, and terrified that that would be the one thing in the essay that got criticized.
- 6.68 And so if I circled that twice and put two exclamation marks next to it and said, "That's, you did that right," the next essay would be like 25% that, and two essays down the road, it was all that. And you can do that to yourself too, once you know what you want. You figure out what you want. Then you notice one day you did it and you think, oh, you got to reward yourself for that. Maybe you take yourself out for coffee, whatever you want. You mark it and you don't treat it lightly. And even neurologically, you know, if you reward something, it grows, right? That's what, that's what, that's how reward reinforces. It bathes the circuits that were active in a chemical that makes them proliferate.
- 6.69 And so if you're watching the people around you and you reward them for what they do that's specific and good, and you tell them what it was so they know specifically what you're referring to, they're thrilled. That's the, what would you say? The life-enhancing consequence of the investment of the attention that's love. It works like a charm.
- 6.70 OK, listening. "Real communication occurs and the evaluative tendency avoided." What's the evaluative tendency? I'm going to listen to you, but you're going to tell me something I don't want to hear. And so, because I don't want to hear it, because it'll take me down a rabbit hole, then I evaluate it and reject it. And maybe I do that by arguing with you or just by not listening. OK. Not helpful. You suspend that and say, "Well, I'm going to listen to you. I'm not going to assume you're right, that I'm wrong, or that you're wrong and I'm right. I'm just going to leave that be. I'm going to let you put your cards on the table and see what happens."
- 6.71 That's a lot of what you do in psychotherapy when you're diagnosing. It's like, what do you think your problem is? Well, you don't bloody well know. So you got to wander around, maybe through your whole life, to figure out what's wrong, randomly, with a lot of misapprehension and misdiagnosis, a lot of noise. And you have to be able to tolerate that, right? Not take it

personally. And it's good if the person that's talking to you knows that, too. It's like, we're going to listen, but we're not going to jump to conclusions one way or another. We're just going to lay out the landscape, right. Then we can see what to do with what we've revealed.

- 6.72 What does this mean? It means to see the expressed idea and attitude from the other person's point of view. So that means that willingness to go down a **rabbit hole**, out of your **frame of reference**, into theirs. Now that's anxiety-provoking because it puts some **entropy** into your system. But the advantage is, you get to have another viewpoint. And if you're so right, you already live in heaven, you don't need that. But if your life is still not what it could be, maybe there's something else you have to learn. And so having the opportunity to see something from someone else's point of view is a huge advantage.
- 6.73 That's why you go see stories, because you get to live the life of someone else. You can do that by listening. It's why I loved being a psychotherapist. It was so interesting. It was like being in a **Dostoyevsky** novel all the time. People are so interesting, if you listen to them, that they're unbearable. That's part of why people don't listen. They're so weird, they're so peculiar, even simple people. There's no such thing as a simple person, regardless of their intellectual prowess.
- 6.74 If you're bored by someone, you're dull. You don't know how to listen. You don't know how to ask the right questions. You, you've allowed the discourse to stay in the land of hackneyed cliché. If you actually listen, people are so interesting you can hardly stand being around them. And so that's also useful to know. If the people around you bore you, you're the boring one. So that's a terrible thing to understand. You don't know how to listen. OK, so what do you do about that? Well, **Rogers** knows. "It means to see the expressed idea and attitude from the other person's point of view," to infer and adopt their aim. That's what you do when you go to a movie and adopt that fictional **frame of reference**. You allow yourself to do that. It's exciting.
- 6.75 "To achieve his **frame of reference** in regard to the thing he is talking about. Stated so briefly, this may seem absurdly simple, but it's not. It's an approach which we have found extremely potent in the field of psychotherapy. It is perhaps the most effective agent we know for altering the basic personality structure of an individual," listening, "and improving his relationships and his communications with others. If I can listen to what he tells me, if I can understand how it seems to him, if I can see its personal meaning for him, I can sense the emotional flavor which it has for him, then I will be releasing potent forces of change within him."
- 6.76 Why? Well, look, maybe you're recounting your story. You've never told it to yourself because you weren't interested and no one else took the time. And so now you're talking to someone who's actually listening. OK. So what does that indicate to you? It indicates that they're willing to devote their most valuable resource, their attention, to the structure of your experience. They indicate by that that it's valuable. They might indicate by that to you that it's more valuable than you think. I had so many clients, especially people who had never been listened to in their whole life, and there's lots of people like that. They were so relieved.

- 6.77 One client I remember in particular, I, for the first eight years I saw her, I probably said 20 words in each therapy session. She was pretty isolated. She came about once every week or once every two weeks. All she did was tell me what was going on, and it took like eight years before we could actually start having a dialogue. She couldn't have a dialogue with anyone. She was so full of things that she shouldn't, hadn't said, that she had to spend, who knows what, 3,000 hours talking before she could engage communally because no one had ever paid any attention to her. Ever.
- 6.78 And so people love—if you pay attention to people, they're so happy with you, they can't stand it. It's a risky thing to do, but it's, and that's the same with paying attention to yourself. And Rogers, who's an optimist in this regard, but it's this logos-based faith, he believes that, well, if you listen to people, they'll change. And not only will they change, but they'll change positively, and so will you. That's a cool thing, too, if it's true. If I can listen, if I can really understand how he hates his father instead of thinking, well, you shouldn't hate your father, you know, it's like, well, do you hate your father?
- 6.79 My wife had a rocky relationship with her father for complex reasons. I thought he was great. He had his problems, but I thought he was great. But there were reasons my wife had trouble with him. And she decided she was going to sort that out, at one point. She made a goal of fixing her relationship with her father, and then she started to think it through. And the first thing she realized was, once she actually expressed it, there were, like, four things she really liked about her father, or maybe 10 things, for every one thing that she was uncomfortable with. And when she was done sorting it all out, there was really only one habit that he had that she found distressing in a, like, an ocean of things she was grateful for.
- 6.80 So even though the initial presumption was trouble in the relationship, once it was differentiated, it was like, no, it was one thing that had cast a pall over everything and never been thought through, partly because part of the assumption in her familial structure was, part of it was, fundamentally, men aren't really trustworthy. And so, you know, that's a problematic relationship if, presumption, if you have a husband and sons, for example, or if you have to live in the world, which is like half men.
- 6.81 And so one of the advantages of listening, and you'll see this with every problem that people address, is that once this is true in your own life, once you face the problem and differentiate it, you'll find that much of your fear is unwarranted. Not all of it. It'll get a lot more focal. The problem will still be there, but it's very frequently the case that you'll cut it down to manageable size as long as you're willing to look at it. So, "if I can catch the fear of his insanity, or atom bombs, or of Russia, it will be of the greatest help to him in altering those very hatreds and fears, and in establishing realistic and harmonious relationships with the various people and situations toward which he's felt hatred and fear."
- 6.82 So that's Rogers' presumption that a fair bit of unnecessary emotion on the negative side will evaporate in consequence of careful exploration. And that's definitely the case. That's that differentiation of the world. It's like, I'm terrified of that. It's like, that's a global, vague prey

animal-like generic stress response. You watch and look, and you take apart with your eyes and your tongue, and you see exactly what's there. And what you'll find, virtually without exception, is that you have unexamined resources personally and in your broader circle, or could obtain them, that will help you overcome that obstacle.

- 6.83** So you have to have faith to do that, right? I mean, maybe someone close to you is dying and you think, I can't handle this. It's like, what if you made all the relationships around you 25% better? Could you handle it then? How about 50% better? How about if you expanded your friendship network, right? Or how about if you decreased your fear of death in the more general sense, by examining it more carefully and understanding the conditions under which life is valuable, even in the face of death?
- 6.84** Or what if you started to understand that, although you're suffering because someone who's close to you is dying, that the fact that you're suffering as a consequence of their mortality is an indication that you love them despite their limitation, and that that means that you concluded that life was worthwhile, even though it's finite and bounded. Right, you don't know what possibility exists in the restructuring of your conceptual schemes, if you dive down the **rabbit hole** far enough, right? You need the faith to do that. The faith and the courage to do that. That's what genuine faith in the sacred actually is, is that willingness to take the risk, not some belief and some claptrap collection of idiot superstitions.
- 6.85** "We know from our research that such **empathic understanding**—understanding with a person, not about him, not evaluative—is such an effective approach that it can bring about major changes in personality." Some of you may be feeling that you listen well to people and that you've never seen such results. The chances are very great indeed that your listening has not been of the type I've described. Fortunately, I can suggest a little laboratory experiment which we can try to test the quality of your understanding.
- 6.86** The next time you get into an argument with your wife or friend, or with a small group of friends, stop the discussion for a moment and, for an experiment, institute this rule. Each person can speak up for himself only after he's first restated the ideas and feelings of the previous speaker accurately and to that speaker's satisfaction. This is such a wonderful thing to master. It'll make you a master of dialogue and communication. So you listen and you say, "Here's what I think you said." Now what you'll do, maybe they've said something to you for ten minutes. You're not going to remember all that. What you're going to do is compress it. You think, OK, I kind of got the gist of what you were communicating, I think. Here's what I think you said. Is that what you said?
- 6.87** Now, if you got it right, they're thrilled because you just said what took them ten minutes to say in 30 seconds. So you've compressed their problem accurately. They're thrilled about that. That's kind of a diagnosis. And if they say, "Yeah, you got it," well then, then what? Well, then they know you listened. So they're pretty happy about that. They know you care because you listened well enough to get it accurately, and you both understand what the hell's going on. So that's a, that's a great deal.

- 6.88 And then the person they think, "Oh, wow. You know, I didn't even know I said that. And look, that person really listened." And then they trust you, and them, and then they'll go a little deeper. And so then they'll do the same thing again. And then you can do the same thing. That's, it's ridiculously, ridiculously entertaining and so productive. And people will just, they'll start kind of dull, you know, and if you can extract out something interesting and crucial they said and give it back to them, then they'll produce more of that. And then if you do the same thing, then they even get better at that. And it's like, down you go into the depths.
- 6.89 And that's, there isn't anything more engrossing than that. And I think it's because it is part of this process by which the world transforms. And you can do that. You can make an agreement with your wife, your husband, just to do that. It's like, when we talk, this is what's going to happen. I'm going to listen until you think it's my turn to talk, and then I'm going to tell you what you said, and we're not going to progress until you agree that that's what you said. And there's no misunderstanding, then, you know, and that's, it's such a relief because you know you're stepping on firm ground then as you're proceeding in the discussion, and you both trust each other.
- 6.90 It's not like it's easy, you know, but you can do it and you can get better at it. It would simply mean "each person can speak up for himself only after he has first restated the ideas and feelings of the previous speaker accurately, and to that speaker's satisfaction." You see what this would mean. It would simply mean that before presenting your viewpoint, which you're going to try to justify because you don't want to go down the rabbit hole, you would, it would be necessary for you to really achieve the other speaker's frame of reference.
- 6.91 No straw man. Now, you don't want to turn your wife into a straw man, right? Maybe she's got a problem. Maybe she's not stating it very well, but she has a problem. And maybe you can win the argument. And maybe because you're more verbally fluent, let's say, you can win 50 arguments in a row. And so she doesn't get to talk and she feels like a bloody fool and she thinks she's a fool. And now you're married to someone who's convinced they're a fool. Well, that's really going to work out well for you, isn't it? Because that's really what you want, is you want a wife who has no self-esteem, who can't stand up for herself, and who's convinced that she's a fool.
- 6.92 Now, the upshot for you is, well, you're right. It's like, yeah, but now you're living with someone defeated. Good work. It's like, here's an alternative. Why don't you take her argument and strengthen it, even if it's against you? Make the strongest possible case for what she said. Fortify it, and then see if there's anything there. And maybe there is, and maybe there isn't. But at least you'll bloody well get to the bottom of it. And then she'll know, too, that you're on her side, even when she's criticizing you. Well, man, that's a—and maybe you'll find out something about yourself that you need to fix. And that's a pain in the neck, but man, it's a good deal. Especially if it's not, like, too much to handle and you can maybe rectify it a bit, and maybe she'll have enough patience to put up with you while you do it, because you listened. And so that's helpful.

- 6.93 Sounds simple, doesn't it? But if you try it, you'll discover it's one of the most difficult things you've ever tried to do. However, once you've been able to see the other points, other's point of view, your own comments will have to be drastically revised. Another impediment to listening. You'll also find the emotion going out of the discussion. If you haven't stated something clearly, it will be emotional, right? Because emotion is the impulse to make something you don't understand clear. And so if you're emotional, it's like it hasn't been semantically formulated sufficiently. That's the indication. It's something striving to be revealed that hasn't yet been transformed into **logos** order. Right.
- 6.94 And so the fact that the emotion is there means that the discussion hasn't progressed sufficiently. You'll also find the emotion going out of the discussion, the differences being reduced, because you'll discover what you're fighting about and what you're not fighting about. And those differences which remain being of a rational and understandable sort. If you really understand a person in this way, if you're willing to enter his private world and see the way life appears to him, you run the risk of being changed yourself.
- 6.95 That's the impediment. Right? It's like, why would that stop you? You know, if you're communicating with someone and they could offer you something, even an observation about yourself that would enable you to improve, you'd think you'd accept that gratefully. Why would that bother you? Well, we know that, because if you have to revise your worldview, even in a relatively minor way, because you've experienced, you've incorporated new information, the first thing that happens is a collapse of the old system before its **reconstitution**.
- 6.96 And so this is why the Israelites have to go through the desert before they escape from tyranny. But not to the Promised Land. They escape to the tyranny, from the tyranny, they go into the desert and then to the Promised Land. You don't ever learn something without a small death. Right. So there's impediments. That's the impediment to learning. But if you know the process, which is, yeah, it's going to be a pain listening to you, man, that's going to be a pain. It's definitely the case in an intimate relationship.
- 6.97 If you're trying to sort something out about your kids, for example, and the way you're interacting with them, first of all, it's really complicated. And you might be right and your husband might be right. You don't know. And maybe there's some way that you're interacting with your kids that's just not right. And you want to fix that because otherwise, obviously—and it might be a pain because maybe you learned something horrible from your mother and it's going to take some **reconstitution** to fix it, and vice versa, you know.
- 6.98 Maybe your husband's a bit of a tyrant because his dad and his dad's dad had that tyrannical bent, and that has to be taken apart, and that will be a death and a rebirth. But the upshot is so positive. If you can withstand it, you know. But you have to have the faith and courage that this process will work, that there is an uphill path, and that you could change for the better.
- 6.99 You run the risk of being changed yourself. You might see it his way. That's annoying. You might find yourself influenced in your attitudes or personality. Well, pride is the interference with that.

Like, if you already got everything nailed down and are perfect, you don't have to listen. And you can decide that for yourself. You know, if you live in paradise, you don't have to listen to anybody. But if you don't, you might think, yeah, probably, either the world's constituted so that suffering is inevitable no matter what, or I have something to learn.

- 6.100** And so then you can hope that, if you listen to your wife, for example, she'll tell you something that you probably need to know. And God only knows what obstacles that will clear from your path in the future, because maybe your tyrannical attitude towards her and your kids is also seriously interfering with your effectiveness as a mentor or an employer at work, or in your relationship with your customers, because you're kind of derisive and dismissive, let's say, to their complaints. That's a great way to make your business fail.
- 6.101** You know, someone will come in with a problem and you're above it all. And so you treat them dismissively. It's like, that, I didn't have to put up with that idiot. So then what happens? That idiot goes and tells a thousand people what a prick you are. And that happens 10 times in your community of 10,000. And that's the end of your business. So these things spread quick.
- 6.102** "If I enter fully as I am able into the private world of the neurotic or psychotic individual, isn't there a risk that I might become lost in that world?" It is frightening. You know, if you're talking to your wife, say, and it's about a serious problem and she's trapped in her familial past in relationship to that conceptualization, and there's a lot of darkness and betrayal there. And you take on that viewpoint. You can feel all that. You can experience it. You see that happening. It's really upsetting. It's really easy to avoid that.
- 6.103** And, but if you, if you can withstand it and you can analyze it, then you can, well, that's how you rescue the maiden from the clutches of the dragon, by the way. Right, and that works. That works. And, you know, in the story of *Sleeping Beauty*, remember, that is that when the prince is trapped in the castle and the evil woman, the witch, turns into the dragon that confronts him, right? That's the impediment that women put forward to a relationship with them. It makes itself manifest in their choosiness with regards to male partners, for example.
- 6.104** And it is Mother Nature itself telling you that you're insufficient, right? It's the most fundamental form of rejection. It's that dragon that the evil queen transforms into when the hero is struggling to eradicate being trapped in the dungeon by the terrible devouring mother. He emerges from that with the help of the positive feminine. That's those little fairies that take his shackles off, and the terrible witch transforms into a dragon who he defeats. And then she has put thorns around the castle that guard *Sleeping Beauty*, and he has to cut his way through the thorns.
- 6.105** That's—this happens in every marriage, in every relationship. And what you'll see when you're interacting with women is that before the sleeping virgin makes herself available to the redeeming kiss, there's many thorn fields that have to be gone through. And those are all the problems that women, as problem detectors, aggregate around themselves to bring to the

attention of men before they can play, right. And it takes faith and courage and a sharp sword to cut through all those obstacles, to get to the, to the place of true relationship. Right.

- 6.106** And a huge part of that is just listening. And how much do you have to listen? Till the problems are solved. And how deep are the problems? Oh my God, they can be multigenerational, like, they're and they're the bottom—that's an abyss, right? That's a real journey down into the deepest possible depths. That's partly why people avoid complex discussions in their own relationships, especially with the problem that recurs. You know, you have a problem in your relationship. It comes up all the time. It's like, there's something at the bottom of that, some complex, some betrayal around which everything is circulating. It's going to be one ugly journey to get to the bottom of that. But you can.
- 6.107** And then the person sheds it like a snake shedding its skin. That's part of that process of renewal. What's the upshot? The end goal of this adoption of this, let's say, transformative attitude? Well, that's the goal of psychotherapy. And not only that, but the definition of integrated personality and social harmony simultaneously. If you're well constituted psychologically and you have the courage to listen and negotiate, then you set your social relations straight. And if you gather people around you, in your family, in your broader community, there's nothing you can't take on, you know, because maybe you can't take it on yourself because it's too big a task.
- 6.108** But if you had a thousand people helping you, you got them all on board on this particular adventure. Is there anything you couldn't? Is there anything that would stop you? You know, one of the things I've learned, I don't believe in natural resources, say. I think human beings can make the desert bloom if they cooperate. There's nothing that can stop us. And what's the necessary precondition for cooperation? Communication and negotiation.
- 6.109** You know, like, if we're married, we're way more formidable than if we're single. Otherwise, why be married? If you're married with a family, you're way more formidable than you are alone. If you aggregate a community around you, it's an army, you know. What can stop you? Well, maybe nothing. Maybe nothing. Maybe almost everything that stops you is a figment of your own imagination. And I'm not trying to make light of the obstacles in life. What I'm trying to do is point to the fact that you have resources in front of you that are far more extensive than you think.
- 6.110** There's a rule. It's a religious rule. God walks with you to the degree that you voluntarily confront mortality and malevolence. It's a definition. It's a definition of the divine, is that if you adopt that attitude, that's the spirit that comes to inhabit you. And if that's the case, well, what's the alternative? That you're stronger if you avoid? That's a stupid theory. If that's the case, then, well, then what's the limit? You know, our whole culture, the whole Christian West, is predicated on the idea that the only thing that stops you is your unwillingness to confront the horrors that are in front of you. And that's nothing but a lack of faith and courage, fundamentally.

- 6.111 Now, nothing but—I'm not trying to make light of that. It's not surprising that you'd shrink away. But we know, one of the things we know as therapists for sure, is you are in trouble to the degree that you shrink away. And you take people who are terrified. You find out what they're afraid of. You get them to confront it. They get braver. They don't get less afraid. They get braver. And that generalizes. So.
- 6.112 And this, this, what I just told you about, what I just taught you, try it. It's, you can do it. You can learn to do it. It's pretty easy. It's like, OK, I'm going to listen. This is the deal. I'm going to listen to you. After you're done talking, tell me, you know, you'll, you'll get to pick that up automatically. You don't have to make it formal. After a while, you'll learn when the person's said enough. But you can have them say, OK, it's your turn. It's like, OK, here's what I think you said. Correct me if I'm wrong. Let's get it right before it's my turn, you know. And the person, I tell you, man, that person will be happy with you. And if you do that enough, you'll run out of problems. And when you run out of problems, it's like, then you can have some fun and that's very much worthwhile.
- 6.113 We know this. So the optimal marital relationship is **partner in play**. OK. We know something about the psychobiology of play from Jaak Panksepp. We'll talk about this in the next lecture. Play is a very fragile motivational state, in that children can't play if any other motivational state dominates them. If they're hungry or tired or angry or upset or frightened, they can't play. And so as a father, what you do is you demarcate a space. It's a **walled garden**, and you fortify it and make it safe. And then the children can play. And when they're playing, they're experimenting with what they could be. That's what play is.
- 6.114 But, so if play is occurring in your house, it means you've optimized the environment. Exactly the same relationship characterizes the relationship that you have with your wife. If you're not playing, it's not a **walled garden**. You haven't listened. You haven't addressed the thorns. You have not confronted the specters of mortality and malevolence that haunt your house. And so there's an impediment between you, and that rediscovery of what you had in childhood but lost can't take place.
- 6.115 And this **Rogerian** pathway, that works. You can learn that. Anyone can learn that. You know the rules, you can implement them. You can do it with yourself too. You know, explore your doubts, summarize them. That way, you learn to communicate with yourself, clear away the obstacles, and then you have an obstacle-free pathway forward, and your vision of where you're headed clarifies. All right, good. That's humanism, **existentialism**, **phenomenology** in the clinical frame.

7. Personality at Play

AT A GLANCE

Integrates Piaget with the neurobiology of Swanson, Gray, and Panksepp, and with psychometrics. Panksepp's rat play shows an emergent ethic of fair play; hunters share to store food in reputation. Explains general cognitive ability and the five-dimensional structure of personality, then argues that action precedes conception: keys, chairs, utilization behavior. Traces infant development through self-imitation, assimilation and accommodation, stable caregivers, pretend play, socialization by age four, identity and screen time, parental referencing, and resentment. Closes with the hypothalamus, motivational states as personalities, and the blindness of aim shown by change blindness and the invisible gorilla.

- 7.1 All right. So we're going to intermingle three topics in this lecture. The tradition of Jean Piaget, the tradition of the biologists, neurobiologists, neuropsychologists, and behaviorists, and psychometric approaches to personality. And we'll do that in a way that integrates all of those with what we've discussed. I mentioned to you when we first started this voyage, that I would endeavor to present you an integrated view of personality theories, using a hierarchy of conceptualization to, what would you say? To locate the different levels of theoretical analysis and unite them.
- 7.2 And I think we can bring that to a successful conclusion, integrating these three quite vastly different approaches—all predicated on the idea that if there is a unity of phenomena and a unity of conceptualization, that there should be a unity of scientific representation, and so that all apparent paradoxes should reconcile, except insofar as there is there an error.
- 7.3 And it's taken a long time, as I've walked through the personality literature, to unify it, because, like the approaches of the behaviorists and the Freudians, for example, are quite different. It took me quite a long time to figure out that they were looking at the problem from different levels of analysis, and it was a hierarchy that they were apprehending. So you'll see how that fleshes out. It's quite fun to see how the neurobiology fits with the conceptualizations that we've developed, regardless of their level of abstraction.
- 7.4 And it's, it's one of those realizations that really hammers home the fact that personality theory, and maybe psychology in general, has become somewhat of a mature science, because we can nail down the abstractions to the underlying material substrate in a way that works for both of them. And that's also a good—if you have, we opened with this, if you have multiple converging lines of divergent evidence that a phenomenon exists, then you have every reason to assume that that's a reliable and valid observation. So away we go.
- 7.5 Here are the people we're going to talk about. Some of them may be names known to you. Perhaps not. They're not as well known publicly as the theorists that we've already discussed. Jean Piaget is probably first and foremost among them in terms of reputation. He's a

developmental psychologist. He called himself a **genetic epistemologist**, genetic because he was interested in the genesis of things, the development. He felt that we could understand philosophy best, which is philosophy as the set of all representations of the world, the set of all knowledge structures. He felt we could understand philosophy best by looking how it developed in children.

- 7.6 Given the presupposition that children would have simpler conceptual schemes than adults, and so more easily understandable, and that if we analyzed how they progressed, that would shed some light on how adults thought. And I think **Piaget** managed that brilliantly. He was also interested, although few theorists who discuss, few teachers who discuss **Piaget**, are willing to understand this. **Piaget** also had a very profound existential crisis when he was a young man. One of these **shamanic** transformations that's very common among the thinkers that we've discussed. **Freud** had the same experience. So did **Jung** and the existential thinkers that we outlined as well.
- 7.7 Certainly **Dostoyevsky**, **Nietzsche**, all had that **shamanic** experience that we described at the beginning. **Piaget**, too. He was highly motivated to bridge the gap between science and religion, which I think he did extremely successfully, and will detail out that to some degree. **Larry Swanson**, definitely a lesser known figure, a physiologist who studied the nervous system from the bottom up, detailing out spinal cord function, particularly concerned with, what would you say, the simpler elements of reflex action.
- 7.8 You walk with your spinal cord. So, for example, if you take someone paraplegic and you suspend them over a treadmill and tilt them forward, their legs will walk when this, when the treadmill moves. So walking is actually a controlled fall. And so what does that mean? All of your nervous system isn't in your head. It's not all in your brain. Your nervous system is distributed through your body, and the spinal cord takes care of very basic motor functions, although very automatized, highly automatized motor functions.
- 7.9 I told you guys earlier that your eyes map directly onto your spinal cord, like, your eyes map onto your nervous system at multiple levels of analysis so they can do very complex processing that's time consuming because of its complexity and very rapid processing that's error-prone and oversimplified, but very, very fast. Right, and so you can imagine there's advantages. You can use a thumbnail or a high-resolution photo. That's a good way of thinking about it. You can see the advantages and disadvantages of both.
- 7.10 **Swanson** is a complete genius. When I encountered his work, it was quite a revelation to me because what he described physiologically maps perfectly onto **Piaget's** work. And so that was so cool to see because there was no cross-reference between them, right. So that was another indication of independence of measurement. Really good. **Jeffrey Gray** wrote a book called *The Neuropsychology of Anxiety*. Took me like a year to read that book. It was 1200 scientific references, of which he read all of them and understood them. Master of the animal behavioral literature. The bloody animal behaviorists, they're so precise in their thinking. They learn so much.

- 7.11** They really built our understanding of the nervous system from the reflex upwards. You know, assuming that we could account for much of what human beings do by looking at simple reflex chaining. True at some levels of analysis, less true at higher levels of analysis, but still profoundly interesting and useful, very practical. The basis for the implementation of behavioral approaches to psychotherapy. Jeffrey Gray was the master of the behavioral world. His book *The Neuropsychology of Anxiety*, it's a tough read. You have to master neuropharmacology, brain anatomy, all of the animal behavioral literature, the wide literature on emotional function.
- 7.12** That's four separate scientific fields right there, all of which have a dense and and complex literature. He integrated all that. Brilliant. It's a stunningly brilliant book, which was very useful to me in understanding Jung's thought. Now the behaviorists are very antithetical, as a general rule, to the psychoanalytic thinkers. But Gray's account of nervous system, nervous system function, especially in combination with Swanson, provides the basis for understanding the motivational implement—the implementation of the pattern of the hero's journey in the lower reaches of the nervous system. So cool. We'll go through that.
- 7.13** Jaak Panksepp. Brilliant. Wrote a book called *Affective Neuroscience*. It's the bible for that field, that burgeoning field. He, his work is similar in some regards to that of Gray and Swanson. Panksepp discovered the play circuit in mammals. Major league discovery. He discovered the emergence of a spontaneous morality in rats that was play-based. Unbelievably important. I think he should have got a Nobel Prize for that. It's stunning to see the emergence of a play ethos in rats on which an ethic can be scaffolded.
- 7.14** When rats play, which they do as juveniles, they wrestle like human beings, like human, especially boys wrestle. They pin each other, even, and they'll work to enter a play arena, which, that's how behaviorists measure motivation. If an animal will work, pull against a load, in order to engage in an activity, the behaviorists assume that the animal wants to engage in that activity. It'll work for it. It'll sacrifice for it. Rats, juvenile rats, will work to enter an arena where they can wrestle with other rats. And if you pair two rats together, males, and one rat is 10% bigger than the other rat, he can reliably win—10% weight advantage will do that.
- 7.15** Same with children, by the way. The older kids in any given classroom are physically dominant; the younger kids are likely to be bullied. They're less likely to be athletically, have athletic prowess. Good thing to know if you have children, and they're much more likely to be diagnosed with attention deficit disorder, which they don't have. They're just young because there's a year between the oldest and youngest kids in any given class. And some of the younger kids are even more immature than that. And so they don't behave as well. Medicate them? Not a good idea.
- 7.16** It's also the case that NHL stars, for example, are much more—National Hockey League—are much more likely to be drawn from the older kids in any given elementary class. So anyways, a weight advantage gives you a physical edge. It works for rats. A rat with a 10% weight advantage can pin a smaller rat. OK, now you think, you put two rats together, that one rat wants to win. Dominate. Higher in the dominance hierarchy. That is what happens if you pair them once. But if

you pair them repeatedly, which is actually what happens in rats' social groups, if the big rat doesn't let the little rat win one third of the time, the little rat will stop inviting him to play.

- 7.17** So even among rats, the ethos of **fair play** emerges in paired bouts, and you think, well, who cares about rats playing? It's like, no, no, you don't understand. What **Panksepp** indicated was that, even among rats, a stable ethos of reciprocal play emerges in repeated pairings. And that's the basis for communal organization. Like, obviously, if you're a child and you play a game with someone and the game goes well, then that person wants to play again and again and again. Then you have a friend. As soon as, that's what a friend is. As soon as you have a group of friends, you have a community. That's the pattern on which the community rests, if it's not based on dominance or hedonism.
- 7.18** This is such a staggering discovery that **Panksepp** made. You know, that's why I think he deserved a Nobel Prize. Brilliant. And he also helped us outline the emotional motivational circuitry in the mammalian brain, in particular. Affective Neuroscience. It's an easier book than Neuropsychology of Anxiety. Brilliant. You'll learn immense, immense amounts of useful knowledge are encapsulated with that book. And **Swanson**, **Gray**, and Panksepp's work also provides the underlying neuropsychology, neurophysiology, understanding of that from a functional perspective that also allows us to understand why we have the personality traits that we have, that we'll discuss when we discuss the psychometric approaches to personality apprehension.
- 7.19** So, and then we'll close this with that, with the psychometric analysis, but also with the discussion of **general cognitive ability**, general intelligence, which is something like a metric of overall nervous system efficiency and effectiveness. Large, people with larger brains, compared to the rest of their body, tend to have higher intelligence. People with larger head circumferences, people with faster transmission of electrical messages between neurons. People with higher IQs tend to be more resistant to neurological degeneration because their brains are healthier.
- 7.20** People who are more well nourished have higher IQs. The best predictor of long-term maintenance of cognitive ability is general physical health. If you want to maintain your intelligence, your ability to learn quickly, the best thing to do is to exercise. It isn't to engage in complex cognitive activity. There's no evidence that practicing engaging in complex cognitive activity maintains your cognitive function. All these companies who claim the alternative, you know, you can play brain games to keep yourself cognitively motivated—it's like, yeah, it doesn't look like it.
- 7.21** Weightlifting, cardiovascular exercise—that keeps your brain healthy. Why? Well, it uses 20% of your metabolic resources, like it's a demanding organ. The anthropological theory is that the reason that we were able to evolve large brains is because we learned to use fire and cook, which made our food much more effective. Our guts could shrink. They're much smaller than they are in chimpanzees, who are sort of shaped like this. You might notice they spend eight hours a day chewing. Plants, they're not edible. Cooked meat, that's edible. You learn how to

manage that with your communal hunt, and all of a sudden you're thin and mostly brain, and away you bloody well go.

- 7.22 And that's what happened to human beings. Looks like we mastered fire about 2 million years ago, quite a long time, and look out, everyone else, as a consequence, right? That communal hunting, that social organization, that ability to share food over the long run. Communal hunters, too—they play because any given hunter is likely to fail at any given moment. But if you group together with, say, ten other hunters, there's a pretty good probability you'll always be successful. Then the problem emerges. How do you share? Right? Because you want to share.
- 7.23 Because if you're, imagine you're the greatest hunter in the group and you're successful 50% of the time, and the next guy maybe only 10%, the next best guy, you might think, well, why not take all the good meat for yourself? And the answer is because you won't get anything when you're not successful. And so what happens in tribal hunting groups is that if you happen to be the best hunter, you play fair. And that means that when you bring down the animal, or maybe your tracking prowess is the reason for the success, you downplay your contribution, you know, in a self-deprecating manner, and you give out the best cuts when it's your kill to everyone else.
- 7.24 Why? Because you store future food in your reputation. Right. And that way to be a great hunter, not only do you have the prowess that makes you the hunter itself, but you have that social interaction skill that makes everybody thrilled to be along on your hunt, right? And so you can see, see, you can see the difference between those two. What types of complex ethos—do you have the skill necessary to win the task, or do you have the skill necessary to produce the social grouping over a long period of time that ensures your long-term survival?
- 7.25 Well, that's what great hunters in the human context do reliably, cross-culturally. And so it's a useful thing to think about with regards to how you approach any given game. You know, it's like, you should be the guy that's kind of on top, but you shouldn't take too much credit, and you should make sure that you distribute resources, perhaps even more than a bit fairly. And you should also make sure that you help develop everyone else's skill because, well, just for selfish reasons or for the reasons of preservation of your family, you never bloody well know when you're going to have to depend on, you know, someone who last year was second place to you, but has now surpassed you in the hierarchy of ability, let's say.
- 7.26 **General cognitive ability.** Charles Spearman, Raymond Cattell, John Carroll—these were all figures who identified the fact that all complex cognitive abilities in human beings appear to be reflections of the same underlying process. They call it *g*, which is the general factor that's derived from factor analytic tests or **general cognitive ability**. If you're faster at one cognitive ability, whatever it happens to be, you tend to be faster at all of them. And so why that is exactly, well, we don't know. It looks like it's probably the additive consequence of a number of related features. I described some of them.
- 7.27 Brain volume is one. Brain volume compared to body size is another general nervous system integrity. We're not sure exactly. We're not sure exactly what the physiological basis of **general**

cognitive ability is, but we're bloody well sure we can measure it. It's very easy. Here's an IQ test. Generate a list of 10,000 questions. Questions about anything. Anything that people could know. Mathematical problems, general knowledge, vocabulary, you name it. Abstract problem-solving. 10,000. Draw a random sample of 100 questions from that bank. Give it to 100 people. Sum the performance. Rank-order the people. That's, then correct for age. That's intelligence. That's all you have to do.

- 7.28** And it's a vicious predictor of long-term success. By far the best predictor we have. Five times as powerful as the next best predictor. So why? Why? Well, speed. That's part of it. Why is speed so important? Well, there's something to be said for getting somewhere new and useful first. And, you know, it's the people on the cutting edge of any discipline who reap most of the benefit. And unsurprisingly, because they get, they get the reputation that's associated with being the first discoverer, let's say. They dominate the space. They get the, what would they say? They get the the naming rights. That's another, that's another element of the success.
- 7.29** And **general cognitive ability** predicts your ability to learn quickly in a novel environment. If you're hiring people for jobs that require learning rather than can be mastered and then done automatically, factory line-worker jobs have that aspect, for example, and IQ doesn't predict performance there particularly well. But if the job involves learning, **general cognitive ability** is by far the best predictor. And there's huge individual variation in **general cognitive ability**. So, and like I said, it's an easy thing to measure. That's all there is to it.
- 7.30** And one of the things you'll see—so imagine you have your bank of 10,000 questions. You can draw random samples of 100 questions. So I could give you a test of 100. All of you. Give you a test of 100, another test of 100, another test of 100. And then correlate your rank-orders, right. You're going to be stable across the rank-orders, which means that if you came in first, the first 100 questions, you're probably going to come in first for the next 200. The ranking will remain remarkably stable across people and across age. So, c'est la vie, and it's very potentially, biologically determined. There's huge genetic influence on **general cognitive ability**.
- 7.31** So, personality. How many personality traits are there? So imagine you take a bank of 10,000 personality questions. What are you like? And you distribute that to, you administer that to a thousand people, and you subject it to an analysis that shows you how the questions group, which would mean if you answered question A in a positive direction, which other questions would you be likely to answer in a positive direction? That's how you detect the clumping.
- 7.32** There's one dimension in cognitive ability. There's five dimensions in personality, arguably six. Five dimensions in personality. And so personality is not a unitary structure. It's quite clearly a five-dimensional structure. And we'll talk about, that was discovered by about 1940, although it's become clearer and clearer with succeeding decades. I did some work with **Colin DeYoung** where we took that five-dimensional structure and broke each of the five dimensions into two primary aspects, and that turns out to be quite a stable, what would you say? Representation as well. And there's some utility in that higher resolution representation that we'll delve into. So that's the territory.

- 7.33 Here's how to understand what we're doing physiologically. So understand the starting point for adaptation to the world, not as conception but as action. OK. So when children come into the world, they're relatively devoid of conceptual structure. But they can act. They can suck, for example. They can investigate with their mouth, which is why, once children can organize their gripping and the movement of their hands, which takes a while for them to figure out, they put everything in their mouth. And they do that because their tongue and their lips are very wired up. And so they can, you know, they can feel things out very accurately with their tongue and their, and their lips. That's why they put everything in their mouth.
- 7.34 And so the baby comes into the world with these rudimentary abilities that become, what would you say, elaborated across time. And they build their conceptions on the platform of their actions. So that's another indication of the fact that we don't perceive objects abstractly. We perceive them in relationship to what we can do with them, right. They're mapped onto our body. And so here's an example of that. You know, you might think that the idea of one, like the numeric idea, is a representation of something objectively true in the world. OK.
- 7.35 But think about, think about this. Imagine you have a ring of keys. OK. Is that one thing? Say you have nine keys. Is a ring of keys one thing or nine things? Now you think it can't be both, right? It's one or the other. It's like, no, that's not right. It's one if you throw it; it's nine if you're trying to open a lock. And so and that's, that's very useful to think through because it means that even the concept of number, which really seems like something characteristic of the objective world, is dependent to an indeterminate degree on the task to which the entity being assessed is being, what would you say? Devoted. Yeah.
- 7.36 And so, and it's true with our perceptions, you know, like, I'll perceive something as a unit, one thing, if I can do something to it as a totality in relationship to a goal. But I'll perceive it as its parts if I have to differentiate it in order for the goal to make itself manifest. So for example, this happens in very complex ways. Imagine that your computer is working, your laptop is working. Well, then what's your laptop? Mostly it's whatever keys you're pushing and whatever you're looking at on the screen, that's your laptop. What happens if your computer crashes? OK, so it stops being the keyboard and what you're looking at, and it turns into, what? A mess of incomprehensible unitary subcomponents.
- 7.37 Same thing that happens when your car breaks down on the freeway, right? So unity turns into multiplicity. Why? Well, it happens in relationship to your aim. You know, what we really want is to be surrounded by things that are unitary in relationship to our aim, unitary or ignorable. Right? And so when someone acts in a complicated way, they snap out of the conceptual structure that you've put them in and that they've been participating in, and then they devolve into all the things they could be. That's what happens when someone betrays you. They turn from a person to a nest of snakes. Right? Right. And that's very complicated and off-putting.
- 7.38 But it's another indication of that problem the phenomenologists were wrestling with. It's like, what's the relationship between the subjective and the objective, even at the level of number?

It's like, well, our conceptions, our perceptions of things as unities, right? As identifiable nameable objects, that's dependent on their function, not on their objective properties.

- 7.39** Here's another way of thinking about it. A beanbag, you know, the ones you sit on, and a stump. They're both chairs. Why? Well, there's, they almost share almost nothing objective in common, right? They could hardly be, in some ways, more dissimilar as objects. And yet they're in the same category. And if you think of the category as a collection of shared objective features that makes chair and bean, or stump and beanbag, odd members of a class. But if you think, well, if you can sit on it, it's a chair. Well, then you start to understand that your perceptual categories yourself, that's the basis of fact, right? The perceptual category is actually dependent on function.
- 7.40** That's very, very, very interesting way of looking at the world, that objects themselves aren't objective. Right. So and that's, it's the case when you walk into a room. You don't see objects. You see elements of functional significance or obstacles or pathways. That's what you see as objects, right? And not, that isn't because you see the object and infer the function. It's not how it works. You know, I already mentioned that, is that—I'll give you an example.
- 7.41** There's a neurological condition called **utilization behavior**. And this happens to you when you develop a certain kind of prefrontal cortical damage. Advanced parts of the brain, forward parts that are controlled, control motor movement, voluntary, and inhibition of motor movement, if you have **utilization behavior**, you can't not use an object if one appears to you. So if you send someone with this kind of neurological damage down a hallway and there's a door, especially if it's open, even if you tell them to walk to the end of the hall, if the door is open and they look at it, they'll walk through it. And if you put an object in front of them, they have to use it.
- 7.42** And it's because the object, everything you see tells you to use it. And there, and at the higher levels of your nervous system, you can inhibit that in relationship to your specific goal-directed activity. But if that part of the brain is damaged, then the objects that are compelling you to use them when you perceive them grip your behavior, and you use them. That's **utilization behavior**. And so it's so interesting that we perceive objects in relationship to their functional utility. Perceive them, not just classify them.
- 7.43** So, what's the upshot of this? Well, part of the way that you build your representation of the world is by interacting with it. You know, when you have a little kid, you say, "Look, but don't touch"? It's like, no, no, no. They have to get in there and manipulate the object, move it and interact with it, because that's how they map it as an entity. What can I do with it? Can I gnaw on it? Can I swallow it? Is it edible? That's an obvious thing to figure out, because you don't die if you can figure out what things you can eat. It's no bloody wonder kids put everything into their mouth on the off chance.
- 7.44** Can you imagine how many people died figuring out which mushrooms are edible, right? I mean, we're surrounded by all these things we can eat. You just have no idea how many people had to die to figure that out. So we're mapping things for functional significance, and we do that to

begin with, with the more primordial forms of behavior that we're capable of manifesting. Right? So we interact with the world in low resolution ways as infants.

- 7.45 Piaget observed, for example, that a baby in a, laying down on their back, you know, babies, they're sort of floating like this. They can't really control their eyes, although their focal gaze is adjusted to be exactly the same distance as head from breast to mother's eyes. That's the natural focal length of, focal distance of a baby's eyes. They're kind of unfocused and crossed because they haven't got them oriented towards a goal, and their hands and legs are kind of wandering around. They're well controlled around their mouth, and they sort of develop from the mouth outward and the center of the body towards the periphery.
- 7.46 They'll lay in their crib, sort of wandering with their hands, and maybe there's a mobile on top of them and they're sort of flailing about, sort of semi-randomly, and they'll whack something and it'll startle them. And babies, their whole body startles when they startle. You can see that. You just take a baby and just blow on it. It'll go like this. Because that a priori startle reflex, which is partly anxiety and part exploration, just dominates them completely. And they like a little bit of startling, which is likely why they like to play peekaboo, because there you are, and that's cool, because there you are, and then you're gone. And that's quite the bloody shock. And then you move the hand and you appear again. And they're completely, starkly amazed by that. And they like to play with that.
- 7.47 And you can establish a game with even a very young baby by doing that. I had my granddaughter. I think she was only three months. She could kind of stand up if I held her. And I played a— you can play games with babies by establishing a pattern of repetition and then varying it. And so the game I played with her was sort of count, make three noises and then tap her forehead on mine. One, two, three, tap. One, two, three, tap. And she'd smile. Do that like six times. And then I go one, two, three, and move but not do it. And then she startled a little bit and laughed, because that's variation on a theme, right.
- 7.48 And so what's happened is, she's mapped a pattern of repetition, and now she knows the rule of the game. Three noises, tap, right. You establish that pattern. And then if you vary it, if you vary it too much, the baby will cry. If you vary it just about enough, they startle a little bit and then they laugh. And then you can vary that. And that's how you can play with a very young infant or someone deep in the throes of dementia. By the way, as their nervous system sort of what degenerates back down to the infantile level.
- 7.49 And so if you interact with the baby, you can find out what their level of apprehension is in those sort of embodied games and play with them at that level. And, well, that's partly how you scaffold their development upward. You're kind of building their brain from the spinal reflexes upward. And Piaget mapped that when he was investigating how children played by themselves first and then with other children. Piaget noticed, for example—so babies in a crib, there's a mobile above them.

- 7.50 By the way, if you buy a mobile for your baby, look at it because most mobiles dangle and the little object is vertical like this, right? That's stupid because the baby can only see the edge underneath. You want the things facing the baby. It's like, duh. And black and white or red, because babies can really see black and white and red. Just so you know.
- 7.51 And so anyways, if you have your baby lying on its back, sort of flailing around and maybe there's a mobile above it, and it'll flail a bit with a bit of control. Babies tend to discover their hands when they bonk themselves in their head, you know. They'll be flailing around and they hit themselves and startle and then notice. And as they get a little better at hand control, they'll repeat what startles them. So maybe they'll hit the mobile and that'll produce a reaction. They're almost, like, stunned in their psychedelic way by this remarkable thing that's occurred because they've moved their hand and then they'll try to duplicate it.
- 7.52 They imitate themselves. Babies watch what they do. And if something interesting happens because of the way they acted, they'll try to replicate it. And that's how Piaget explained their scaffolding of their knowledge. You'll see this with, you know, toddlers, for example, younger than toddlers, eight months old, your babies are at the table, maybe in their little highchair, and they'll drop food, which they love doing as soon as they're, like, the least bit not hungry. It's like, food everywhere. They'll drop the food and then repeat that and repeat it and repeat it, because they're trying to figure out like, what the hell's going on here? You know, I pushed this over and away it falls.
- 7.53 And repeat that and repeat that and repeat that. And that's partly how they start to generate their understanding, you know, their—of up and down, right. And of the causality that's associated with objects. It's, they watch their own behavior. There's a random element to that. And then when the behavior produces some interesting outcome that they don't quite expect, they replicate that and investigate it until they can predict it. And then they look for another interesting and unpredictable outcome. And that's the same, that's that exploratory technique that we were describing.
- 7.54 And what Piaget mapped was how babies build those initial structures of knowledge and then how they transform them by further exploration. Called that **assimilation** and **accommodation**. **Assimilation** is the **assimilation** of new information, and **accommodation** is the adjustment of schemes of conception to incorporate the new information. And that process of **assimilation** and **accommodation** follows that **descent and ascent** pattern that we described. Right, that's a stage transition.
- 7.55 You'll see this in your infant's development, is that they'll kind of stabilize and be somewhat emotionally stable, and then they'll learn something new and incorporate a new set of skills. And they're all bitchy and irritable for a while after that, because they kind of dissolve and reconstitute as a consequence of having to, you know, incorporate the new information. Something like that can really happen if their caregiver shifts. For example, babies hate that. The worst thing you can do to your child, just so you know, is when, especially under three, is shift

their caregivers. They do not like that because their caregiver is their world. That's the thing they're mapping.

- 7.56** Babies can have multiple caregivers. That's not a problem as long as they're stable. But if you have a nanny and then another nanny and then another nanny, especially for kids under three, that does not make for a happy child. So they're, you know, they're wired to bond to someone and to maintain that bond, and you don't want to violate that. If you violate it profoundly, it can really damage a child. And you can do that in a way that can't be fixed. So I wouldn't recommend it.
- 7.57** So they imitate themselves. And then you can see this in children as they imitate others, too. But you see this particularly if you have a child, and then you know, you have one child and you have a younger child, the younger child will imitate the older child like mad. And children tend to kind of do this naturally, like adults do, is they'll pick a child to be a, like, a hero who they admire, who's ahead of them developmentally in some important manner, but not so far ahead that they can't conceivably do what that child can do. And so they want to find someone to admire. That admiration is the grip of the developmental instinct to admire who they can imitate and scaffold their own development in relationship to.
- 7.58** Now, we do this as adults too, because no matter how old you are, in all likelihood, if you have any sense, you'll come across someone that you admire. So that person's pattern of behavior and attention grips you. And that's because your nervous system is signaling to you in a sense that there's something worth exploring in relationship to that person and assimilating. The admiration is actually the grip of the developmental instinct. Same thing applies in children. And so, so there's the stage. So what would you say? Children explore, assimilate, and accommodate. That happens in stages. There's micro stages and macro stages, and the macro stages are more evident.
- 7.59** And some of that's, you can characterize some of that as play. Now that experimentation with repetition, that's self-generated. So the baby hits something and notices the response and then imitates that. That means they're playing by themselves. Now children basically play by themselves, at least at the abstract level, until they're two, three. It's a little more complex than that because really simple games infants and toddlers can play, right, pretty much right from the beginning, right? But it's hard for them to play a formal game that requires another person until they're three.
- 7.60** So it's kind of like, if you have to act out, if you have to state the rules abstractly, if you have to negotiate the rules using verbal communication, kids really can't do that until they're about three. They're not social enough to do that. Probably best not to put your kids in daycare until they're three. They're really not ready for that. Very extroverted kids, maybe a little earlier than that, but fundamentally, it's probably best to avoid it. After three, arguably after three, the primary vehicle of child socialization is not you, it's other children.

- 7.61** Your goal as a parent—it's good to know this—your goal as a parent is to make your child maximally socially attractive by the age of four. And if you fail in that, your children are seriously in trouble because children unpopular at four tend not to make friends and they stay unpopular. And if they're aggressive and unpopular, they stay aggressive and unpopular. And that's a very bad developmental trajectory. Very stable, very hard to change after the age of four. And so you want to produce children that can take turns and share games.
- 7.62** So, let's conceptualize that a little bit. That's play. The way that you build yourself from the bottom up, let's say, is from these micro routines upward. So you have a two-year-old and maybe it's dinnertime. So that's the frame. Let's feed the family, OK, and you want to get your two-year-old to participate. And maybe it's time to set the table. OK, so setting the table—that's a subset of completing a meal. That's a subset of caring for a family. That's a subset of being a good parent. That's a subset of being a good person.
- 7.63** OK, how do you build that? You say to the child, "You see that drawer?" And the child, OK, so what are you using? They're not quite reflex. It's more complex than that. The child knows how to direct its gaze by verbal instruction. Do you see that drawer? Knows what a drawer is. So you can say, "Do you see that drawer?" You get a nod. "Good. Can you pull the drawer open?" Yes. "Can you take a knife out of the drawer?" Yes. Pat. Pat. That's the reward. "Can you carry the knife to the table and put it on top?" Well then, see. So you can see you're building the micro routines of setting the table from the bottom up in embodied form.
- 7.64** Now, at some point, once they know what a knife is and what a fork is and what a plate is, and where they go in relationship to other, to one another, and where the cups go, then you can say, "Set the table." Right. And that's an abstraction that contains all those micro conceptions all the way down to the level of motoric movement. That's the highest level of resolution that you sort of have conscious control over. And so, as a behavior therapist, what you do is, often, especially with people who have been very badly socialized, is you build those micro routines.
- 7.65** I told you before, for example, that it's something to even ask yourself about. It's like, how good are you at the basic micro routines of social introduction? You know, you should be expert at presenting yourself properly, of shaking someone's hand, of saying who you are, of asking them what they do, of asking the first introductory questions, and not to push you away, but get a social dynamic going. And you should teach your children that. Like, they should—that's basic manners.
- 7.66** And it's so important because if your children are good at that, if they know how to introduce themselves, if they know how to listen, if they know how to smile when they're being introduced, if they do that with a certain amount of confidence, but not, and in not a bit of a playful manner, but not too arrogant, let's say, then they'll charm adults and other children. They'll make friends quickly and they'll be instructed. It's really, really, really important. You know, so that they're standing up properly, so that they know how to shake hands. They know how to say their name.

- 7.67 It's very important, too, to teach them, especially around the age of three, because that's where it starts, to start to be able to take the viewpoint of another person. That's kind of what you do with a game. So imagine a boy and a girl, a bit of attraction there, even when they're young, let's say. A boy and a girl meet each other in class and there's a bit of an attraction. So there's some reason they want to get to know each other better. So what are you hoping for from your son or daughter? Well, let's take the case of—it doesn't matter—we'll take the case of the son for sake of argument. You want him to be able to say to the girl, "Would you like to play something?"
- 7.68 So that's an invitation. And then maybe the boy can say, "Would you like to play house?" Right. And the girl might say, well, yes, or she'll suggest another game. So what they're doing is establishing a joint **frame of reference**. Right. So the goal of house is to what? To act out a role. Will you play house? Yes. You could be the mom and I'll be the dad, or I'll be the dad, and you can be the daughters, or you can be the cat. You know, there's lots of varied roles you can play.
- 7.69 When I used to take my kids to the beach in Boston, if it was cloudy and they couldn't go in the water, it was cold. I'd mark out a house on the sand, you know, just with my foot, with the rooms in it. And they'd be playing in the bloody house for, you know, an hour. And they're so good. Kids are so good at using an abstraction as the representation of reality, you know, and then playing out those roles. And what they're doing when they inhabit the roles is, what, they're plotting out the territories. Like, if I was a father, how would I act? And maybe they'll act out a rough part of the role and a benevolent part of the role, and they'll see how that works in the game.
- 7.70 And they're so smart because they kind of imitate. But it's higher-order abstraction, you know, like if your son is imitating you as a father, he doesn't copy exactly what you do, which is what basic imitation would do. What he does is, he watches how you act across multiple situations, and he extracts out the pattern from that. So that's like the spirit of the father. He'd get that from movies and books as well. He extracts out that pattern and then instantiates it as a dramatic role, and experiments with that, and experiments with how to make that manifest physically.
- 7.71 I suspect that that alters him, the games people, children play, I suspect, alter them all the way down to the level of DNA in the manner that we described previously. Turn on and turn off different genes depending on the pattern of psychophysiological activation that's being played out in the drama. Now, if you're playing house, there's a rule for the game, a meta rule, which is the girl has to want to play, right? And that's a real important rule throughout life. And so the game has to be structured so that she'll take her role voluntarily and want to play during that game, but to repeat it across multiple bouts, in which case you've made a friend.
- 7.72 Right, and that can lay that, that obviously lays the groundwork for later relationships, you know. If you're married properly, you're playing house with someone who's playing voluntarily because they want the game to continue. Otherwise, you're a tyrant or a hedonist, and that's a suboptimal solution. And children are working all that out when they're 3 and 4, 3 to 7. And one

of the things we're doing to children that's just bloody brutal and terrible is that we're substituting screen time for that dramatic play.

- 7.73** And, you know, you can be concerned about what your children are being exposed to on a phone, and fair enough. But the big concern should be what are they not doing while they're on the screen? And one answer to that is, they're not playing, and that is not good. You know, one of the things I'm seeing happening in campuses, you know, there's all this confusion about identity, all this weird, dramatic costuming play that's going on, and especially among, you know, older adolescents and young adults, confusion about identity and dramatic play—I think that's all, what would you call? Forestalled early childhood. Dramatic play. Is that they didn't get the opportunity to do that when they were like 4 to 7.
- 7.74** And you have to do it. It's not optional. That's how you catalyze your role and how you negotiate your identity with someone else. And part of the reason I think that everyone's in a dither about their bloody identities is because we haven't—we've interfered with childhood play so badly that people aren't catalyzing their identities properly when they're little. Like, children around three and four, they become obsessed with gender identity, right? They want to know, am I a boy or am I a girl? Well, why? Well, it's really complicated to be both, right? It's hard enough to be one. And you don't want to overwhelm your child with choice.
- 7.75** Another thing to know about kids. Your kid has 20 outfits, and he's three. You don't open the door and say, "What do you want to wear?" It's like, you don't want to go to a store and pick from 200 shampoos. That does not make you happy. No matter what shampoo you pick out of 200, it's not the best one. You don't want 1 or 0 because then you're in a communist state. Maybe you want four. You want optimal choice level. And so with kids, you know, one of the things you can do to make them happy is put three outfits on the bed and say, you know, pick one. Then it's constrained choice. And that's a good game. But you don't—
- 7.76** You got to watch your kids. You know, they want a little bit of choice but not too much. And if you give them too much, they just get anxious, just like adults do, by the way. So, OK, so you're building your children from the bottom up or they're building themselves. And once they get to say, like, the third rung or something like that on that hierarchy we're describing, they can start to play with other people. And when they do that formally, what they do is they negotiate a shared goal. And that's how you learn to live with someone.
- 7.77** Like, if we have a shared goal, you see, if our aims are aligned, then we see the world the same way. Like, literally, we see the world the same way, and we have the same emotional response to things, and we can predict each other's behavior, and we can cooperate and compete. So you can hardly overestimate the significance of that early, of early expertise in pretend play. It's unbelievably important. And it's so easy to dismiss it. You know, it's just child's play. It's like, would that you were fortunate enough to conduct yourself like that as an adult.
- 7.78** You know, the greatest poetry we have, the greatest sacred ideas, suggest to us that the secret of the most sophisticated maturity is to rediscover the ability to play and to play dramatically

that you had when you were a kid, to maintain your adult wisdom, but to return to that orientation in the world. And I think that's absolutely right. We know that play is a very high—what would you say? It's the highest level of conduct. And if you set things up around yourself properly, then what you're doing is playing. Your relationship becomes play, your work becomes play.

- 7.79** And so that's a good deal if you can manage it. So don't be thinking it's not important for kids and you don't—your household is set up optimally if your children are playing. Right, and then you might ask, you know, what role should you play as a parent? It's like, you're there as a, what? Resource. You shouldn't be hovering at all. You should leave your children be and let them play, especially with other kids.
- 7.80** This is partly why it's actually easier to have more kids rather than few. One kid, you amuse. Two kids, they start to amuse each other. Four kids, they're gone. They're, they're playing by themselves all the time. So that's a, that's a useful thing to know, because you might think that the workload increases as it would if you had four individual children, but that isn't how it works. The children start to take care of each other, and they socialize themselves. And children have to do that because, after the age of three, the primary agents of socialization for children are other children, not you.
- 7.81** So what's your role? You're there for when things go wrong or as a source of evaluation. So the kids need you around because if they hit a complexity they can't manage, which will make them emotional and upset, they'll come to you as a reference point. And the first thing they do—imagine you have a small child and a mouse runs across the floor. The child will orient to the mouse because the novelty attracts them. And the first thing they'll do is look at your face. That's called **referencing**. And if you jump up on the table and scream, they assume mouse equals mother panicking, right? But if they just see you calm, they'll tag the mouse with your calmness and they'll reflect that in their own categorization.
- 7.82** So they use you as a reference. And they do that mostly by reading off your face and your bodily posture. And so you're around as a reference. So you need to be around. But it doesn't mean you have to hover. You can do your own thing, and you should, because you also want to model for children the fact that adults have important things to do. You're not there at their beck and call, and if you're your child's slave, then you indicate to the child that the role of adult is slave to child. Why the hell would any child mature if that was their destination point?
- 7.83** You know, and this is, this is something for mothers to know in particular, because mothers have to be more devoted to children, especially in the first year, than fathers have to be. And so it's easier for mothers to become resentful slaves of their children. And you might say, well, that's necessary because the child has to be so carefully attended to and primarily by the mother. But it's not necessary because there's two things you want to do as a mother for a child. And one is take care of that child, especially when they're under, you know, when they're under nine months old because they're so dependent.

- 7.84 But the other thing you want to do is model the fact that you get to have a life as an adult. And so one of the things to watch, too, if you're female, especially with a more marked proclivity towards agreeableness, is that you don't get resentful, especially to your children. If you're getting resentful, I outlined this before, there's only two possible reasons. One is you should grow the hell up and take on your responsibility and be grateful for it. That's one possibility, and the other is you're sacrificing too much for someone else. Right. There's some optimal level where you're of sufficient service to your children, but also to yourself and serving as a model for maturity.
- 7.85 And if you get that right, you'll be happy to take care of your children because you're not going too far for them. And the best marker for that, the simplest marker for that, is resentment. Like, it's a terrible emotion. It destroys people. It's a bitter, awful, sinful emotion. But it's unbelievably useful because you can use it as a reference point. It's like, if you're resentful, there's something to adjust. You either stand up for yourself more or grow up. Those are your options. And you can do that. You want to do it till you're not resentful.
- 7.86 You know, and this is a really useful thing for agreeable people to know. Agreeable people tilt toward service for other people. And there's something, you know, there's something about that that can be necessary and wonderful. But if it's purchased at the cost of resentment, that's a very bad long-term solution. Very unstable, very stressful. It causes an immense amount of social trouble. It makes people bitter. It's not good. But man, if you watch it, you can, you can learn so much from it. You can learn so much and dispense with it.
- 7.87 OK. So as you move up this hierarchy, which is basically a hierarchy of attention and motor output, you move towards more abstraction, right? You move to more complex and sophisticated long-term games. And what happens while you do that is your brain is developing from the bottom up, from the spinal cord upward towards the cortex, and then in the cortex towards the front, which is the most, what, is the part of the brain that's least implicitly structured and most dependent on context and socialization to mature.
- 7.88 So there's a concordance between the adventurous expansion of your identity, let's say, towards longer and longer future-oriented solutions that include more and more people, right, and cortical maturation. And that's part of the reason why so many forms of psychopathology are something like, what would you say? Sustained manifestations of immaturity. So people with personality disorders, like borderline personality, they're very immature. They're basically old toddlers, like people with borderline personality disorder. They will have temper tantrums.
- 7.89 And I tell you, it is something to see someone 30 have a two-year-old temper tantrum. You'll never forget it, I can tell you that. And so, and what's happened is, there are people who, they weren't socialized, you know, and they didn't make friends. And they passed that critical period of development between 2 and 4, when you're, when you integrate your motivational states with that of others and become a socialized person, and then they're alienated from their peers for the rest of their lives and they never develop. And it's very, very hard, impossible maybe, to fix. Very hard.

- 7.90 With criminal types, they're usually male, by the way. Five percent of two-year-old males are hyper-aggressive. Bite, kick, hit, and steal. If you put them with other two-year-olds, most of them are socialized by the age of four. If they're not, they stay alienated from their peers, so they're sort of already in jail. Then they're delinquents, then they're criminals. What do you do with them? There's no treatment for antisocial personality disorder that works. And I mean none. Everything you can possibly imagine has been tried. You can go look for yourself.
- 7.91 Psychologists, sociologists, economists have tried for 70 years to remediate antisocial personality with no success. Sometimes, what, the interventions make it worse. So, for example, if you put **psychopaths** in group therapy, you make them more effective **psychopaths**. They get better at manipulation. Right? And if you group antisocial kids together to try to remedy their faults, the best of the antisocial kids learn more devious tricks from the worst. And all of them devolve, right?
- 7.92 So don't be thinking your stupid, well-intentioned intervention is going to produce the result you intend in a complex situation, because it probably won't, given there's more ways for things to go wrong than right. And also some things are very, very, very hard to fix. So an antisocial personality disorder, these disorders of immaturity, very, very difficult to rectify. So.
- 7.93 OK, so the child is building him or herself from the bottom up, scaffolding on these basic reflexes that are integrated, first of all, in these fundamental motivational and emotional states. Right now, **Piaget** kind of thought of children as reflexive and then building only on the reflex. The more accurate representation is something like that the child comes into the world wired up in some ways on the sensory and motor side, and then organizes those micro abilities within the confines of basic motivational and emotional states, which are also innate.
- 7.94 Now, **Swanson, Larry Swanson** did a very good job of mapping out what those basic motivational states are. Now, we could contrast motivation and emotion. Let's do that. Emotion isn't really a category, because many of the things that we regard as emotions are dependent on different brain systems. So emotion is kind of a rough category that is practical but not exactly objective. Same with motivation. And you can say, well, what's the difference between motivation and emotion? And the answer is, they interpenetrate. Anger and pain are good examples. It's like, is pain emotion, or is it a motivation? Is anger a motivation or an emotion? What about hunger?
- 7.95 Kind of a rule of thumb you can use is that a motivation sets a goal, and an emotion tells you where you are on the pathway to that goal. Now, it's not exactly right because anger can set goals, right, but it's not bad and it's not a bad initial rubric. And if you use that, it can kind of orient you in the space properly. Basic motivations. Well, here's how they're grouped physiologically. So you have your spinal cord, let's say, and it sort of mediates some of the more basic, easily automatized fundamental motor actions like walking, let's say. Well-practiced fundamental motor routines.
- 7.96 And then on top of the spinal cord, there's a system called the **hypothalamus**. And it's kind of the first part of the brain. And it's responsible for very basic motivational states. It's got two

sections, the front half and the back half, roughly speaking, and one half is responsible for temperature regulation—tells you if you're hot or you're cold—thirst, hunger, sexual, sexual desire, and regulation of elimination. And so the way it works is you kind of cycle through those states, right? Sometimes you're hungry, sometimes you're thirsty, maybe you're a bit too hot. You're a bit too cold, right?

- 7.97** You have to regulate yourself biologically, and each of those motivational states is capable of putting up a frame of perception, with the goal being the satiation of that state. So you're hungry. Now you start imagining going into the kitchen, and then you start searching through what would satiate that state. Maybe you have a craving for peanut butter. Your cravings are dependent on your taste. The taste system is set up so that you can identify tastes. Many of them, although they're categorizable in about five different dimensions and those would be the basic tastes. There are six basic tastes, and each of those tastes is associated with a separate satiety function.
- 7.98** So the taste system is set up so you can taste things and you can evaluate whether that's, whether you want that or not. And that's why you can eat enough protein for dinner and still want something sweet. Right, because the different taste systems have a different satiety counter, and satiation, which is the evaluation of the desirability of the taste, is separate from the taste.
- 7.99** You can imagine a different system where, you know, the more you eat of something, the less it tastes until it finally doesn't taste like anything and you're done. But that isn't how it's set up. The taste remains constant, but the desirability of the taste shifts. And in principle, part of the reason you have independent satiety is so that you eat a variety of different foods. Right, and so, anyways, you get hungry. Now the goal is to eat. You can see that that fantasy will enter your imagination. You know you're lying in bed or you're working and you think, oh, I'd like a sandwich.
- 7.100** It's like you, if you notice what will happen is an image often will pop into your head. You know the image will be of a sandwich or of you walking into the kitchen. That's the grip of the imagination by the motivation system. And then your emotions will rearrange themselves around that new goal, so that the idea of going to the kitchen is now positive. Now there'll be a bit of ambivalence when you shift between frames, because you might be, the previous you who was working might be annoyed by the intrusion of the new idea into that space, right, because it's interfering with the previous goal, and you can get caught in conflict between goals that way.
- 7.101** That's an **approach-approach conflict**, **approach-approach conflict**, technically speaking. And then anything that gets in the way of the food is going to be regarded as an obstacle, and anything that isn't relevant will be zeroed out so you don't perceive it, right? Most of the world is zeroed out. Almost everything. Way more than you think. So here's an example. Famous experiment.

- 7.102** So you're a tourist and you're on a university campus, right? And a kid comes up to you with a map and asks you to tell them where to go with the map. And so you're busily playing with the map. Now, while you're doing that, some workmen walk by rudely with a door. And when they do so, they get between you and the student, and it blocks the student from your view momentarily. Unbeknownst to you, the people carrying the door are psychological experimenters, and as they walk past, they swap the person that you were talking to with one of the people carrying the door, who also now has the map. And so when the door ceases to obscure your vision, there's a new person standing in front of you asking the same question.
- 7.103** The question is, do you notice? And you think, well, of course you notice. It's like, no, you don't. And the reason for that is, all young people asking questions who you don't know are the same. And the reason for that is, what the hell difference does it make to you? You don't know the person. Why concentrate on the differentiators when the function is the same? And you'd think, oh no, I'd notice. It's like, no, you wouldn't. They've done this, too, in stores where it's quite funny. The experiments. **Change blindness** is what the experiments are called. You're at a store. The, you're interacting with the person, and they disappear beneath the counter for a second, and a different person pops up, and you think, yeah, you'd notice. It's like, no, you wouldn't.
- 7.104** There's the **invisible gorilla**. Very, very famous experiment. You just can't believe this can possibly be true. So you see these six people, three dressed in black, three dressed in white, and they're throwing basketballs on a team in front of elevators. That's how the video is structured. And your goal is to watch the team in white pass the basketball back and forth, and count the number of times the basketball is passed. OK, so you're watching, counting, because you're so smart. You're going to get this right.
- 7.105** And while you're doing this, a gorilla comes onto the screen. Like, the people fill the screen, by the way. This is not some distant gorilla. A gorilla comes onto the screen and stands right in the middle of the screen and beats its chest like five times, and then walks off. And then the experiment concludes and you ask the people, "Did anything—" You asked them how many counts, and they go 17. They're feeling pretty good about themselves because they're so smart. And you say, well, did you notice anything strange? And they say, well, no, no. What do you mean?
- 7.106** And then you say, well, did you see the, did you see the gorilla? And they say, well, there's no bloody gorilla. And they say, well, I'll just show you the video again. And so this time they're kind of watching for the gorilla, which you'd think you'd be watching for anyways. And sure enough, the gorilla comes out. It's 100% starkly obvious. It's right in the middle of the screen, beating its chest, and it wanders off, and you think, oh my God, how blind am I? And the answer is, you're so blind you can barely imagine it.
- 7.107** It's a remarkable thing that you just don't walk into walls all the time. Like, if it's not relevant to your goals, you do not see it. And that's, man, there's no way you can learn that deeply enough, because then that means that what's relevant in your world is dependent on your goals. So you've got to be thinking, like, maybe you're miserable. And then you might think, well, what am

I missing? Well, the answer is, you're missing almost everything. And maybe you're missing exactly what you need because your goals are wrong. It's highly, highly probable.

- 7.108** What are you ignoring while you're pursuing what you're pursuing? Right? That's that **underworld** of complexity that you fall into when your conceptualizations collapse. And the utility of that is God only knows what you'll discover that, you know, you were blinded to by your idiot presumptions. So one rule of thumb, it's a good one is, if you're miserable, maybe you're missing something, and you'd better hope that's true, because the alternative is, you're miserable and that's your destiny. You know, if you're miserable because you're stupid and you could fix it, that's good news. Now, it might be that you're kind of profoundly stupid, and it will take a lot of work, but, God, it's a lot better than the alternative.
- 7.109** All right, so **Swanson** mapped out the **hypothalamus**. It'll switch you between these fundamental motivated states, each of which has its own perceptions, its own emotions, its own imagination, its own fantasies, its own view of the future, like they're full-fledged personalities, as you kind of know when you get angry. You know how when you're angry, well, you want to win. You want to defeat, even if it's the person you care for. And you'll have fantasies about victory, and you'll only remember terrible things about the person you're arguing with.
- 7.110** And then maybe you'll snap out of it later and you'll think, oh my God, you know, it's like, I like this person. What the hell am I doing? It's like, yeah, well, the anger demon got you, and it's a personality, and it's way better conceptualized as a personality. And it's worse than that, in a way, because you can imagine, like, a kind of meta-personality of negative emotion, anger, resentment, bitterness, the desire, pride, all wrapped together and then surrounded by a cloud of cultural elaboration that's sort of like the villain, like the **Joker** in the **Batman** series.
- 7.111** Then you think, that's what you're inviting in when you allow anger to possess you. It's not just a biological motivation, man. It's a full-fledged personality, and God only knows where it will take you. And so if you study, like, the darker regions of psychopathology, for example, I've spent a lot of time studying the writings and sayings of extremely vicious and pathological people, and they brood on their resentful fantasies, sometimes for years, before they go out and commit their, like, school shooting crimes.
- 7.112** And they develop these fantasies that are a consequence of their possession by these dark ideas that are so brutal that you just, it's, what would you say? Trauma-inducing just to begin to understand. And so, it's very useful and salutary to understand that these lower-level motivational systems are best construed as personalities. They're the archaic deities of the world—love, lust, aggression, hunger, even gluttony, the fundamental sins, pride. They're much more like personalities. They have a viewpoint. They strive for dominance.
- 7.113** **Nietzsche** had figured this out 150 years ago, right? That we're this internal war of competing subpersonalities. Now, if you meld all those together and you put them in their proper place, they become allies instead of foes. But if they're alienated because you **repressed** them in the **Freudian** sense, you failed to bring them aboard, so they, they're occupying a kind of

independent existence. You haven't integrated your aggression, for example. You've made it an enemy. You're in—you've got one hell of a foe on your hands. You better watch your step. So that's all very useful to understand as well.

8. Traits and Transformation

AT A GLANCE

Completes the physiology: the hypothalamus governs both basic motivations and exploration, which is linked to dopamine, addiction, and religious transformation; obstacles and unpredictability set the emotional landscape, and the dragon is the predator with treasure. Discusses female mate preference (Beauty and the Beast), hypergamy, pain and anxiety systems, reptile-driven vision, r and k strategies, and Dark Tetrad short-term maters. Surveys psychometrics: the heritability and predictive power of IQ, conscientiousness, and neuroticism; the Big Five with their aspects and sex differences; plasticity and stability; the Pareto distribution of creativity; and the Dark Tetrad. Ends with a course summary.

- 8.1** All right. So let's just walk through this with some degree of specificity. You're going from point A to B all the time. You see a pathway and you see tools. That produces positive effect. Things that move you forward, that produces positive emotion. That's what positive emotion is. It's something that signifies movement towards a desired aim, **incentive reward** that's mediated by the **dopamine** system. OK.
- 8.2** So now in the **hypothalamus**, the **hypothalamus** sets up the aims and the frame, right. The aim, the goal, and the **frame of reference**. OK, now the other side of the **hypothalamus**, it mediates exploration. This is why you can take a cat. They're called **decorticate cats**. Take a cat and you take its whole brain off, and all that's left is the spinal cord and the **hypothalamus**. So it's like 90% of its brain is gone. If it's a female cat, it can still function pretty well. Male cats can't organize their sexual behavior if they just have a **hypothalamus**, but a female cat can.
- 8.3** And so it can cycle through all its motivational states and maintain itself in a relatively simple environment. And it's hyper-exploratory. So that's so weird. As I mentioned before, a cat with no brain is hyper-exploratory. Well, why? Well, the reason you stop exploring anything is because you explore, you make a model, and then you remember. And so you don't have to explore anymore because you have a model of the thing that you remember. Well, if you don't have a brain, you can't remember. And so all you do is explore.
- 8.4** And likely what happens with psychedelics is that psychedelics eliminate inhibition of cortex on exploration. And so everything pops out of its frame. And so it's magnificent, wonderful, and miraculous in its complexity. And you hyper-explore, like, entranced by the phenomena which has reemerged, but you have no access to your habitual **frames of reference**. Now that can help you investigate what's novel again. But, well, the cost is, is that everything is entrancing.
- 8.5** And, you know, a lot of the time, especially by the time you're an adult, you ignore almost everything. Instead of perceiving, you see your memories, you see your assumptions. You know, I know this. Like, I can't really bring the houses in the neighborhood I live in now to mind. I've been in this neighborhood for 20 years. Why? I've never really looked at them. The neighborhood I grew up in as a kid, I can visualize every single house, right? Because I explored

them thoroughly. By the time I was an adult, it's like, probably I didn't care. It's like, one house is pretty much the same as another, and I had other things to do than to be, like, transfixed by the wonder of each house.

- 8.6 But when you're a child, you've got that, and then you map it, you know, and that's, now that becomes the a priori **frame of reference** through which you see the world. It's so cool. Most of what you see, most of what you see is memory. And so the way your visual system is structured, you get input from your retina, right, to the primary visual cortex. It detects things like edges, primary aspects of the visual reality. And then that's elaborated as you move up the physiological hierarchy towards your more complex brain areas, let's say.
- 8.7 But those more complex brain areas have top-down inhibition and modification at each level. So even when you're directly perceiving, you're not. Most of what you see is what you assume. Now, the advantage to that is efficiency, right? Because once you've built a model, you might as well just see the model. But the problem with that is, well, what if your model is wrong? That's a problem. Or what if something's changed, right? And so, well, you have to be able to adjust on the fly essentially. And you do that with exploration and you do that with error. Because error signals that you're a priori presumption is incorrect.
- 8.8 You default to exploration. How does the **hypothalamus** manage that? Well, it's half standard reference frame. What should you eat. And it's half, you should explore if you aren't getting what you need. And then there's a default position, which is, if you've got everything you need, why not explore? Because you might as well do some extra mapping, just to figure out if there's something out there that you might need in the future.
- 8.9 And so that's, that shows you that that, there's a couple of things to understand there. One is exploration is very fundamental. It's as old neurologically as thirst or hunger. So that's old. It's half of your motivational system, half of the **hypothalamus**. What else is cool is that that half, that's the foundation of the **dopaminergic** system. That's the system that cocaine and amphetamine and all the drugs of abuse activate. It's the positive emotion system. And so you're wired so that exploration and positive emotion are basically the same thing, exploration, approach to a valued goal, and positive emotion. They're the same thing.
- 8.10 And the reason people like cocaine, for example, is because cocaine makes them feel like they're doing something high-order worthwhile, because it hyper-stimulates the systems that mediate that emotion. So now, one of the best ways of overcoming an addiction is to find something better to do, right. It's one of the best ways to deal with an alcohol addiction, for example, is, maybe you like drinking. Like, maybe it's a great **dopaminergic** drug for you. Maybe it mediates a lot of your social contacts. Maybe all your friends are alcoholics, which is highly probable if you're an alcoholic. So you have lots of reasons to drink.
- 8.11 So then you stop drinking and you go through the **withdrawal**. That can kill you. That can take a little while, then you're no longer dependent. Maybe that happens in a treatment center, but you go back to your normal environment and you relapse almost immediately, partly why? You

need something better to do. You know, part of the reason that 12-step programs work, for example, is they orient people. They orient people different ethically, and they give them some other avenue, partly for communal, community, because a 12-step program will do that. They also orient them spiritually, let's say, towards higher goals, and that actually recalibrates their nervous systems, so that pursuit of something worthwhile provides the kick that the drug had substituted for.

- 8.12** People use false adventures all the time as a substitute for the real thing and the— it's been known for years in the addiction treatment literature, that there's almost no more reliable treatment for addiction than religious transformation. Everyone knows that, even all the atheistic researchers. It's well-established fact, especially with regards to alcoholics. So, so tools. Obstacles. Positive emotion. Negative emotion.
- 8.13** Here's a little bit more complicated way of thinking about it. You're moving from point A to point B. You see what you predict and hope for, right? So that means that your plan is working, right. As you move towards it, the world is cooperating with you, and you're making progress. That means you're getting towards your goal. So that's very useful. Makes you happy. But it also means that your **frame of reference** is valid.
- 8.14** OK. So now let's say obstacles start to arise. OK. Two possibilities. One is you can circumvent them and keep the same aim. Another is, the obstacles are insuperable and you have to switch your aim. That's a more fundamental defeat. That knocks you down the **rabbit hole**. Your aim disintegrates. The meaning of the world becomes indeterminate. You're surrounded by **chaos** that hasn't been ordered yet. And then you can despair. You're anxiety-ridden, maybe curious, but anxiety-ridden. You've collapsed, you've defeated, and something new can emerge out of that, which would be the emergence of a new **frame of reference**.
- 8.15** Sometimes that can happen for motivational reasons, like if you're depressed and you're lying in bed, you'll probably get hungry enough to eat, right? So the motivational systems can grip you even if you're in the pits of despair. But it's better to generate up a new meta-strategy if you can manage it. So unpredictability, obstacles and unpredictability produce negative emotion. Unpredictability is a little more complex because it also elicits curiosity and positive emotion.
- 8.16** You know, so maybe you're in an unhappy marriage and your wife cheats on you. Let's say, well, is that a bad thing or a good thing? Well, mostly it's column A, but it's also partly column B, and that's a good example of the complexity of the unpredictable, right. If you're in a miserable situation, something that upsets your boat is an opportunity as well as a complicating catastrophe. So we have an ambivalent response to the unpredictable, right? Some of it's freezing, like a prey animal, and some of it is, yeah, what might happen? Especially if we interacted with it properly.
- 8.17** That's that concatenation of the dragon and the treasure. Right. That's really reflective of the fundamental operation of our nervous system. It's like the unknown emerges. What is it? It's a dragon. Which is a predator, right? Cat. Eagle. Reptile. Fire. That's a dragon. It's a predator.

What's the unknown? Predator, with treasure. Right, and that's, that's exactly right, forever. That's what the unknown is. And what's the right orientation? Well, you can run and hide, or you can take arms and confront. And that's the heroic path forward.

- 8.18 And that's what human beings are. Like, we're not prey animals. We're kind of prey animals, because things can eat us and we're not very big, but fundamentally, we're prey animals that decided they were going to be predators. And we got very good at it. So when the, when human beings came to North America 20,000 years ago about, it took like 3,000 years, and they wiped out every mammal that was roughly their size, right? All the mastodons, all the mammoths, all the saber-toothed tigers, anything that was predatory or edible. 3000 years, gone.
- 8.19 Why? Twenty men with spears? It's like, there's no animal with bigger teeth than that. And that's human beings, man. We are one wicked force to contend with. So, and that's prey animals who decided to be predators. That's exactly what we are. That's our basic pattern. And it's even true on the sexual side, you know. It's certainly the case that the more successful hunters, in the socialized sense, too, in archaic communities, have the most children.
- 8.20 And so women are—standard pattern of female pornographic fantasy is well mapped out by the Google engineers who studied millions of instances of female pornography usage. Men use images, women use fiction. Verbal representation; stories. The pattern's clear. Five most common targets of female sexual desire in the fictional world. Vampire. Werewolf. Pirate. Billionaire. Surgeon. Right, and the standard story is very clear. It's *Beauty and the Beast*. You know, the Disney story. So there's a *Gaston*. He's a narcissist, *Dark Tetrad* type. He pretends to be a man. He pretends to embody the masculine. And he's pretty good at fooling stupid, naive women. That's the giggly blonds in the Disney representation.
- 8.21 And there's a beast on the periphery who's genuinely aggressive and who's made some mistakes in the past. He's a, has the potential to be an actual predator, and she establishes a relationship with him and tames him. She has preference for the genuine item in contradistinction to the *narcissistic* pretender. Then there's a battle between the *narcissistic* pretender and the genuine beast, and Beauty allies herself with the Beast who's now being socialized and civilized.
- 8.22 So what are women after? Predatory men who are productive and can share. Right. Very tight balance for women. It's a very hard target to hit because you want someone who's genuinely capable of being monstrous, who has subordinated that to productivity and generosity. Right, and so that's an intimidating father, let's say. And so you can understand that's a pretty damn hard target for women to hit. They're also very picky.
- 8.23 So the thing that distinguishes female humans from chimpanzee females— they're our closest biological relative by a large margin—female chimpanzees, when they're sexually motivated, are not choosy in their mates. So the dominant males among chimps have more infants. But that's because they chase away the subordinate males from the, from the females that are in heat. The females in estrus. And that happens in chimps, but not in human beings. Human-being

females have **concealed ovulation**, differently than chimps. The males chase away the subordinates, the females, but the females will mate with any male.

- 8.24** But among human beings, that's not the case at all. Human females are extremely choosy, and sometimes to their own detriment. As the intelligence of a woman increases, the probability that she'll be married decreases. Why? Women are **hypergamous** across cultures. They prefer men who are at their social status or higher, right. Whereas men mate across and down the hierarchy, women mate across and up. And that means that as a woman stacks up desirable traits, her window of acceptable mate shrink. And so that's mostly marked in the case of intelligence.
- 8.25** And so if you have a woman who's three standard deviations above the mean in intelligence, her pool of acceptable men shrinks to 1% of the population. So then imagine she's attractive and hardworking and intelligent. It's like, what's her problem? Well, who's she going to find? I had lots of women like that in my clinical practice, because I worked— with one corner of my practice was high-achieving people. So I worked with law firms who sent their most productive people to me on the understanding, with this company I worked with, that we would help make them even more productive than they were, because every law firm depends on a small number of its employees who are extremely proficient as lawyers, but who also can generate business. Very rare combination.
- 8.26** And a fair number of them were women, half of them probably, maybe more. And they were always women in their 30s. The law firms lost all those women because what the women concluded at about 30 was they didn't want to work 20 hours a day, which is what the really high-end male lawyers would do, right? Because if you're at the pinnacle of your profession, like the serious pinnacle, all you do is work. Like, you're smart and you know what you're doing. And then the way you maintain your edge among everybody else who's smart and knows what they're doing is you just work all the time.
- 8.27** And women who can do that, they hit 30 and they think, why am I doing this? Which is a really good question, right? Because the real question is, isn't why you would do that, it's why anyone would do that. Why would anyone do that, work 80 hours a week, especially if they're already making more money than they need? Well, the answer to that is some men will do that because that's what they're like. Like, they'll just, no matter what situation they're in, they'll hyper-explore and head for the top. Why? Well, that's what makes them maximally attractive on the reproductive side. And that's built right into their physiology.
- 8.28** It has no effect whatsoever of that on women. Zero. And so what the women usually conclude is, I'd rather have a 9 to 5 job and have a life, which is also what most men conclude, by the way, and which is a good default position. Why wouldn't you conclude that? And so the law firms— this is true with every high-performing enterprise. They all lose all their females in their 30s because the women think, "I don't want to work 100 hours a week. Why the hell would I? I'd rather have a life." Especially if they marry a man who's high-achieving, because then, which they do, which also eliminates the economic need.

- 8.29 So, you know, you hear about the glass ceiling. It's like, yeah, all the women that I worked with in law firms in Toronto, and that was a lot of them, they all knew perfectly well why the women left. And it wasn't because they were having trouble organizing childcare. Those firms were bending themselves over backwards to keep their women, because these women were worth, in terms of the business they were generating, like tens of millions of dollars a year. The law firms were, like, competing like mad to promote them and keep them. But it didn't work.
- 8.30 So we talked about the basic motivational frames, you know, the fundamental motivations—thirst, hunger, sexual drive, defensive aggression, elimination—all mediated by these subcortical systems that organize basic behaviors in their purview. That's sort of like the default human being. That's associated with exploration, which is also a **hypothalamic** function that's regulated by systems, part of the negative emotion systems that aren't in the **hypothalamus**, by the way, anxiety and pain. Those are separate systems.
- 8.31 So pain stops approach and exploration, obviously. You encounter something that causes you pain when the systems that are involved are damaged by the encounter. That's pain. Anxiety or fear is the threat that something that's damaging might occur. So, you have a pain system that regulates your approach, and you have an anxiety system that says, look out, because pain is likely. And that's a later maturing and more sophisticated neurological system. That's part of the negative emotion system that regulates exploratory behavior and motivated approach.
- 8.32 Right, and so, and different brain systems mediate pain. **Periaqueductal gray**. Opiates are the chemical that mediate, that quell pain. Benzodiazepines, alcohol, barbiturates, mediate anxiety. **Dopaminergic** agonists like cocaine and amphetamines activate the exploratory system. So that's the landscape of reinforcing drugs. And that's why they're addictive and rewarding. Some of them moderate anxiety. Some of them quell pain. Some of them produce a state of incentive activation that's equivalent to excitement, **enthusiasm**, and adventure. And that's pretty much the landscape of addiction.
- 8.33 So that was all mapped out painfully, mostly by animal researchers, absolutely painstaking research, thousands of papers very, very well summarized by **Jeffrey Gray** in this book, *The Neuropsychology of Anxiety*, by **Jaak Panksepp**, in *Affective Neuroscience*. This **Swanson** beautifully mapped out the nervous system, especially its lower-level functions, the **hypothalamus**.
- 8.34 We can see the association between the function of those systems and the story we told. The hero story—that's exploration, right. Is, what do you do, by default? You explore. Why? Because you expand your world, right? And what do you explore in the face of? Negative emotion and positive emotion, right? Negative emotion. That's the dragon. What's a dragon? It's a predator. That's been studied. There's a great book on the symbolism of dragons. I think it's called *Here There Be Dragons*. I can't remember, unfortunately. Tree snake, cat bird. That's a dragon. It's the same in image. It's the same idea as the concept predator.

- 8.35 Our default imaginary representation of the unknown is dragon. Why? Well, what the hell should you imagine when you're three years old and you're wandering away at night from the fire. Right? What do you imagine in the darkness? How about a python? Five percent of primate deaths worldwide are reptile-related. And if you look cross-culturally, this is so cool, if you look cross-culturally at the acuity of primate vision, the primates with the most acute vision live in the territories with the largest percentage of reptiles. Why? Because they're very good at hiding and camouflaging.
- 8.36 And so our vision is a gift from our reptilian enemies, right? Our vision, you see in the story of Genesis that it's the serpent who opens Eve and Adam's eyes. The serpent and the fruit are vision. We're trichromats. Why? To detect ripe fruit. Right. So we have color vision because we're fruit-eating primates, and we have acute vision because reptiles were our enemies. Right, this is going back like 60 million years or longer. Very, since we had, since we were tree-dwelling-like shrews. It's about 60 million years, back when there were still dinosaurs. The enmity between reptiles and mammals is very, very old.
- 8.37 So what's a good imaginary representation of that which lurks beyond the confines of the light? Remember in The Lion King, when Simba is sitting on Pride Rock with his father, who says everything the light touches is ours? Remember the kingdom outside the light? It's all skeletons and hyenas, right? It's the kingdom of the dead. Why? Wander away from the fire and see what happens. You think you're entering the landscape of the dead? You most certainly are. Are there hyenas there? You bet there are. Yeah, right. And hyenas, man, those things—their teeth can crack bones, no problem. And they're pretty formidable opponents to lions. So that's the landscape of the darkness beyond the light. Right.
- 8.38 And Simba, that's where he goes after his father dies, right? That's a descent into the underworld, into, into the chaotic underworld. And it's the encounter with the anima from the Jungian perspective that turns him from an adolescent into a hero, right? Because Nala shows up when he's out with his adolescent friends, living for the moment because he's still immature, and shames him. Right? He's attracted to her. She doesn't care much for him. Why? Because he's an immature adolescent. She's got no interest in him. She's got serious things to do.
- 8.39 And that's really the case for women because they mature sexually earlier than men. And it's way more of a burden for them because they can get pregnant and they're smaller and they're more vulnerable, and they're going to have to care for infants. And so worldwide, by the way, women prefer men who are about four years older. That goes along with the hypergamy. And it looks like it's part of the attempt to balance the scales, because you might say, well, why do women prefer men who are above, at or above their level socioeconomically? And the answer is, why the hell do they want another kid, right?
- 8.40 I mean, they're, they're already—what is it? Typical chimpanzee female, I think, carries her infant. I think it's something like 500 miles before it matures. It might be more than that. Tremendous burden, this dependent infant. And it's way more in the case of human beings, because human infants are way more immature and dependent than even chimpanzee infants.

It's like, the dependency period is 18 years. So what do you want, if you're female, to redress the scales, is you want someone that will help you voluntarily with that burden over the long run.

- 8.41 OK. So that'll, that'll take us into **Dark Tetrad** traits to some degree. This is quite fun. So there's two patterns of mating that characterize the biological world. OK. There's mosquito puffball pattern. And there's human pattern. OK. And the humans are on the extreme of—one is called *r*, small *r*, and the other is called *k*. I don't remember why it's called *k*. *R* is for reproduction. The mosquito puffball technique, fish as well, is 100 million offspring. No care. All of them die, but like one. Otherwise you're knee-deep in mosquitoes in no time flat. Right?
- 8.42 So it's, sex is the initial investment. Sperm. Nothing else. Now the female devotes the egg, which is much bigger, so it's much bigger biological sacrifice. The definition of female is not chromosomal, biologically. The definition of female is that sex that devotes most resource to reproduction, and that starts right at the level of egg. The egg is much bigger than the sperm, and then it's replicated at every level of reproduction. The female in virtually every species invests more. OK.
- 8.43 It's still not much of an investment for the ***r* strategists**. They produce a plethora of offspring with no investment. On the very opposite end of the continuum are human beings. Very few offspring, very high investment. 18 years, more than that. Human beings have the lifespan they do because we're multi-generational investors. There's room for grandparents, because human children are so complex that one generation of parents is not enough. And so we seem to have evolved the lifespan we've evolved because it's optimal for children to have grandparents around to help with their care. So that's how extensive the dependency period is for human beings.
- 8.44 OK. So what does that imply? No investment. High investment. Human beings over here. Now let's take human beings and do the same thing. We could imagine that there are two patterns of human reproduction. Low investment and high investment. OK, there's arguably men tilt more than women towards low investment strategies. Now, why? Well, because they can. Right. Because a man can sleep around. And if he gets someone casually pregnant, he can run away from the pregnancy. Whereas at least historically speaking, the woman wasn't going to run away from the pregnancy. So men can get away with low investment sexual strategies.
- 8.45 OK, now imagine we take the—we take men and women, but we'll concentrate on men for the time being, and we map out their personalities in relationship to their preference for sexual strategy. I'll tell you a funny story about this first. Orangutans have two male variants. So, and this was only discovered in the last few decades. So the typical orangutan is arboreal. So they live in the trees almost all the time, very graceful creatures. And, but the males, the reproductively successful males, are so big that they really can't be arboreal, so they hang around on the ground like football blockers, tackles.

- 8.46 And the females come to them. But there's another male variant. And they thought these were adolescents, and they're thin and arboreal. And that's what an adolescent male looks like. But a lot of the adult males still have that form. There's only one ground-dwelling dominant male in a territory. And if you're the male and you're not him, then you stay arboreal and your strategy is rape. The females don't come to you. You chase them down. OK. So there are opportunistic, there's an opportunistic male variant among orangutans. Right. So the females come to the high status male, and the low status males have to use force.
- 8.47 Exactly the same is true among human beings. OK. So now here's the question. You have this distribution of mating strategies, short-term adventurous mating versus long-term commitment. OK, now you personality-map those males. What are the short-term males like? **Dark Tetrad**, **narcissistic**, **Machiavellian**, **psychopathic**, and **sadistic**. That's a good thing to know. Now, naive young women confuse the **narcissistic**, **psychopathic**, **Machiavellian** sadists with confident men because they're emotionless, and they're emotionless because they're predatory, not because they're competent.
- 8.48 Like, women are after competent men. That's why they go for wealth. It's not because of the wealth. It's because the wealth marks competence. And they want competence and they want long-term commitment. The **psychopathic** pretenders mimic that with their confidence. That's **Gaston in Beauty and the Beast**. He's a pretender. Yeah. So that's really something to understand, why that's quite the remarkable. OK. And that brings us into the psychometric domain. And we'll, we'll close up with that.
- 8.49 So far we've talked about clinical investigation with many of the theorists and biological investigation. There's another domain of inquiry in the psychological field which is statistical and psychometric. So let's call it statistical. OK. So how does it work? Well, in the cognitive domain, you can imagine aggregating the kinds of cognitive tests that I already described, any kind of test that requires abstract conceptualization, any kind. Rate of word reading, for example, mathematical problem solving, pattern identification, general knowledge. Doesn't matter—if it requires abstract conceptualization, we'll put it in the bin.
- 8.50 Then the question would be, how many different ways are there of thinking? And the answer basically is one. Fast and slow, comprehensive and narrow. One. Now it's a bit more complicated than that because as someone becomes more intelligent, their intelligence differentiates. So there's really one way of being not very bright and varied ways of being super intelligent. But fundamentally, it's one thing, smart versus not smart. And so, and that's been discovered mostly statistically.
- 8.51 And the way that's been discovered is you give a whole bunch of people a whole bunch of tests, and you see how they do. And what you find is the people who do good on one test, who do well on one test, do well on them all, and it's insanely stable and it's unbelievably biologically predicated. So here's an example. Imagine you took identical twins and you separated them at birth, OK. And then you studied their—how alike their **general cognitive ability** was, how good they were at problem solving.

- 8.52 Now you might look at the intelligence of their parents, their adoptive parents, and see if that had any effect. Right, because then you'd see that the environment mattered and you could see if the environment mattered more than their biological heritage. Right, because you could contrast one twin with the other, especially if they're separated at birth. What do you discover? Identical twins separated at birth are much more like each other than they are like their adoptive brothers and sisters. They're no more alike their adopted brothers and sisters than they are alike strangers, and their intelligence is remarkably unrelated to that of their adoptive parents and still predicted by their biological parents.
- 8.53 And they're almost universally as intelligent as their twin. And then you might say, OK, well, imagine you track their intelligence across time as they mature. What you'd expect is that, as they got older, separated as they are environmentally, they'd become more and more unlike each other, right? More different from each other, as the difference in their experience accrued. That's not what happens. The opposite happens. By the time they're 60, identical twins separated at birth are so alike one another on the intelligence front that it's like testing the same person twice.
- 8.54 And what seems to happen is that the biological determinants of intelligence, the longer they have to manifest themselves, the more comprehensively they determine **general cognitive ability**. So **general cognitive ability** is unitary and highly heritable, very stable across life. And the best predictor on the personality side of long-term success is work ethic. **Conscientiousness**. The more you work, the better you do, right? Unsurprisingly.
- 8.55 That probably only works in societies that actually reward merit, right? Because you can imagine a society set up—the alternative to **meritocracy**, by the way, is dynasty and nepotism, historically. It's not equity. It's not everybody gets the same thing. If you don't use objective tests of merit, you default to nepotism, favoritism, and dynasty, promotion of family members. **Meritocracy** is the way out of that. **Meritocracy** prioritizes intelligence. It's a brutal business, but intelligence is the best predictor of ability and complex domains by far.
- 8.56 It's—the correlation between long-term life success and IQ is about 0.5, 0.6, something like that. So that, you square that. That accounts for 34% of the variance. So there's random effects. You know, health for example, can make a difference, and situation can make a difference. There's random things that can happen to you, and other factors that play a role. But the measurable factor that plays the biggest role is intelligence.
- 8.57 The second best predictor, which is **conscientiousness**. We can't measure it as precisely. Likely we don't have good behavioral measures of **conscientiousness**. Weirdly enough, they're very hard to come by. My lab tried for years to find a measure of **conscientiousness** that wasn't personality report. Like, I could report on your **conscientiousness** if you were my child or my wife, say, because I knew you, or I could self-report. You'd think I could find a way of assessing your habits that would predict your **conscientiousness**. But no one's been able to crack that. Not really, weirdly enough.

- 8.58 Anyways, if we use personality tests, you only get about 9% of the variance in long-term life success with a, with **conscientiousness** measurement compared to 50% . That's the upper bound. 35% is a reasonable estimate. So the best predictor we have on the outside of IQ is only one quarter as powerful.
- 8.59 After that, it's **neuroticism**, which is negatively correlated. That's trait negative emotion. That accounts for about 5% of life success, probably because you can't tolerate stress well. You know, so you're more likely to collapse in consequence of an excess workload, let's say. So IQ is unitary. It's the thing that makes smart people smart across a multitude of situations. It's very much dependent on brain health. And it's an index of brain health. It's highly dependent on nutrition. If you want smart kids, breastfeeding them is a good idea. You can decrease IQ by starving people. You can decrease IQ by decreasing the cognitive complexity of their environment.
- 8.60 It's quite difficult to increase it. No one has figured out how to do it. No one's figured out how to improve it by practice. If you educate people, you can fragment IQ a little bit into nonverbal and verbal, and you can increase people's verbal IQ by educating them. But it's damn difficult to increase their nonverbal IQ. And you might think, if you had people practice a variety of different cognitive tests, that they would practice the meta-trait that unites all of them. It doesn't seem to work. So no one's cracked that problem. And many, many people have tried.
- 8.61 And now and then you get a report in the psychological literature that somebody practiced, like, a complex video game, and they did better on an IQ test, but it never replicates. No one's managed it. If you want to maintain your brain health, it's like, exercise, it's by far the most. Like, your IQ decreases from the age of about 23 outward, especially nonverbal. So you get—it gets harder and harder to learn, and you're slower and slower. And the best way to stave it off is by far cardiovascular health and weightlifting. So that's a useful thing to know. It's very effective, by the way. And even if you're older, 50, and you start exercising, you can restore a fair bit of your cognitive function. So that's a useful thing to know.
- 8.62 On the personality side, you take 10,000 questions and you administer them to a thousand people, and you assess how the questions clump. So for example, let's look at **extraversion**. I laugh a lot, and I'm most likely to be the first person to talk in a new social situation. Those clump; they're manifestations of the same thing. I don't like being alone. I prefer to be around other people. And, what's an **assertiveness** indication? Yeah, I'm likely to take control in a social situation. Those two things clump. If you say yes to one, you're likely to say yes to another.
- 8.63 So psychologists have taken huge banks of questions and mapped them out statistically. Right. What, which questions clump. And then once you know the clumps, right, then you can assess people. And you look, you can look at their comparative differences. That's the trait approach. OK. Now if you do that, you find that there's five, basically five dimensions of personality. We'll talk about a sixth variant, five dimensions. **Extraversion**. That's positive emotion, fundamentally. It breaks down into **assertiveness**. So that's social dominance and **enthusiasm**. Positive emotion.

- 8.64 Men and women are quite similar in **extraversion**. Women are slightly higher. Women are quite a bit higher in **enthusiasm** and lower in **assertiveness**. So overall the **extraversion** levels balance between the sexes. But women are more, have more positive emotion. So, and they're not quite as assertive verbally. So that's **extraversion**. And the biological substrata is the positive emotion system.
- 8.65 So the second personality dimension is **neuroticism**. That's negative emotion and it's an index of susceptibility to negative emotions. And we talked about the negative emotion systems. Pain and anxiety are the cardinal negative emotions, right. Response to punishment, pain, and response to threats of punishment, anxiety or novelty. That's negative emotion. It variegates—shame, guilt, frustration, disappointment, anger. They're all parts of the tree that branches out of negative emotion. If you're susceptible to one negative emotion, you tend to be more susceptible to all of them.
- 8.66 The major subsections of susceptibility to negative emotion are **withdrawal**. That makes you depressed. And **volatility**—that makes you irritable. Depressed people are markedly irritable. It's underdiagnosed because irritable people aren't irritable to people of higher status. They're irritable to people of lower status. So depressed people tend not to be irritable to their physicians. So it's underdiagnosed, but they tend to be irritable to people around them. It makes it hard to deal with a depressed person. And depressed people know that. And that's hard on them to realize that, so that's annoying.
- 8.67 Women are higher in negative emotion than men reliably across culture. That kicks in at puberty, because it's not true for boys and girls, and it's probably characteristic of sexual differentiation. And the question is why? There's a bunch of possible answers. One is boys and girls are about the same size and about equally strong. Not true once women hit adolescence, because the men get bigger and stronger, especially in the upper body. And human beings are upper body fighters, like kangaroos. And so the difference in upper body strength between men and women is substantial. The curves barely overlap, so the strongest woman is on average, in the upper body, weaker than the weakest man.
- 8.68 And so that's a huge disadvantage on the battlefield, let's say. So one of the reasons for women to have higher levels of negative emotion at puberty is you probably shouldn't fight, especially with the man, because you're likely to get hurt. And so threat, the threat should intimidate you. Why else? You're sexually vulnerable in ways that men aren't. That's a huge contributor. So the world is more dangerous.
- 8.69 And perhaps more importantly, there's no reason to assume that a woman's nervous system or the nervous system of a human being, for that matter, is optimized for that individual, right. It could easily be that evolution has optimized the nervous system function of females for the infant-mother dyad, and not for the female. And so what does that mean? Women are alarm systems. Why? Well, when I had my first child with my wife, I built this bunk bed. And my daughter, infant daughter, slept underneath in a little crib. And at night, if that baby just made a

peep, my wife was like, instantly awake and down, like before I was even awake. She was already down there, right?

- 8.70** Women have to be very, very, very, very sensitive to the distress of infants. And the cost of that is that they're very, very sensitive to distress. And so that's, well, that's the price you pay for taking care of dependent infants. That's what, I think that's likely the biggest contributor, although all three of those perhaps play a role. You see this echoed, too, not only in the personality literature but in psychopathology literature. Men are much more likely to abuse substances and to be criminal than women, but women are much likely, more likely to be depressed and anxious. And that goes along with that higher proclivity for negative emotion.
- 8.71** And that's true cross-culturally and the differences between men and women, if you're inclined to think that this is cultural, are larger in gender egalitarian societies than they are in gender stratified society. So as the environment becomes less and less patriarchal, you could say, men and women get more different, not less. And the reason for that probability probably is that, imagine there's two sources of variation for the differences between men and women, one cultural and one biological. You get rid of the cultural difference. You maximize the biological difference, right?
- 8.72** The other major difference between men and women in the personality domain is in interest. And it's the biggest difference. So men and women don't seem to be much different at all in intellectual ability. Even on the mathematical side, it was thought for a while that there were more genius mathematicians among men. It's the **male variability hypothesis**, which is there are more loser men and there are more hyper-successful men. The curve of competence is broader among men. There's some evidence for that.
- 8.73** But there's a lot of gifted girls mathematically in junior high. Almost none of them pick mathematical careers. And there's a variety of hypotheses about that. One is that the girls who are particularly mathematically gifted also tend to be gifted in other ways, and the probability that their interest lines up with their mathematical skill is low, because women are reliably more interested in people than in things, whereas men are the reverse. And that's part of the reason why men are way more likely to be engineers, and women are way more likely to be nurses, especially in gender egalitarian societies.
- 8.74** So, and that goes along, by the way, that interest goes along with women's also higher level of **agreeableness**. So **agreeableness** is a trait that breaks down into **compassion** and **politeness**. And women are markedly higher than men in **agreeableness**. Like, they're still broadly similar. Right? Men and women are more similar than different on each trait. The biggest differences are in **neuroticism** and **agreeableness** and interest. But, but if you aggregate all the traits, you can separate men and women merely on the basis of personality, with about 75% accuracy. And if you add interest to that, the accuracy of classification goes up to like 85 to 90%. So.
- 8.75** And what that does mean is that there are, by the way, is there are plenty of women who have masculine personality and vice versa. And that is the one thing you might say, that the people

who presume something approximating the independence of gender from sex, there's something to be said for that. There's something to be said for that, because there are feminine men and there are masculine women. So masculinity and femininity have some independence from sex. But by and large, most sexually, most biological women are feminine in their temperament, and most biological men are masculine, especially if you take interest into account.

- 8.76 So, so what does that mean? Well, let's walk through the other traits. We talked about **extraversion**, positive emotion, variation in positive emotion. We talked about **neuroticism**, variation in negative emotion. So we know the underlying psychobiology, right. We can understand evolutionarily why there's differences in the traits or in the sexes in those two traits, especially with **neuroticism**.
- 8.77 **Agreeableness**. Well, **agreeableness** is something like, in a given negotiation, how much are you arguing for you and how much are you arguing for the other person? And the more agreeable you are, the more you argue for the other person. And that's part of caretaking. Disagreeable people are more competitive. They're harsher. They're blunter. Now, modern personality theorists tend to associate that with psychopathology, and that's a big mistake. It's a big mistake, because being disagreeable is not pathological in and of itself. Right.
- 8.78 There's very many admirable things about being disagreeable. In fact, if you want to hire a manager, the best managerial data show that disagreeable managers do a better job than agreeable managers. Why? Because the agreeable managers get taken advantage of. Right. Thing about being agreeable is you think the best of everyone. You don't have much of an imagination for evil. It makes you very cooperative. It makes you easy to be around unless you're resentful. What's the disadvantage? If you're agreeable, a malevolent person will walk all over you. And there are malevolent people.
- 8.79 And agreeable people don't like that idea at all, because they like to think the best of everyone. And that's fine when it's true, but it's not fine at all when the person you're dealing with is not your friend. Right, and 5% of the population, 3 to 5%, is seriously tilted towards **psychopathy**. That's 1 in 20, 1 in 30. Imagine the worst kid in your elementary school class. You know, the one who was not so good every year. Right, well, 3% of the population, they can cause an awful lot of trouble. And they're very good at preying on agreeable people. In fact, that's who they seek out.
- 8.80 So you got to watch that if you're agreeable. And that's the downside of that cooperative proclivity. You know, you're very good at caring for people, very cooperative. But you're putty in the hands of someone who's truly malevolent. This has been modeled, by the way, by game theorists. So you can set up cooperative games online, let's say, and watch how the community functions if all you have is cooperators. And so you can set up stable games that are composed of nothing but cooperative players. But if you drop one shark into the tank, he takes everything. Right, so that's the downside of **agreeableness**.

- 8.81 So that's offset by disagreeableness, more of a masculine trait. It manifests itself in competitiveness. And women prefer men who are somewhat disagreeable. It's complicated. We already walked through that. That's that Beauty and the Beast conundrum, is that women are more sexually attracted to higher-status men who have a certain predatory element, but that are productive and generous. And so what a woman is really looking for is a man who has disagreeable traits—so that's an integrated shadow, you'd say, from the psychoanalytic perspective—but who's also integrated the more feminine element that would be associated with generosity and hospitality and the ability to care for others. Right. So that's agreeableness.
- 8.82 Fourth trait. Conscientiousness. Industriousness and orderliness. Men and women are about equally conscientious, but women are higher in orderliness and men are higher in industriousness. And so, and the differences aren't huge, but they tilt in that direction, much to the dismay, I think, of the average woman whose threshold for mess in a household is slightly lower than her husband. One of the things that's weird about personality traits is, there doesn't have to be much difference between you and your mate to make all the difference in your relationship.
- 8.83 So one of the things I noticed, for example, with my kids, is my threshold for my child's misbehavior was slightly lower than my wife's. And so that meant I did most of the discipline. Not all of it, but I noticed if I just shut up for 10 seconds when my kids were being annoying, then my wife would intervene. It's just that she didn't get annoyed quite as fast as me. But since it's a threshold phenomena, we didn't need much of a difference between our temperaments to make a real difference in outcome.
- 8.84 And so, all right, last trait. Openness to experience. It subdivides into something like esthetic appreciation and creativity. That's one. And interest in ideas. Men and women are about the same in openness. But women are higher in esthetic appreciation, and men higher in interest in ideas. And so women like nonfiction and men like fiction. Sorry, women like fiction and men like nonfiction. Quite a reliable gender difference. And it reflects that underlying difference in temperament.
- 8.85 And so how does that play itself out in the world? YouTube tends to be a male-dominated social media platform, especially long-form podcasts. They're idea-centered, not esthetic-centered, so that's one difference. And it's weird because, see, in most enterprises, most enterprises are dominated by people who are particularly high in interest or ability in that domain. And so small differences in the mean can make a big difference in gender representation in any domain. So, like, men and women overlap to some degree in their interests and in whether or not they're agreeable. But way more men are engineers. It's like 10 to 1.
- 8.86 Why? Well, you have to be really interested in things and not very interested at all in people to be an engineer. And almost all the people like that are men, right? Because it's the extremes that are making the difference. It's the same with nursing. Like the Scandinavian countries have been trying to gender-balance engineering and nursing for like 30 years. It just goes nowhere. Like, they put all this effort and time into it. And for a while there's a few more female

engineers. But then when the social manipulation collapses, it goes back to like 10 to 1. Same on the nursing side.

- 8.87 And so what seems to happen is, when you make a society gender equal, men and women can pick their occupations based on their interest and their temperamental proclivities. And you get quite a lot of gender differentiation. And how that will play out in the long run, we really don't know. I mean, a lot of weird things are happening in our society at the moment. I mean, it's 2 to 1 women to men in universities, and there's some evidence that the women stop attending at about that ratio, you know, because why do you go to university? Well, to get educated, but partly when you're 18, you go to university to meet a mate.
- 8.88 And it's pretty damn slim pickings for the women at the typical university now, because it's two women for every man. Man, that's of great advantage to the predatory men, by the way. Right, because what happens to the women, it's so awful because they're **hypergamous**. Even though you'd think the men who are terribly outnumbered would now have an opportunity on the mating front, what actually happens is the successful men have hyper opportunities, and so they're very likely.
- 8.89 So the women are chasing a small pool of successful men at the universities, and the hyper-successful men have a huge choice of women. And so the women don't have an opportunity for stable long-term relationships. And the men get to be trained to be exploitative **psychopaths**. So that seems like a very bad long-term solution. God only knows what that's going to do on the university side. You know, we really have no idea because it's never happened before. Right, but the men are bailing out of higher education in droves, and so. Well, we'll see what happens over the next 20 years. No one really knows.
- 8.90 OK, so let's relate the personality traits to what else we learned. And then we'll draw this to a close. You can take **extraversion** and **openness**. They make a meta trait, because they're slightly correlated, called **plasticity**. Highly plastic people, extroverted and open, are very entrepreneurial and they're also very exploratory. So their basic mode of adaptation in the world is the exploratory mode. Right, and the other three traits, emotional stability, reverse of **neuroticism**, OK, so resilience to negative emotion, **agreeableness**, and **conscientiousness**, they clump.
- 8.91 Stability. And so the adaptive advantage to people who are high in stability is they're conscientious. So they work hard. That's a good predictor of success. They're emotionally stable. So they don't suffer much. They're agreeable enough to get well along with others. So they're well integrated into their social communities. And that's sort of their niche. Right, the entrepreneurs are pulled out of the **plasticity** class, and the more conservative managerial and administrative types that keep the show on the road when everything's going well, they're high in **plasticity**.
- 8.92 And you can see that both of those approaches would have their advantage and that they're both desirable. I mean, I don't know if you, if you could probably pick a single personality trait

out of the hat that would most make you happy, you'd pick low **neuroticism**, because when people say they want to be happy, but when you analyze that, you find out that's not true. What they really mean is they don't want to be miserable. Extroverts are happy. People high in **neuroticism** are miserable.

- 8.93** When people say, I just want to be happy, they mean, I wish I wasn't anxious, I wish I wasn't in pain, I wish I wasn't angry and frustrated and disappointed and grief-stricken. That's really what we want, is cessation of negative emotion, more than thrilled **enthusiasm**. And so your life is a lot less burdensome if you're low in **neuroticism**.
- 8.94** Now, you might be less sensitive to danger. And, you know, you can see that as a problem. You know, there's something about being on edge. You're going to see danger when it appears. That's kind of the curse that women live with. But it's hard on you, existentially. Open people are creative. Extroverts are gregarious. Agreeable people are cooperative. Disagreeable people are competitive. Open people are creative. Those are all niches. There's a place for everyone.
- 8.95** One of the way of thinking about the world that's positive, I would say, in regard to this, is that there's a lot of ways of being in the world, and these personality traits are emblematic of different ways of being in the world. Creativity is a high return, high risk game. You can be very successful creatively, hyper successful, but the probability of failure is extremely high. Most people aren't entrepreneurial. One person in 50 wants to start their own business, and you hear "everyone's creative." It's like, that is not true.
- 8.96** We did research, creative achievement questionnaire, assessed long-term lifetime creativity across 13 different dimensions, eight levels of creativity in each dimension. Literary. You've written an article for your local newspaper, right? That'd be like level one. Zero would be, I have no talent or training in this area. One would be, I've written an article that was published in a local newspaper or online. Level 8 would be, I have multiple international bestsellers aggregated across 13 domains. 70% of people score zero, right? The next most common score is 1, right.
- 8.97** **Pareto distribution**. Almost everyone stacks up at zero. There's a number of outliers way out at the tail who have scores of, like, you know, 100, right. 30 bestsellers, multiple patents. Maybe they're composers, maybe they're architects, right. Creativity is very rare. But if you're, so that's an expression of **openness**, intelligence. If you're hyper creative, you're hyper successful. But mostly you'll fail. So what's the point?
- 8.98** There's lots of different ways of being in the world. There's five different niches that are associated with the traits. Each of those niches allows people to play a game that they could be successful at. A well-structured society produces a diverse range of games, so that every person and every temperament in principle has a role to play. It's harder with the people who are low in **conscientiousness**, low in **agreeableness**, and high in **neuroticism**. Right.
- 8.99** OK, let's close with the **Dark Tetrad**. When psychologists put together the list of adjectives from which they derived the statistical models, they noticed that if they put in evaluative terms, like good or evil or good and bad, cruel or kind, that you got two dimensions, good and bad. And

they knew there were more differentiated approaches to personality than good and bad, so they took out all the evaluative words. Then they got the five-dimensional structure that we described, that broke down into the 10 aspects.

- 8.100** Unfortunately, they lost some real information by getting rid of the evaluative adjectives, and they've snuck back into the literature that attenuated the relationship between personality and psychopathology. Because personality traits aren't a great predictor of mental disorder. They're not too bad, but they're not great, partly because we got rid of the evaluative terms. Investigators into the **Dark Tetrad** of traits have re-investigated the evaluative terms.
- 8.101** **Dark Tetrad** types, we talked a little bit about. This is the dark end of the personality spectrum. They're **narcissistic**. Personality-wise, that makes them extroverted and disagreeable. They're **narcissistic**. They want unearned social status. They're **Machiavellian**. That means they use their words to manipulate others, right? They're **psychopathic**. That means they're predatory. What's yours is mine, and parasitical— if I can get you to work for me, I will. Pimps are parasites, right? Criminals are parasites. Criminal pimps are parasitic predators.
- 8.102** **Psychopathic**. A **psychopathic** person has no concern for you. You're a field of opportunity. And if you're agreeable, you're amenable to their machinations. That was the **Dark Triad**. That was studied by students of Robert Hare, who was the first person who mapped **psychopathy** in prison populations. Further investigation showed that if you were predatory and you were **narcissistic** and you were **Machiavellian**, so lots of fun to be around, you're also **sadistic**. You took positive delight in the suffering of others, and the behavior of the **Dark Tetrad** types is increasingly well understood.
- 8.103** 3% of the population, almost all the online anonymous trolls who are poisoning the public discourse are **Dark Tetrad** types, right? They're a minority of the population. But now and then they get the upper hand. They get the upper hand after idiot ideological revolutions, for example. And when that happens, there's blood in the streets, because the evolutionary niche for a **Dark Tetrad** manipulator is free sexual access with no responsibility. And the more **chaos** you can produce, the more likely that outcome.
- 8.104** There's a strange pattern of male sexuality that's not much discussed. Most human sexuality is private. Rape during wartime is very common. In fact, it's common enough so you can track its consequences in human genealogy across the evolutionary line. When all hell breaks loose, the short-term maters rise to the top, right, and so they're motivated to spread **chaos**, because under normal circumstances, they're not very attractive to discerning women. So what they want is as much bloody mayhem and **chaos** as can possibly be managed, because that's their opportunity.
- 8.105** And that's actually what seems to be something approximating a stable evolutionary niche. The stability of **psychopathy** is about 3%, 3 to 5. What seems to happen if there's fewer than 3% **psychopaths**, everybody forgets that they exist and they sort of go to sleep. And so then a **psychopath** can arise, and no one notices, and they can be quite successful. But if they get above

5%, everybody thinks, oh, there's a lot of psychopaths around here, and they wake up and take whatever measures are necessary to stop it from happening, and that seems to keep them at about that level.

- 8.106 And so anyways, who are the psychopathic predators? Well, they're the immature. They're immature people who retain the aggression that was part of their temperament when they were young. That's the easiest explanation, right? And why are they callous? Well, the typical two-year-old really doesn't have much appreciation for anyone else. There's the basics of the beginning of empathy, but an unsocialized person is basically out for themselves, and some unsocialized people are also aggressive, and those are the ones that, if they're not socialized, well, they turn into the Dark Tetrad types that destabilize themselves and everyone else. So another thing that is worth being alert to, on the personality side, if you're wise, is that people like that exist. And so keep your eyes open.
- 8.107 All right. That's probably good enough. Where did we wander? Well, we talked about shamanistic and religious approaches to personality, right. Showing that there's a universal pathway of development that's associated with heroic descent and ascent. We showed how that was mapped and replicated in the psychoanalytic tradition, and how the stories that, and the dreams and the fantasies that the psychoanalysts analyzed reflected that.
- 8.108 We talked about the existential, phenomenological, and humanistic traditions, the idea of the integrated personality, integrated socially, the idea that that integration was a function of the removal of internal and social contradictions and something like an upward climb, and that there's a motivational pathway that marks out that climb. We talked about the instantiation of those patterns of adaptation in physiology and their reflection in the psychometric literature. And that's a pretty good survey of the domain of personal, personality inquiry and a reasonable approximation of something like a unified theory.
- 8.109 And with any luck, it was, what would you say? Interesting at the level of abstract conceptualization, interesting in relationship to the understanding of psychopathology and the clinical endeavor, and useful practically, since we're all personalities and we all have to deal with them. And so thank you very much, for your time and attention. Thank you. Very nice to be here with you all.